



VAISHNAVI
PATEL

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AUTHOR OF
KAIKEYI

WE
DANCE
UPON
DEMONS

A NOVEL

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WE DANCE UPON DEMONS

A Novel

Vaishnavi Patel

SAGA  **PRESS**

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To James Barrett, John Britton, David Gunn, Shannon Lowney, Jennifer Markovsky, Leanne Nichols, Robert Sanderson, Barnett Slepian, Ke'Arre Stewart, Garrett Swasey, and George Tiller, and to all those who risk their safety to ensure access to reproductive care.



1
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FORTY DAYS

Depression feels a lot like drowning.

I know everyone says that: Depression is a tar pit, depression is a weight, depression is like drowning. I should clarify that depression feels a lot like drowning—in calm, shallow water when you're a strong swimmer. My body knows what to do. It strains and strains to reach the surface. But my brain refuses to send the right signals. My brain won't do anything at all. It's a fucking traitor.

But then, because it's shallow water, my feet hit the ground and muscle memory kicks in. I push off the ocean floor. I surface, coughing up water. I think, *Thank gods that's over*. I take a stroke toward solid ground, an impossible distance away. I am pulled under again.

Perhaps that's a dramatic excuse for why I'm chronically late for work. On the rare days I actually roll in at nine a.m., people pretend to be shocked. I'm sure there are plenty of Indian Standard Time jokes made at my expense. It's fine with me. I'd rather that than have them know the truth: after a night of hardly sleeping, once I've bypassed the nightmares to wake up with the sun, I lie in bed, paralyzed by the thought of sitting up. Of getting dressed. Of brushing my teeth. But once my bladder gets too full, my feet hit the ground, and the momentum carries me forward. I eat a piece of toast. I walk to the Red Line station. Thankfully, my place of work comes with my own personal depression filter—

protesters. Something about getting screamed at and called a baby-murderer fills me with just enough annoyance to power through the rest of the day.

Today I exit the train around nine thirty a.m. Even though I'm late, I pop into one of the Indian grocery stores to grab a chai from an uncle I know.

"Running late, dear?" he asks, and I give a little shrug.

I know him well enough to understand that it's concern, not judgment. I'm already tardy, so why not grab an extra energy boost? It's a Wednesday, which is usually quiet at the clinic, since we don't have surgical abortions scheduled, and I'm hopeful I won't be the only one getting in late. But as I get closer, I hear a swell of people who are trying and failing to be quiet. *It can't be*. I scramble to look at the date on my phone, and sure enough, it's Ash Wednesday. Or, for those who find perverse joy in harassing women and want to impose their religious beliefs on the rest of the country, the start of Forty Days for "Life." In the forty-six days between Ash Wednesday and Easter Sunday, extra protesters haunt the clinic Monday through Saturday—Forty Days of Hell.

Every year, Forty Days sounds the death knell for clinics like ours. It's Forty Days of scaring patients, threatening newer providers, and turning community members against each other. In my culture, after a baby is born, the mother and child stay at home for forty days, sheltered from the outside world. So I always envision this period similarly, as our clinic's time to hunker down until it's safe again. A yearly rebirth. I'm sure the protesters would hate this idea, given the significance of Lent.

I pick up the pace after I spot a regular, Steve, standing on the corner and holding a gory dead baby sign. "Stop Calling Child Sacrifice 'Choice,'" the sign reads, above a picture of a chopped-up, toddler-sized "fetus" smeared with blood. It's not like scientific accuracy matters to these people, but still, you have to wonder how many hours he spent on Photoshop to make this monstrosity.

"Go not into the house of death!" Steve shouts into his megaphone. "The worshippers of Satan have powers you know not! Death follows!" I lift my chin and give him a little wave. "Oh, it's you."

His comic disappointment is only heightened by the way his words bounce from his megaphone. I resist the urge to laugh. Steve loves his house-of-death spiel. He teaches high school physics, but he is tenured and so senior that he's

been able to engineer his schedule to keep his mornings free to harass women all around the city—sometimes his own students! He’s also a card-carrying member of the Midwest Family Institute, and through it, he’s helped get his own queer colleagues fired. At least Steve is a known quantity. As I pass him, I see what looks like a veritable horde of protesters amassed on the sidewalk in front of the clinic. They’re not blocking the turn into our parking lot, but they are dangerously close. Some are kneeling and praying the rosary. Others are holding their own signs: “God Loves You, Mommy!” “We Will Help You!” As I turn into the drive, they start shouting at me.

“Choose adoption!”

“Your baby should have a choice, too!”

“Don’t be a killer!”

“These clinics kill Black babies!”

Ugh, that one’s particularly disgusting. I scan the crowd, which is pretty much all white, but fail to identify the commenter.

“At least take a leaflet,” someone else says while shoving a piece of glossy paper with a smiling baby into my hands. “You have other options.”

I turn my eyes to the ground and keep walking. Someone rushes in front of me. FACE Act violation! Not that it matters. I wouldn’t rely on the police for help even if there was an active shooter, and the current administration’s Department of Justice would probably prosecute us if we tried to report a breach of the Freedom of Access to Clinic Entrances Act. I try to sidestep the protester, and they grab my wrist. I firmly shake them off, but I’ve been encircled. How many patients have had to run this gauntlet today? There’s nothing I can do, since I’m not interested in losing any teeth. I pull out my phone and start recording, capturing the faces of everyone around me just in case.

“We’re just trying to help you!” a woman says in a voice I’m sure she thinks is compassionate. “If you go in there, they’ll try to trick you. They’ll lie and say we’re the bad guys. But really, we’re pro-women. Half of all fetuses are girls!”

There is one thing the antis and I agree on—there are good guys and bad guys—though obviously we disagree on which is which. Seeing what I do every day, it’s impossible not to sort the world this way. It’s the division that keeps me sane.

There are no clinic escorts outside, but usually Diane keeps an eye on the situation to help if things get serious. I'm not sure identifying myself as an employee is the best way to get myself safely inside, so I just try to edge my way toward the entrance. The crowd moves with me, never mind that they're trespassing on private property.

"Please, mommy, don't go in," a serious voice says. I gag internally. "Your baby wants to live!"

I think about what Aai would say to me, what she *has* said to me whenever I've told her that I want to give up. *If Durga could defeat Mahishasura and Kali could consume Raktabija and Satyabhama could defeat Narakasura, you can survive this ten seconds longer. Our women are strong. Ten seconds more. Ten seconds more. And then, I didn't raise a quitter.*

The door to the clinic swings open and Diane marches out with her bullhorn. "Get off the property, now!" The crowd almost immediately disperses, and I hold up my phone to try to get a picture of the whole group. It could be helpful to track repeat offenders. Diane turns to me. "You okay?"

"Has it been this way all morning?" I ask, not wanting to answer her question with the truth, that I almost had a panic attack.

She nods. "I prepared myself, but I didn't think it would be this intense."

"They must be coming from Indiana or somewhere else where there aren't any clinics left to protest."

If I'm right and we're going to be hosting this volume of antis for the next Forty Days of Hell, I'm going to need to draw up a daily escort schedule—and fast. We'll need to onboard new volunteers. I'll pick up more shifts. There's so much to do, but at least now I'm motivated to get it done. I pull out my employee badge and scan into the building, hearing a collective groan behind me. It's almost enough to make me smile. Instead, a wave of despair overtakes me. There's a seed of doubt blooming in my brain as I think about the wall of faces wishing me bodily harm. My heart beats faster, and I realize that at last I'm feeling an emotion. Fear.



2
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ART IMITATES LIFE

I'm halfway to my office when Diane calls after me, "Nisha, I almost forgot! We have a new doctor starting today."

We only have one provider, who also maintains a practice at Rush Medical Center for her long-term patients. "New doctor?" I ask. "What happened to Dr. Levy?"

"Dr. Levy's new resident," Diane says with a wink.

"It's February," I point out. "Don't they switch in the summer?"

"New rotation," Dr. Levy says, emerging from the clinical wing. "The last one wasn't interested in sticking around when her time was up. But my new resident has a passion for providing abortion care."

She holds open the door, and my heart stops. I have to protect the patients.

"This is Dr. Robinson," Dr. Levy says, still smiling, as I lunge forward.

Aaron's eyes widen as he sees me leaping toward him, and he hastily steps back. The door swings shut and I slam into it. I would be embarrassed, if Aaron fucking Robinson wasn't now inside the clinical wing unsupervised. I turn to Dr. Levy and Diane, who are staring at me like I've lost my tenuous hold on reality.

"I know we don't usually call the police," I say, keeping my voice quiet. There are two patients in the waiting room, and I don't want to scare them. "But we might have to if he doesn't surrender himself."

“Surrender himself?” Dr. Levy echoes. “Nisha, are you feeling all right?”

My hands are shaking. “Dr. Levy, this might be hard to believe, but Aaron Robinson is an anti. A *vehement*, protest-outside-the-clinic kind of anti. Would you be comfortable going after him to make sure he’s not sabotaging our equipment?”

Aaron slowly pushes the door back open. His face is flushed a deep red. “I promise I’m not sabotaging your equipment.” He steps into the waiting room, and Diane gestures us over to the welcome desk.

“So who’s going to explain?” Dr. Levy asks. Her bullshit tolerance is about on par with Aai’s, and I can tell this drama has used up all her patience for the day.

I cross my arms and look at Aaron. “Perhaps this pitiful excuse for a human being?”

Aaron winces. “Nisha, I’m so sorry.”

“For infiltrating the abortion clinic I work at? Not sure ‘sorry’ is the right word.”

“I didn’t—I’m not infiltrating your clinic. I’m here to work. I’m an OB-GYN resident, and I requested a placement here. I didn’t know you would be here too.” His voice is so sincere, it might have even worked on someone else.

“Dr. Robinson, what is your view on abortion?” Diane asks.

“I’m pro-choice,” Aaron says with confidence. I snort so hard, my nostrils hurt. “I wasn’t always. I was raised in a very conservative rural environment. I protested outside a clinic—once—during my last year of college because someone from high school invited me. And it was... horrible. The experience changed my life. Every person should have the right to choose what they do with their bodies, and I want to help however I can.”

“And,” Dr. Levy adds, “he wrote all this in a very compelling personal statement. And repeated it during a truly touching interview. It’s not a secret.”

“He’s a liar,” I snarl. His words aren’t an apology, they’re a recitation. It’s almost like I’m having an out-of-body experience, except I can very clearly feel the sweat pooled under my arms, the runaway heartbeat in my chest. I can smell that he still wears the same deodorant. “I would know.”

“Would you?” Aaron asks. “Name a single time I lied to you.”

My eyes snap up to meet his, and I regret it. The nerve of this asshole, trying to be familiar. “I don’t think you want that.”

Dr. Levy looks at the two of us. “Although I appreciate your concern, Nisha, you’re going to have to trust me on this. Dr. Robinson is going to be heavily supervised. So far, he’s done an admirable job. So you are both free to resolve this *interpersonal conflict* after our patients have been seen.”

She leaves me and Aaron standing behind the desk, with Diane trying to make herself invisible in her rolling chair. Aaron opens his mouth to say something, but Dr. Levy clears her throat and he dashes behind her. I sag, all the energy flooding out of me in a rush.

“What was that?” Diane asks. “Who are you, and what have you done with Nisha?”

“I was worried he was a threat to the patients,” I say, not quite turning to face her. I feel cold, shaky.

“You walk past people threatening to firebomb the clinic every day and turn the other cheek,” Diane says. “That was something else. I’ve never seen you that worked up.”

I swallow. She’s right. For all the years I’ve worked here, I’ve maintained a veneer of calm. But this anger isn’t unfamiliar to me; it’s always been there, just under the surface. “That’s because you can’t see inside my mind.”

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Diane decides to meddle and texts my supervisor, who insists that I take a few hours off to “center myself.” Not that he knows much about me as a remote project manager, but I think Diane is worried that I’m on the verge of a breakdown, which, maybe I am.

I pass back through the protester gauntlet, get on the Red Line, and before I know it, I’m in front of the greening lions of the Art Institute. This museum has always felt safe, and I can’t deny that it’s especially on my mind because Aaron and I came here on our first date. I text Diane that I’ve gone downtown and I’ll be back in two hours, then grab my ticket and go directly up the steps, across the second floor, and back down the rear landing to stare at Georgia O’Keeffe’s *Sky*

Above Clouds IV. I remember coming here as a kid and being bored to death by it, wondering why it occupied such a place of pride at the Art Institute. But now, I feel like the painting sees me just as I see it. It is too vast, too deep, too much. The clouds don't quite fit inside the frame, jostling for room in the composition. There's a haze of clear sky in the distance, too blurry to make out. The depth of sadness is endless. If I turn my head just so, I can see the border of the art. But when I do, I cannot see the full picture. Something is always lost.

A voice in my head that sounds suspiciously like Aai says, *Get some distance*, but my feet are rooted to the ground. Eventually, I close my eyes and the imprint of the clouds floats before them. I shake my head and decide to wander through the impressionism exhibit.

If you are someone to whom impressionism speaks, you can feel it when you look at each painting. The naked, ephemeral unfilteredness, the dappling of light and dark, the way that no image is quite right. Wonder and pain. Hope and confusion. It's almost enough to make you believe in magic. The placard introducing the exhibit explains that these works were produced during a time when rapid industrialization and urbanization dramatically changed economic and family structures. These artists tried to capture hope and the continuation of daily life, even among that bleakness. Some went mad. Some made beautiful and transcendent works of art. Some did both. I know absolutely nothing about living during the late nineteenth century and yet tears prick the corners of my eyes when I stare at the blue-green-purple of these skies. In the quiet wonder of the room, surrounded by grief, I find myself smiling. These paintings are proof that perseverance is possible, that pain can be transformed into the sublime. I have not yet learned that alchemy. I may never remember how to swim to the surface of my mind again. But it is possible. Someone has done it.

My break is almost up, and at last I leave the impressionists behind to pay a quick visit to the South Asian art section. As much as I love the sculptures, I can only look at them for so long before I start thinking about the mass lootings that helped fill the gallery. But today, the exhibit is in a state of disarray. Some of the protective cases are missing, and it seems like pieces are being moved around. I've never seen this before, but I've never been here in the middle of the workday. I make my way through the sculptures, pausing briefly to look at one of Krishna

defeating Kaliya, before allowing myself to be pulled toward my favorite statue of Nataraja. Shiva's avatar, the Lord of Dance. I used to love assuming the pose when I practiced Kathak, one knee bent, the other foot raised over the knee, arms outstretched, one hand flexed up and one down. Even though it was a static pose, it felt so dynamic. My teacher kept a beautiful gold-colored Nataraja statue in the corner of our dance space, and I have a small murti in my apartment, but I've always loved this Nataraja at the Art Institute best. You can clearly see Ganga flowing from his hair, the damaru keeping time, and the demon of ignorance's near-comical expression of woe as he's trampled underfoot. Perhaps it's the history embedded in this version—a sculpture over a thousand years old just *feels* different, like it could spring to life at any moment, whirling hair snapping around, raised foot landing on the demon's head, and all the world being destroyed by the awesome wonder of it.

I realize from about ten feet away that the Nataraja statue is also missing its glass case. I inch closer, until I'm near enough to brush my fingers against the cool metal if I wanted to. Instead, I pull out my phone to take a quick picture of the statue in all its unfiltered glory before leaning forward, hands on knees, to peer at it closely. My eyes are drawn to Apasmara, the demon of ignorance—he really does look like he's moving. Suddenly I'm too hot, even though the Art Institute is always uncomfortably cool.

The statue seems to be beckoning me. My hand reaches out of its own volition toward the statue. One of my fingers touches Lord Nataraja's upturned hand, and I feel a sharp sting. I immediately pull away and see a spot of blood on my finger. The wound looks pretty deep. *I just defiled a priceless piece of art with my blood.* I whirl around to see if anyone saw, but everyone is busy with their own work. I take a step back. Something's wrong. I've never been one to get lightheaded at the sight of blood—so why—my knees buckle. Everything goes dark.



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OLD FRIENDS

When I return to awareness, my body freezes. Memory comes flooding back: I collapsed, I'm on the floor, and something is very, very wrong in my body. But, as one of my therapists once told me to remember when I feel this way, my lungs are still breathing. My heart is still beating. I may be stuck in a rut forever, but hey, at least I survived the accident that nearly killed me and now I get to walk around with the debilitating fear that it could happen again! Needless to say, I stopped going to therapy. Two breaths later, I take account of my surroundings. There are no paramedics, no shouting or beeping or prodding, just hushed, urgent voices. I prepare myself to stand and assure everyone that I'm fine. A cool hand touches my shoulder, and I flinch back, eyes flying open to meet the gaze of a light-skinned Indian man looking down at me with concern.

"Are you okay?" he whispers. Something about him screams *wrong*.

"I'm fine." I see people gathered behind him. "I'm fine," I repeat louder.

The man follows my gaze, and then says, "She's fine." The people crowded around me immediately drift away. If I wasn't so discombobulated, I would roll my eyes.

"Thanks," I say.

He doesn't seem to hear me. Then, without warning, he grabs my hand and studies it. "Did you touch it? How—what did you do?"

I snatch my hand back. *Fuck*. "I don't know what you're talking about."

He narrows his eyes at me, then offers me a smile. “Right. Of course not.”

“Thank you for your concern,” I add, because I’m still feeling shaky and this man does not seem inclined to leave me alone.

“Should we... find you something to eat?”

Though his tone remains polite and friendly, I balk. I’m in a public place and could certainly scream if I needed to, but I don’t want the drama of a confrontation.

“I’m sorry, sir, but I’m not interested.”

His brows draw together in confusion and he recoils, looking almost a bit disgusted. “Of course not—I’m old enough to be your gr—” He stops himself as a flash of panic crosses his face. “Forget I said that.”

He says it like a command, and I can’t help but laugh. Despite his oddness, some of the tension has started to leave my body. “I’ll do my best,” I say, pushing myself to my feet. When he doesn’t respond, I add, “Have a good day, grandpa.”

“How do you remember—”

“Nisha!” It’s unmistakably Aaron.

“Nice to meet you, Nisha. We’ll catch up later,” the man says, and then strolls away before I can say another word.

I don’t have time to process how bizarre and off-putting that conversation was, because Aaron is running up to me.

“What are you doing here?” The words sound harsh and angry, but I don’t regret them.

“It’s my lunch break. Dr. Levy told me to come resolve our issues.”

“And you came to the Art Institute?” Something’s buzzing under my skin, changing me.

“Diane said you were headed downtown. I thought I’d find you here.” He’s sincere, which makes it worse.

“So you’re a stalker.”

“I wanted to apologize. I didn’t know you worked here, or I would have said something, given you a heads-up. Apologized for what happened. Cleared the air before we became coworkers.” His shoulders hunch, and he becomes smaller. He always did that when we argued, an unconscious response to my anger. It used to be a warning that I was getting too worked up, back when I cared.

“We’re not coworkers,” I say. “Because you’re going to leave this position. I’m not letting you—”

“Nisha,” he interrupts softly. I hate that he knows better than to let me get into gear. “I’m sorry that I made assumptions. I’m sorry I didn’t return your texts. And most of all, I’m sorry for what I did. Protesting an abortion clinic—what I did disgusts me now. And I know I was old enough to know better. When I saw you there... it changed everything for me. I talked to a lot of people, read and researched.”

“Oh, good,” I say. “You read a *Jezebel* article and now you’re cured?”

“Jezebel?” Aaron asks, face scrunching in confusion. “No, I...”

“Never mind. Just—why are you here?”

“I’m doing this all wrong,” Aaron says. “I should have started by telling you how sorry I am. I didn’t mean to disrupt your life. I want to do this work. It’s important to me. You don’t have to forgive me, but I hope you can believe me.” I look at my hands, because I don’t know what to say. For all my claims at the clinic, Aaron never actually lied to me. He misled me about his true beliefs—or maybe I just assumed and never asked. Maybe it was my fault, too. I fiddle with my fingers, trying to stave off the overthinking, when I realize my pricked finger is healed, unblemished. I rub my fingers together, willing my brain to work, but I’m too slow to figure it out. “You know, I think it’s very brave of you to work at a clinic after everything—”

“What the hell do you mean, ‘after everything’?” I snap, and Aaron flinches. Some small part of me feels ashamed.

Aaron looks at his shoes, his throat bobbing for a moment before he speaks. “I... set up a Google Alert for your name. It made local news. It must be hard to go into a clinic every day. Any person would have trauma—”

“Shut up!” I hiss. His mouth clamps shut. I hate his judgment and his pitying glances. The fact that he set up a Google Alert for me is, after a moment of reflection, pretty sinister. That’s the kind of behavior a stalker exhibits right before kidnapping you and chaining you up in their basement. “You know nothing about me. It’s been years. We’re not friends. You’re a fucking stalker.”

Aaron’s eyes widen in a pitiful display of hurt. But I remember the way his eyes used to narrow when we argued, as though trying to fight back tears I never

saw him shed. I'm right that there's something off about him, right to suspect him. I wish I felt more satisfaction.

"I didn't..." Aaron trails off just as his phone buzzes. "Shit. Dr. Levy gave me ninety minutes, and I only have thirty left. I'm sorry to leave things this way, but I have to go catch a cab."

I roll my eyes before I can stop myself. I almost say, *Take an Uber, Luddite*, but then I remember Aaron broke up with me because he thought I was having an abortion. He ghosted me without even asking a single question. I remember what happened after. So I say nothing instead. Aaron flashes me his half smile. That hasn't changed one bit. Then he's gone, and I'm left with a maelstrom of thoughts. I take a deep breath and count by seven to ground myself. My cut is healed. My skin is buzzing. I feel as though I have forgotten something. It's on the tip of my tongue, but I can't reach it. The feeling is overwhelming. I can feel my mind shutting down, closing off. I should probably go back to work, but my brain is resisting movement or action. I can't stand hunched over in the Art Institute all day, though. I know how to deal with this: small steps. Once I start moving, I'll be able to keep going.

I manage to coax myself into turning back toward the Nataraja. I had thought myself alone, but the weird man from before is standing in the corner, glaring at Aaron's retreating back. Was he listening in? When he catches me looking at him, he just walks away, the bewildering cherry on top of this batshit sundae. I watch him go, dumbfounded. A small tremor runs through me. There's too much going on to make sense of it all. Aaron, the statue, the cut, that man. I should be searching for answers, but I let my body put itself on autopilot, and head back to work.

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It's a good thing our actual social worker is in, because apparently today's been a doozy. We have her three days a week—primarily on surgical abortion days—but our patients regularly need help getting connected to shelters, crisis counselors, food banks, and other resources even when they're coming in for medication abortions or other services. When she's not there, it falls to me to pick up the

slack, since working at a struggling independent clinic means wearing every single possible hat. I was brought on to manage volunteers and community outreach, so I guess it's not that much of a stretch beyond my job description. I've been told that I'm very even-keeled, which is a kind way of describing the blankness that I can't seem to penetrate, but I think it must also help that I look like some of our patients. Or, I should say, I used to look like our patients. Since abortion was outlawed in most of the states surrounding Illinois, we now regularly see white Southern women who have the money to travel here to pick up their mifepristone and misoprostol. I don't begrudge them that, and many make sizable donations to our travel fund so that pregnant people with less can make it here too. But some of them clearly voted against the right to abortion, and they look on their fellow waiting-room denizens with open disgust.

Anyway, according to Diane, today one of the travelers started going off on a young Indian patient about how her generation was disgusting and irresponsible, causing a verbal—and very nearly physical—altercation. Something about the crop top the young woman was wearing. Diane is almost laughing retelling the story, so I know it can't have been that bad—the increase in protesters just has everyone riled up.

“Are you sure you're all right?” Diane asks.

“As all right as I ever am,” I say, the response rolling right off my tongue.

“Not reassuring,” Diane says. She's obviously teasing, since none of my coworkers actually suspect there's anything going on beneath my placid surface. Still, it makes me wonder if I've been messing up, making work about me instead of the patients. “You have a volunteer interview in fifteen minutes, according to the anticipated guest list. I'll walk her over when it's time.”

I had completely forgotten and race to my desk so I can prepare. We can't afford to turn away volunteers, but the antis are always trying to infiltrate abortion clinics, lacking anything better to do with their time. I do a quick search of the applicant, Julie, and find very little. There's a LinkedIn profile that doesn't look brand-new, but it's fairly sparse. We went to the same undergrad, but the picture is too pixelated to see if I recognize her. She doesn't have a Facebook, but what under-twenty-five does anymore? Her Instagram is private, but the picture seems to match the LinkedIn. I'm at least reassured that she's a

real person. The sound of voices travels down the hall and I rapidly click to a new tab so Julie doesn't catch me internet-stalking her.

"Oh my goodness," JJ says, stepping into my office. "Nisha?"

I'm out of my seat immediately. "JJ?"

We hug, tight and close, and I feel my body relax for what feels like the first time all day.

"I didn't know you worked here. It's been forever since we talked, hasn't it?"

"Not since graduation, I think," I say. "I thought you were moving to... Paris?"

JJ shrugs. "You know how it is. Bad breakup, and boom, back to my family's ancestral stomping grounds."

Blue-eyed, blond-haired JJ is not Ojibwe or Potawatomi—her family came here from Germany a couple hundred years ago. From what I've heard, they're old-money Chicagoans, so I never corrected her favorite saying then, and I don't now.

"It is so good to see you." We were friends in college but didn't keep in touch—not odd, since I lost touch with pretty much all my college friends, time and distance doing their work. I feel so exhausted most days that it's all I can do to feed myself, let alone maintain relationships, but JJ doesn't know that. It's a clean slate.

"You too! So you work here now? That's so admirable. I always thought you would do something big. Something amazing." Her words hurt, although she doesn't mean them to. I wanted to do something big, something amazing. I wanted to change the world. Now I'm twenty-six, and I know the world can't be changed. At least not by someone like me.

"Yeah. I've been doing this type of work since graduation, and I've been here about three years. I run the volunteer program, outreach and education, and some community relations and patient resource connections."

"That's a lot," JJ says with a slight frown. She looks worried about me, and I almost want to hug her again. "But you're supersmart, so I'm sure you do it well!"

"I enjoy the work, especially today... Julie." I flash her a smile. "I forgot that was your full name, to be honest."

“It’s so weird, isn’t it? You live across the hall from someone and you share everything, your whole life story, but you forget things like sharing your full name. Back then, I used my middle name instead of my last name because I hated my dad, but we’ve made up.” She gives a little shrug.

“So, Julie Perkins, huh?” I ask, lifting my printout of her application.

“That’s me!”

“I have to ask you a couple questions, but between us, it’s just a formality. There’s no need for you to tell me about yourself. Although, out of curiosity, what are you up to now? Any time constraints we should be aware of?”

“Just working for the family business,” JJ says, gesturing vaguely. “I barely understand it. Super boring, but no weird timing constraints. In fact, since I’m working for my dad, I can probably get out earlier or go in later if you need people at a certain time.”

Flexibility landing in my lap at the beginning of Forty Days is such a blessing. If JJ can take off a couple of mornings a week, a lot of our problems might be solved. “That’s awesome, really. We need that.”

“Yeah, I saw the situation out front,” she says, with a sympathetic grimace.

“There are plenty of volunteer opportunities out there,” I say, but I smile so she knows it’s not a criticism. “Why Rogers Park Health Center?”

“Women have a right to choose. There shouldn’t be some group of rich men deciding what happens to women.” Her voice is sure, confident. I see the me of a few years ago, before the endless monotony of fighting for basic rights wore me down.

I nod. “Obviously this clinic performs abortions. I know you basically just answered this question, but we have to ask as a matter of course. Are you comfortable volunteering for a clinic that performs abortions and helping patients who are seeking abortions?” Behind JJ, there’s a flicker of movement outside, in the parking lot. For a moment, I think I see the man from the Art Institute. Then I blink and he’s gone. JJ’s looking at me expectantly. I didn’t hear her answer, and part of me wants to let it slide. But we have the policy for a reason, even if I’m about to look like a massive idiot. “Sorry, I didn’t hear you. I thought I saw something outside.”

“No worries,” she says. “I was saying it’s fine by me. As you know, that’s why I’m here!”

“Great.” I make a note to myself in our volunteer evaluation form, just to make sure everything is properly squared away. I don’t want to get in trouble for cutting corners for my friends. After Aaron, JJ is a breath of fresh air—good people are in short supply. “Do you have any questions for me?”

“When can I start?”

I give her a genuine grin, remembering the enthusiasm for life that JJ always had. “We have a group training this weekend, and you can start picking up shifts once you’ve finished.”

She reaches for her purse and stands up. “And when can I see you?”

“Let’s go out for hot chocolate after the training,” I say. “The forecast says snow.”

Once she’s gone, I collapse onto my desk. Between Aaron and JJ and whatever happened at the Art Institute, today has been too much for me. My body is stretching, remembering something long forgotten—but I don’t know what. It’s warm, familiar. Almost like a dance.



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STRANGER DANGER

Self-loathing dogs me through the next day, along with a wave of guilt at my lack of preparation. I have so much to do—finding and vetting new volunteers, responding to outreach opportunities for our clinic, and reaching out to some of my acquaintances at other clinics to see if they’re experiencing an increase in protest activity. I’m always worried that ICE will show up to detain our patients, or that we’re going to be falsely accused of a crime and the police will raid us, or that someone will bomb us, or that the antis will send in a fake patient to sabotage us so that we lose our licenses. Perhaps it’s paranoia, but all these things have happened to other clinics. By the end of the day, I’ve successfully gotten two inactive volunteers to commit to shifts and confirmed a tabling opportunity at a big Holi expo three weeks away, but I’ve gotten no bites on my social media posts looking for new volunteers and a couple of the other clinics have confirmed that the intensity of protest activity is unique to us. Some special hell.

On the train back to my apartment, down in Near South Side, I scroll on my phone. My feed knows me and knows what I’m interested in, but unfortunately, updates on the body autonomy space tend to be doom and gloom.

I’ve been a reproductive justice lawyer for thirty years, and here’s why I’m worried about the Comstock Act, one post reads. Of course I click. I have some basic knowledge about the Comstock Act—something about not mailing obscene materials in the postal service—because it’s been referenced in the past

in relation to being able to mail abortion pills. But this woman, who I follow because of her legal expertise and who has yet to lead me astray, explains that the problem with the Comstock Act, beyond the obvious, is that it redefines obscenity to include objects, not just speech. Birth control pills could be an obscenity under the Act. *Look around you*, she writes. *Do you own anything that didn't enter the mail system at some point? Do you take any drugs that weren't shipped to you or to the store?*

It sends a shiver down my spine just thinking about it. I remember being in college, and the student health doctor chuckling and commenting, “Good on you” when I asked for birth control pills. It creeped me out, especially since I started taking them because a friend said it would help with my period. Even as pro-choice as I was, I felt the urge to show the smarmy doctor that I wasn’t like other girls. I wanted birth control for the “right reasons.” It’s embarrassing now; we’ll all suffer no matter our reasons if this future comes to pass.

Any day now, the ban could come. I imagine my job duties including driving to Canada to pick up abortion drugs. Would that be allowed? Where do they manufacture abortion drugs? I hop from thought to thought, unable to fully grasp any one of them. I doubt the protesters have any idea of the consequences of their actions. A woman could die right in front of them from miscarriage-induced sepsis, and they would still believe in their rightness. Their overlords speak the language of dogma and control, not life and conception. Even pro-choice people, who make up the majority of the country, don’t realize that abortion was simply a helpful tool to reunite a fracturing conservative movement post-segregation.

It doesn’t matter that the antis’ “heartbeat” at six weeks is just an electrical impulse, because the fetus doesn’t have a heart yet. It doesn’t matter that many of these collections of fertilized cells are not capable of growing into babies, and that even the ones that can develop are far from having any markers of independent life. It doesn’t matter that women are dying, or what doctors and scientists say. Hell, it doesn’t matter that the Bible says nothing about when life begins. Back then, they thought a life began at quickening, when the fetus started moving around. It doesn’t matter. Nothing matters. I’m giving speeches in my head, an old habit from when I thought I would go to law school and

change the world. By the time I get home, I'm shaking and nauseous with the futility of it all. I'm only pressing on an open wound, because I'm powerless to change anything at all. I shuck off my backpack and coat and lie down on the hardwood, unable to do anything more. The despair is too overwhelming. I close my eyes, just for a moment.

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I wake up an hour later, supremely sore from lying on the floor, to someone knocking at my door. I'm perversely grateful to whoever is forcing me to get up; otherwise I'd probably have stayed like that for hours. It's around six thirty p.m., and pitch-dark outside. I live on the second floor of a three-story house, so it's usually safe enough to answer the door. Something makes me hesitate, though. I look through the small peephole and see a bald, middle-aged white man in a suit. His expression is so perfectly neutral he could be an automaton. I slide the chain into place, and then open the door the six inches it allows.

"Can I help you?" I ask.

The man smiles, a weird and disproportionate thing, like he has a few too many teeth. His smile grows wider and wider, grotesque, but then I blink, and he's normal.

"My name is Daniel Olsen," he says. "I'm here on behalf of a third party interested in buying your assets."

Assets? It seems like a standard inquiry about my apartment, but I scan him for a recording device. The antis have pulled stunts like this before, goading tired abortion workers into giving them a sound bite for Fox News. A little bit of sarcasm can be headline fodder on a slow news day. "I'm a renter," I say, trying to keep my statements as vague and inoffensive as possible.

He pulls a piece of paper out of his back pocket. "Nisha... Cool-car-knee?" I've heard worse butcherings of Kulkarni, but it's still pretty heinous. I don't respond, since I certainly know better than to confirm my name and address for a stranger, especially one this suspicious. My name is only signed on a nonpublic lease. He knows me from something else. "Well, is that you?"

"I don't own this place," I say to him. "I can't help you."

He leans toward me, and suddenly I see long teeth jutting out of his face and an inhumanly long neck twisting into an impossible S shape. I flinch, and he looks normal again.

“I understand you must be concerned about men appearing at your door, since you’re a young woman living alone. Have I done something to offend you?” he asks.

“I really can’t help you,” I say again. “Perhaps you can try the next building over?” I’m wondering if I can shut the door in his face, but I don’t want him to try to break in. I have no idea how sturdy this door actually is, and I don’t want to find out. And something in my mind is ringing alarm bells, screaming, *Run, escape, this isn’t right. This isn’t normal.*

At last, the man’s face produces a snarl, with teeth that are pointed and red-brown, like those of a just-sated wolf. Have I lost it? “Please reconsider, Ms. Kulkarni. My employer has much to offer you.”

“I’m going to have to ask you to leave,” I say. But I can see in his eyes he knows there’s nobody I can call. The Chicago police aren’t likely to be helpful, if they ever show up. He can stall me as long as he wants. “Goodbye, Mr. Olsen,” I say firmly.

He reaches into his back pocket, and I’m convinced he’s about to shoot me. He pulls out something black, irregularly shaped, and I dive out of the way, slamming the door shut. I round the short hallway into my living room and collapse against the wall, arms covering my head. Outside, there’s a persistent beeping noise, but no gunshot. No explosion. My heart is hammering, even as I berate myself. Imprinted on my eyelids, I see the shape of the man in my doorway. Eight feet tall, with bloody tusks and horns, a long neck, and a pointed tail.

“I’m sorry,” the man calls. “I understand your reluctance. I can leave a business card for you to call me. I would love to arrange a time to speak further. I am so very interested in your opinion.” I can’t bring myself to move or respond. “I’m not going to leave until I know we have an understanding, sweetheart.” I reach for my phone. I know one of our volunteers lives near me. It would be so unprofessional, but... what choice do I have?

From outside, the man says, “Good evening! May I speak with you for a moment?”

There’s a low murmur of voices. Did Nadiyah see what was happening and send Faruq up? I don’t realize that I’m standing until I’m already creeping toward the door. The voices are quiet, the timbre of people trying to whisper but failing, so it’s hard to tell who the second person is, but it doesn’t sound like either of my downstairs neighbors.

I press myself to the door and hear Aai say, in accented but perfect English, “Sir, I don’t know what you’re talking about.” I hear footsteps retreating, and then Aai knocks on my door, right against my ear. “Nisha? Are you okay? Open up!”

I manage to undo the chain with shaking hands and yank open the door. It’s only been a week since I saw my mom, but I throw myself into her arms.

“Who was that?” Aai asks.

“A protester, I guess? They’ve followed other people before.” Now that I think about it, though, he never brought up the clinic. “Did he look... normal?”

“As normal as any man can, but this is why you need to buy a security system,” she says, and I laugh. “Say Om. You need to calm down.”

“I’m fine,” I say. I’m a little terse, and Aai pulls away to glare at me. I close my eyes, take a deep breath, and exhale a long “Om.”

“That was so sad,” she says. “Again.”

I do it twice more before she nods in satisfaction.

“You didn’t forget, did you?” she asks. “We need to go to the Bhats, but you smell. Take a shower, fast. Go, go!”



5
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PARTY GAMES

It takes the whole five-minute shower for my mind to shift gears from victim of a freaky maybe-anti encounter to party attendee. When I come back out of the bathroom, Aai is inspecting my fridge, rearranging containers to add a few of her own. She turns that same critical eye on me.

“Are you all right? Are you sure that man wasn’t a threat?”

“I’m sure. It happens all the time. He’ll give up now.” I feel steadier, and remind myself that every person in our field has at least one story like this.

Aai studies me, then motions to the lehenga she’s laid out. I realize she’s already in a sari, hair in a bun, makeup done. “Get changed. We have to drive to Naperville.”

I suppress a shudder. Aai raises an eyebrow. “Traffic’s going to be hell. After all, it’s a day that ends in a ‘y.’”

She looks instantly annoyed. “If you are able to stay in this job and put up with all these bad people, you can handle some traffic. It’s an auspicious day for the Bhats’ puja. Don’t insult them and attract bad energy. And remember, don’t start anything.” I haven’t started anything in two years, but parents always remember you as you were, not as you are. Besides, she’s a better mom than pretty much anyone else I know. So I shut up and take the lehenga out of its garment bag.

“Is this...” I start.

Aai smiles. “Yes. I let out the blouse.”

I hug the skirt to my chest. It’s light, lighter than a lehenga like this should be. Forest green, with gold embroidery down the sides, and a red border with mirrors and sequins. If I were to wear it, and spin fast enough, the whole dress would flare out. The border would catch the light, which would transform the hem into a ring of fire, shooting gold sparks up the skirt. I used to love dancing. I lived to perform, coming alive onstage. There’s no real reason why I don’t dance anymore. At least, that’s the lie I like to tell myself.

As I run my hands down the embroidery, I remember what it felt like to be connected with my community, back when it was something I could be a part of without reservation. Before I grew up, and a religious nationalist was elected, and suddenly my Indian community became a place where uncles made questionable remarks about Muslim people, seemingly at random, and aunties moaned about how oppressed Hindus were in India. I could see these sentiments had been lurking just under the surface the whole time. Each of my attempts to voice opposition or even just suggest that there were similarities between US and Indian politics were met with sharp looks from Aai and the constant refrain, “You can’t possibly understand, since you have never lived in India.” So I pulled away. I stopped dancing as much, stopped attending functions and spending time with my community. They pulled away from me, too, staying silent and leaving the vulnerable among us exposed. When I had my accident, the fracture lines severed my connection to them completely.

But putting on a nice dress matters to Aai, the one person I still have in my corner. And I can tell that my wearing it will make her happy. I strip down, then tug on the lehenga, which I once painstakingly fitted with elastic so that I wouldn’t have to worry about tying the nadu tightly enough. Aai hooks the blouse in the back, then safety-pins my dupatta in place. She goes to use the bathroom.

Just once. I spin quickly, closing my eyes, and feel the skirt snap out. Muscle memory takes over, my weight centered over my left heel as my right foot hits the floor hard. I do it again. I feel powerful, like someone who might start something—it’s too much. I tie my hair back in a simple ponytail and grab my purse, busying myself with mundanity and waiting until the brightness of the dance

has faded. There's no point in reveling in that momentary feeling when it only makes the crash harder. I can't change anything. I can't even change myself. Believing that I can is dangerous.

"By the way," Aai says when she comes out, carefully not meeting my eyes, "I have something to tell you." Every single time Aai nervously begins this way, I wonder if she's finally about to admit that I ruined her life and she wishes she could have gotten an abortion instead of having me out of wedlock. She's a good mother—a great mother—so I know she won't. And yet, my heart kicks up a gear. "Rima Auntie is in the car."

"I—what? Who?"

"Rima Iyer." She says it calmly, as if I haven't heard her curse this woman's name for years. Rima Iyer, Aai's former friend, who stopped associating with us after I got into a fight with her husband.

"Ajay can give her a ride," I say. "Why is she here?"

Ajay Iyer is a cardiologist, but don't fear, he's an expert in politics, too. At parties, he offers gems like, "Muslim people have destroyed India since the time of the Mughals, and now they want preference?" and "These Mexicans are just like Muslims, we need to close the borders to all these me-me-me welfare grabbers." At some point I very politely informed him that statistics were not on his side, and you would have thought I told him to go fuck himself the way people reacted. It made me wish I had called him a self-righteous piece of shit and pointed out that he had servants wiping his ass from the day he was born and a mommy and daddy who sponsored his entire education and path to America. But instead I committed the worse sin of being a young woman who dared to contradict an elder. Nobody wanted my opinion on the political matters I was informed about. The gathering went quiet as Ajay's face grew red and he called out for Aai, to tell her in a whisper meant to be heard by all that perhaps I would benefit from a stronger male influence in my life. Aai had turned to Rima Auntie, who simply looked away, as though in agreement.

"My daughter does not need a man. She has more morals as a college student than most of the full-grown men here," Aai snapped back.

At first, gossip about what happened spread like wildfire. But then I had a freak accident, and suddenly the confrontation was forgotten by all but a few.

Rima Iyer never called Aai back, never apologized, and loudly left any event to which we showed up.

“That swine Ajay... apparently something happened between her and his mother, and he slapped her. She came to me this afternoon, crying. I could not turn her away.”

“She has plenty of vapid little friends to help her out, Aai. You always tell me not to be a bleeding heart, so take your own advice. Besides, she’ll be back by his side tomorrow.”

“She’s the one who insists on going to the party without him,” Aai says. “I think she wants to snub him, turn her nose up. I warned her, but...”

“What?” I ask, because I recognize Aai’s expression and just know she already has regrets. “Let me guess. She said something horrible about Muslim people for no reason at all and then insisted that the enlightened Hindus at the function would rally around her?”

“Nisha, she’s gone through a hard time. Don’t be so harsh.” Aai’s lips press into a thin line and I know I’m close to the truth. “Get in the car. And be polite. I know you don’t like her, but she’s gone through terrible things. I want you to be the bigger person.”

I don’t have it in me to fight Rima Auntie, but the principle of the thing still compels me to say, “It’s wrong to entertain bigots.”

“Don’t turn this into a philosophical argument,” Aai snaps, and I can tell I’ve reached the end of her patience. She’s had a trying day, and I’m being a bitch. I feel a surge of contrition, and she sighs. “Arguing with her right now will only make her spiral. When bad things happen to difficult people, it doesn’t change the badness of what happened. Perhaps this will be a time for her to grow, yes?”

“If she’s going to take your help, she’ll definitely have to change,” I say, bumping my shoulder against hers so she knows it’s a compliment.

Aai shakes her head. “Get in the car. You know how I feel about traffic.”

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Rima Auntie sits stiffly in the back seat, which is surprisingly considerate of her. I can’t see any marks on her face, but a man like Ajay Iyer would be careful not to

hurt a woman where it could be seen. I brace myself for the usual, *You look healthy*—translation, *You've gained weight*—but she just looks me up and down and says, “Nice lehenga.”

“Thanks, aunty. How are you?”

She snorts but doesn't say anything. She probably doesn't want to spill her guts to a girl she has long thought of as roadside trash. On the other hand, perhaps there should be an enemy-of-my-enemy attitude here. Aai drives through traffic like a woman possessed, cursing out the drivers ahead of us. We'll be late, but so will everyone else. Who even holds a party post-satyanarayan puja, and who does it three weeks before Holi instead of in the fall? It's a nice touch, I guess, to distribute the prasad from the ceremony to friends, but usually the puja is a household affair, so the Bhats really are using it as an excuse to host a party on some random Thursday. Aai says that the Bhats aren't all bad, but she's never explained how she met them in the first place other than to mention how they “owe” her.

Too soon, we pull onto the street. The houses in this neighborhood are massive, too big to be comfortably filled by the four- or five-person desi families who live here, but great for a party. All the BMWs and Teslas have filled the nearby parking, so we park farther and walk through the old, iced-over snow. I mentally prepare myself as we trudge forward, reminded by the cars that these people are deeply conservative. Plenty of them want to stop immigration—from India too!—in order to give their children an advantage, believe in Muslim bans, think Black people don't work hard enough, and worship money. Maybe not everyone, but enough of them that I am always on guard.

There's a crush of people inside. Too many, but at least it's warm. I scan the crowd, hoping to find an acquaintance to stand next to—perfect Shreya Pillai, perhaps, or the recently engaged Apoorva Sangvi—but come up empty.

“Neha!” a woman my mom's age calls out, beckoning Aai over. A young man stands next to her.

We've barely even slipped off our shoes, and the game begins. This is why I avoid desi gatherings like the plague. These large, impersonal events are all report-card and bank-account competition all the time. I'm twenty-six years old, and people want to know my SAT score. I recognize the moment in which

everyone else notices that Rima Auntie is with us, because there's a hush of silence followed by extremely forced conversation. The woman who called out to Aai withdraws her hand from the air, but Aai sets her jaw and moves toward her with me in tow. Over my shoulder I see Rima Auntie bulldozing her way toward Kamala Auntie, a fast friend of hers, or at least, a fast friend of hers twenty-four hours ago.

Aai says, "This is Sheetal. Sheetal, meet my daughter, Nisha."

Sheetal Auntie gives me a once-over, then says, "Have you met my son?"

Aai barely hides her eye roll as Sheetal Auntie pushes her son forward. I prepare myself for the forthcoming dick-measuring contest—mine's bigger, not that anybody cares. "Ishaan went to Northwestern! He's a consultant."

Well, that's a job title that makes me want to choke on my own vomit. I hope I've managed to smile rather than grimace. "Cool."

"He's very smart," Sheetal Auntie continues. "He got a 1500 on his SAT and works for a Big Five consulting firm, Parthenon. Where did your daughter go? Where does she work?"

"Nisha went to the University of Chicago," Aai says. "She works at a health center."

Sheetal Auntie's eyes light up. "I think it's wonderful when kids go to the public city schools and save money, especially to work in medicine." Translation: I'm not threatening to her precious son's prestige, but I'll bring in a good income. These aunties only hear what they want to hear. Aai's eyes dart toward me in warning, but I stay silent. I have no pride to protect anymore.

Ishaan says, "She means UChicago, Amma. The number three school in the country."

Sheetal Auntie gives a small, insipid laugh. "Even better!"

"Nisha doesn't work in medicine," Aai breaks in. I'm thankful. Hopefully it will make me less appealing, so I can move on.

"Oh? What do you do?" Ishaan asks. In a surprise twist, he's actually addressed the question to me. I almost feel a little bad for him, because he doesn't know what most people in the community already do, that no self-respecting family would want me to be a part of theirs.

“It’s a small clinic, so I wear a lot of hats. I do outreach to local organizations, manage volunteers, and sometimes counsel patients.” Simple, clean. I’m not ashamed of what I do, but I’d rather avoid drama.

“What kind of medical clinic has volunteers? You mean students?” Sheetal Aunty asks. It’s obvious from her tone that she’s annoyed at us, probably for the semipublic correction issued by her own son. This kind of tone always ticks off Aai. For all her talk about wanting me to control my temper, I had to learn it from somewhere.

“An abortion clinic,” Aai says with a sharp smile.

The effect on Sheetal Aunty is immediate. She wrinkles her nose and takes a step back. “That’s... nice,” she says, before adding sotto voce, “But don’t you want your daughter doing *cleaner* work?”

Disappointingly, Ishaan looks like he agrees. I look around the crowded room—sometimes Geeta, the owner of our clinic, happens to be at these things. I see her more at parties than at the clinic, since she embraces a hands-off role.

Something in Aai snaps. “Cleaner how? Do you really divide work that way, Sheetal?”

Sheetal Aunty opens and closes her mouth, then looks at a point behind us, before offering a cruel smile. “Rima’s the expert. She says that this abortion business is contrary to Hinduism.” She whispers the word *abortion* as though she doesn’t want to be caught saying it. Both Aai and I whirl around to face Rima Aunty, who is wearing a guilty expression.

“Well, I didn’t say that, exactly,” she whispers in a meek tone of voice I haven’t heard from her before.

“Hinduism is a very scientific religion,” proclaims a male voice out of nowhere. I think it might be Dr. Bhat, which would be an absurd development. “The medical consensus is that we cannot consider a fetus to be independent life until viability. Our religion teaches that we must minimize harm, and what is abortion if not respecting someone’s choice to minimize harm for themselves?”

It *is* Dr. Bhat. That man has said maybe ten words in public in the whole time we’ve known him, and now he’s participating in discourse about abortion and Hinduism? Everyone else seems equally shocked, so he gives a little shrug and disappears into the kitchen. I pinch myself.

“Did that just happen?” I whisper to Aai.

“I didn’t know he could do that,” she responds, her voice so soft that I can barely hear her. She may be talking to herself. The circle of people around us disperses, and a few people pat me on the back before wandering far, far away from the toxic huddle I seem to be stuck in.

“Where’s Ajay?” Sheetal Aunty asks Rima Aunty, as though inquiring about the weather.

“Oh, Ajay texted me earlier,” Kamala Aunty says, sidling up to us. “He says not to worry about him, that he was only worried about you, my dear. He said you’re going through a hard time, and you need friends.”

Two spots of color rise on Rima Aunty’s cheeks. “I’m not some sort of imbecile,” she snaps.

“Control yourself,” Kamala Aunty orders, as though speaking to a child. “Bhagwan only knows we’ve all been on the bad end of your tongue. Ajay is worried about you! Most of us would love a husband who shows such concern.”

With each passing moment, Rima Aunty seems to retreat further into herself, her whole face suffused with maroon. “I—he—you don’t understand—”

“My cousin’s daughter had some... instability, you know how kids these days are,” Sheetal Aunty says. “And she had to get a therapist. I will get you the name. We all want you to get well, Rima.” She gives Rima Aunty a condescending pat on the hand, then leaves the three of us alone. Our radioactivity might be making us glow.

Rima Aunty takes a deep breath, and then turns to me. “I was perhaps a bit harsh in how I have spoken about you. I had to, you understand?”

A bit of me is repulsed. At a detached level, I recognize in myself a classic cognitive dissonance. I know that victims of abuse may exhibit signs of childishness or immaturity, and act in manipulative ways in order to get the support they so desperately need. Hell, I’ve seen it at the clinic when I have to fill in to counsel patients on their options. But those patients haven’t hurt me. Rima Aunty has.

After the day I’ve had, the desire to hurt her back is brewing within me. Part of me wants to lash out, call her a pathetic liar. An evil in my chest warms at the idea, and I do my best to ice it out. “An apology would be a nice start,” I say.

“I’m sorry,” she says.

She’s given me what I want, and still I can’t bring myself to forgive her. Aai reaches behind me and pinches my hip. “All right.” Her face brightens, even though I’ve given her the most noncommittal response possible. I turn away in disgust, both at her and at myself. If people want to talk shit about me, well, maybe I deserve it.



6
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LYING EYES

There is a man, handsome and proud, walking through the foothills of the Himalayas. He is leaving, the mountains at his back. Although there is snow everywhere, and the man is dressed in a light kurta, he does not seem cold. He looks up at me, and when he smiles, his teeth are pointed—

I snap awake at the thrill of adrenaline and sit bolt upright. I clench my eyes shut and try to remember the fading remnants of the dream. It was long, though I can only remember snippets. The man conjured by my subconscious had the face of the man I met at the museum, but at the start of the dream he had been covered in blood and shaking as though just birthed. Yet he was fully formed, and when he pushed himself onto his feet, brushing tears off his face and shuddering, he did not seem like a child. He walked with uncertainty, looking back at the mountains with longing. But in time, he held his head higher. He saw smoke rising in the distance and was possessed by grim determination. There was a hard look in his eyes, and I knew it could be nothing good. Even so, he didn't do anything wrong; I was judging him based on the sensation of the dream, some prickling sense in the back of my head. My brain clearly combined a few of my recent encounters into a rakshasa-inspired dream. But it lodges in my gut, churning, feeling truer than the reality I don't want to face, especially not after that party.

When I started at this job, I told myself it would be a stepping stone to greater things. I was just out of college, believing that individuals like me could change the world for the better. That was before I learned that not even a Democratic president could protect women's bodies, that not even millions of people marching in the streets could save Black lives, that not even one hundred countries coming together could stop a genocide. That no person could make a positive change, but it only took one person to ruin a life, a country, a world.

My first boss—who has since been replaced by a part-time remote outreach supervisor who “manages” me by sending fundraising emails on Wednesdays and Thursdays—was a woman named Patty, whose exhausted eye bags only grew more pronounced with each passing week. I was filled with energy and brainstormed ideas to build out a full volunteer program, emailed hundreds of potential partners, found court cases we could join, and generally made myself a nuisance. Eventually, Patty called me into her office for a check-in.

She said, “I’m concerned about you, Nisha. You’re overextending yourself.”

“Is there something I’ve been forgetting to do?” I asked. “I’m so sorry. I’ll correct it straightaway.”

Patty sighed. “I don’t want you to burn out. Have you managed to find more consistent volunteers? Have any funders responded?”

“It’s an awkward time right now,” I told her. “The pandemic and all. I’m sure soon—”

“I’ve had a long day,” Patty said. “A long year, a long decade. So let me be blunt. We’re not stupid or lazy here. The reason we don’t do everything you’re doing is because we learned long ago it didn’t work. You’re wasting your time.”

“But—”

“Focus on what we have.” She clicked something on her computer screen. “*Roe*’s going to fall soon anyways. We just have to try to survive.”

“I read an op-ed in *The New York Times* the other day that said the opposite?” I phrased it as a question, hoping to break through her pessimism, but she just scoffed. I felt confident she was wrong.

“Young people think they know everything, but if the world worked like you think it does, you’d be out of a job.”

There was nothing I could say to that. In just a few sentences, she had transformed me from a crusader into a naive idealist.

Then came the *Dobbs* decision, and I finally learned that no matter what conservatives swore under oath before Congress, they didn't care about fairness. They cared about power. Patty apologized on the day she left. She cried tears of relief and wished me all the best. Now I'm something worse than Patty because I don't even have the courage to get out of my own rut. I try to take some deep breaths, because I need to pace myself. It's only day three of forty. Patients are relying on me, and I'm already late. I lie there, wasting another five minutes thinking about how I should get up, before finally, by some miracle, my body forces itself to work. My feet hit the ground. I get into motion.

—

I feel a bit dizzy on the way to the clinic, but the machinations of the body serve to further ground the mind.

"Feeling better?" Diane asks when I get in. She pushes my bright yellow vest toward me.

I nod. I've at least focused on the task ahead.

"There's a big crowd already," I say. "How is it that it's worse every day?"

Diane shakes her head sadly. "You know, I thought when they won, they'd be less loud. But then I realized, as long as even one clinic is open, they haven't won."

"Good to know we still consume their every waking thought," I snipe, and Diane gives me a short laugh in reward.

But just as quickly, her face turns serious. "Hey, have you heard anything about the clinic having to move? Something about the alderman?" Her voice is pitched low, and I almost get whiplash from the change in mood.

"What are you talking about?" I ask.

She purses her lips. "Maybe it's nothing, but I'm concerned. I always keep my ear to the ground, you know, and all of a sudden I'm hearing news that someone wants to buy us, or maybe we're going to be considered a public nuisance now, or..."

“It’s probably just Forty Days. Nobody likes to be around a clinic then,” I say. We’re both thinking the same thing, though: Any shift in the political or financial wind could sink us. Our clinic, like most independent operations, is always hanging on by a thread.

She sighs. “Stay safe out there, honey. I’ll call through the volunteer list you emailed me yesterday when I have a free moment. Hopefully we can get more boots on the ground.”

“I’m sure we can. I would start with Jeff.” Jeff is a big, burly retiree—an absolute sweetheart to patients and a stone wall to protesters. We met escorting at Planned Parenthood, when he took me aside and gently told me the protesters would treat me worse for being brown. As a Black man, he knew.

“They’re not going to shout slurs at you—well, not most of them, anyways. They’re going to target you because they love to pretend they’re fighting for people like us,” he said, placing a large, mittened hand on my shoulder, breath coming out in steaming puffs. I thought I could handle anything then but didn’t want to seem disrespectful, so I thanked him.

At the end of that first Planned Parenthood shift, Jeff found me crying in the volunteer coat closet. He shook his head. “I know, right?”

“I thought you were overreacting!” I couldn’t believe how they had gotten under my skin, making my blood boil with their comparisons of abortion to genocide.

“Oh honey, no,” he said. And finally, at the end of that horrible and terrible day, I was able to laugh.

Jeff lives in the south suburbs, so he’s not a regular here. But when we call him, he’s always willing to put in the miles. I could use his gruff, grounding energy right about now.

I take a moment to gather myself before stepping back outside. It was nice enough out yesterday, but now it’s snowing. At least it’s warm thirties snow. For Chicago in February, that’s pretty decent. The protesters are shouting, and I think someone’s speaking in tongues—or maybe they’re just that incoherent. A car comes down the narrow street, and the moment its signal turns for the clinic parking lot, protesters run in front of it. I sigh and try to make eye contact with the person inside, beckoning them forward. They seem to get it, honking twice,

then moving at a snail's pace. As the car creates room, I slip into the gap and throw my hands out to shield the driver's side. Someone bangs on the back windshield, but then they're in the parking lot. Safe.

I'm about to approach and ask if they want to be walked inside, when I make sudden, jolting eye contact with an anti. Not someone. Something. For a moment, the roaring of the protesters fades into silence as I stare open-mouthed at the otherworldly creature—a stocky red-skinned demon with hooves instead of feet. It smiles at me, revealing two great tusks. Nobody else seems to notice or care. I take a step forward to get a better look and narrowly avoid a car pulling up in front of me. I tear my gaze away to see Aaron staring at me in confusion through his windshield. I'm standing in the middle of the road. I jump back, and when I look up, the demon is gone. That side of the road is unoccupied, stretching wide open in either direction. The demon—I'm making things up. I look over the rest of the protesters and feel a new sense of unease.

Another car pulls up. "Hey, Nish! Sorry I'm late, I got stuck in traffic!" JJ calls out the window. "Diane called, said I could pick up a shift even though I'm not trained yet because you'll be on duty with me?"

The demon is gone. This is all in my head, and I'm letting myself worry about supernatural fantasies instead of keeping the clinic running. I'm embarrassed that I let myself daydream on the job. I turn my focus to JJ.

"Thank you *so* much for coming in on short notice. As you can see, they're out in full force today. But go inside, grab a vest, and I think the patients will be in good hands."

—

Here's the thing about hallucinating demons: It's not fucking normal. And yet when I catch another glimpse of one from my office window several hours later, I only briefly startle before shaking my head and refocusing on the emails I need to send. The demon is standing some yards away near the main road, wearing a suit, with horns that spiral high into the air. For a moment I lean forward, looking at its sharp, fang-like teeth, my heart beating so hard I fear I may have a cardiac event. A car trundles by it, slow and close enough to notice the demon,

but it doesn't stop in alarm. The demon looks right at me, mouth opened wide in what I think might be a laugh, and raises a hand in greeting. I force my eyes onto the screen. I don't have time for a nervous breakdown, for hallucinating demons. I have an inbox full of emails from volunteers explaining why they haven't shown up for a shift in a while, and I need to focus on sifting through them. When I look out of my window after five slow-crawling minutes, the demon is still there. He seems to be... scribbling in a notepad? I scrub at my eyes. The demon disappears. I slump back in my chair. Could I have a brain tumor? No, that's last month's *Grey's Anatomy* binge talking. I would have a headache or something. Before I can freak myself out too much, I have my phone in my hand and Aai on speed dial. She picks up on the second ring.

"Are you okay?" she asks immediately.

"I think so." I close my eyes, and the demon man dances behind them. "I feel like I'm seeing things, Aai. Do you think I'm dying of a brain tumor?"

I can almost hear Aai roll her eyes. "What are you seeing?"

"Demons?" I phrase it as a question because I want to sound less crazy, but I know it probably isn't helping.

"You've always had a really strong imagination," Aai says. "You used to hunt for demons as a kid, remember?"

I blush even though nobody else can hear her. "Okay, but I'm an adult now, and I'm seeing demons in suits, with big horns and teeth..."

"Did you sleep well last night?" Aai asks.

"No."

"Are you sure you're not dozing off at work?"

"... No."

"What's more likely? Seeing monsters because you've let yourself get extremely tired or having a brain tumor?"

I want to tell her that she should take me more seriously, because I'm too embarrassed to admit she's probably right, but I'm also too fucking tired to argue. "Okay."

"You need to meditate more, baccha. Have you been saying Om every night?"

"No."

“You should pray. Don’t argue—it doesn’t have to be religious. The words are meditative, they’ll help you relax.”

Her advice makes me snort. It’s a perennial favorite of Aai’s: If I start praying, my life will finally improve. “I’ve tried that, it doesn’t work for me.”

“Try to imagine some balloons, filled with worries, popping one by one.”

“Yeah.”

“Call me from the train,” Aai says, sounding distracted. I’m interrupting her day with my stupid neediness. “You’re going to be fine.”

“Thanks.” I hear three beeps on the other end and look back out the window, seeing only the expanse of parking lot, scattered trees, and, beyond that, the road. There’s nobody there. It’s all in my head.

I get to my feet, though it feels like moving through molasses. On my way out, I Google whether hallucinating demons is a common sleep-deprivation symptom. The front of the clinic is empty and dark. A shape moves in the corner of my eye, above my phone screen. I scream, then clamp my mouth shut, letting out an alarmed squeak.

“Sorry! Sorry!” It’s a familiar voice.

The lights come back on, and I see Aaron hunched over, like he’s trying to make himself small.

“What are you doing?” I demand.

“I thought I would save some energy, since we’re done with the patient list. I didn’t mean—sorry.”

“Where’s Diane?”

“In the back, helping with something.”

“Closing the front is her job,” I say. “What if someone came as a walk-in?”

“We don’t—”

“*You* might not see walk-ins, but Dr. Levy stays late sometimes just in case.”

“I didn’t think—”

“Clearly.” I should probably stop interrupting him, but I have no desire to conduct a conversation. Instead, I glance at my phone and skim the top results of my search.

Signs that your insomnia might be more serious than you think

Prevalence of supernatural hallucinations in sleep deprivation

DEMONS ARE REAL!

My phone pings. Aai sent me a meditation video. When I look up, Aaron is gone.

—

I go to sleep early, and wake up from a dreamless sleep feeling not refreshed, but something close to it. Hopefully, my relaxing Saturday plans will give my brain the rest it needs to get back on track. I'm planning to pick up a shift escorting patients at the Planned Parenthood in Aurora, something I always look forward to. After today, I won't be able to return until after Forty Days is over, since our clinic will need me every Saturday. Like other Planned Parenthoods, this one is massive and better funded than our clinic, but because no good deed goes unpunished, it's also a bigger target: When people think about abortion, they think about Planned Parenthood. Their workers are doxxed, their neighbors are canvassed, their websites are flooded and hacked and crashed—all supported by the web of untraceable money fueling the anti-choice movement.

A few years ago, antis managed to buy up the land across from the Aurora Planned Parenthood and built a crisis pregnancy center there. They put up signs that read, "Pregnant? We can help!" and "Free ultrasounds!" and "Pregnancy clinic this way!" to redirect patients. The unfortunate few who have accidentally ended up there have told us afterward how terrible it was. How they learned the clinic didn't have a doctor. How the ultrasound techs didn't have formal training. How everyone addressed them as "mom" and "mommy." Their stories drive me, and every time I go down there I look forward to it—it feels like I'm marching into battle, a battle I can win. I'm sure the actual workers at the clinic feel a lot like I do, always one wrong move away from ruin. But while I'm in Aurora, I'm just a cog in the machine with one simple task. It may be hard, but I know I can do it. I can feel useful.

All the volunteers are veterans of escorting, so when I climb into the carpool and explain our newly expanded horde of protesters, I immediately gain four offers of help. When we arrive, I make eye contact with Steve, who shoots me an angry scowl. I wave. We've been doing this dance for years. Four of the other antis link arms and walk into the road, creating a blockage for people trying to get to the neighboring Jewel-Osco supermarket. I sigh and step forward to tell the would-be shoppers that they can circle around the parking lot to the store, when I stop cold. The man in the first car—there's something not quite right about him. A feeling of wrongness prickles up my spine, oddly reminiscent of Thursday evening and the man at the door.

"Ms. Kulkarni," he says through the open window. "You have something very valuable, and I am prepared to pay its worth."

"Who are you?" I whisper.

"You are seeing things, aren't you? You are not crazy, merely in possession of a gift. If you—"

"Move along!" Jeff calls from behind me. The man in the car jerks.

"Murdering bitch, get out of my way!" he shouts, but his voice sounds different than it did before. He's just another angry anti. I take a step back and collide with someone.

"It's just me," Jeff says. "Why are the antis blocking their own cars? We should go inside and ask the staff what they want us to do about it." With great effort I nod, focusing on the familiar face. "Did he know you?" Jeff continues. "Or was that just the usual babble?"

"Never met him. He was just... proselytizing."

Jeff shakes his head. "Half these people could benefit from therapy."

"Only half?" I joke with a shaky laugh.

It is only when Jeff turns away that I internalize that he saw it too, just as Aai saw the man outside my apartment. It's not all in my head. I'm pulled out of my thoughts by the approach of a mother and her young son. The antis immediately start yelling at the little boy.

"Your mommy's going to kill your brother!"

"Your mommy's going to kill you!"

I push down my inner turmoil and run forward to usher them onto clinic property. Seeing the boy start to cry, I hit play on my Spotify escorting playlist. Taylor Swift starts singing “Shake It Off.” The mother gives me a hesitant smile, and I sing along, doing a little dance for the boy while positioning myself between him and the antis.

“Home, Mama!” the boy cries. He stops abruptly, and I worry he’s about to bolt. “I want to go home.”

The woman sighs. “Come on, baby, just a little bit farther and we’ll be safe inside.”

“Don’t go in!” a protester shouts on their megaphone. “They tear off baby arms and legs in there!”

“Don’t let me go in!” the kid wails as he grabs ahold of my leg. “Mama, I like my arms!”

The woman is clearly starting to freak out, so I gently pull the kid’s arms away from my body to try to move him toward shelter. He just burrows farther into my fleece sweatpants.

“Maybe we should go,” his mom says, and I feel a jolt of panic.

“C’mon, kiddo,” I whisper. “It’s going to be fine. Nobody’s going to hurt you.”

Please forget about this, I silently beg. *Kids have short attention spans, right?* I feel something warm rush through the hand that’s touching his arm, and I immediately let go, worried I’m gripping too hard.

With a dazed look in his eye, the boy blinks up at me and asks, “Where am I? Where’s my mom?”

“I’m right here, baby. Ready to go inside?” she responds.

“Who’s yelling?” he asks. His eyes are blank.

“Some bad people. Don’t worry about it,” his mom says.

“I like this song!” he declares, and I take the opportunity to usher them forward.

Pretty soon we’re on clinic property and the boy is dancing, shaking his little arms and twirling.

“Thank you,” his mom whispers. “He usually never lets things go. I was just going to give up.”

“No problem. He probably got overwhelmed,” I say. But my hand is still burning. “He’s so sweet.”

“His father is... we have to leave. Can’t do that with a baby.”

Patients often confide in me, try to explain why they’re here. I’m honored by their trust, even as I wish they didn’t feel compelled to offer a justification.

“We’re here to help. If you leave during my shift, we’ll have a dance party walking out, too.”

I’m rewarded by a laugh from the boy. I wish it was always this easy, but I can’t shake the unsettled feeling building within me. *Please forget*, I said in my head, and the boy forgot.



7
—

IGNORANCE IS BLISS

That night, I have another dream. I'm following the same demon-slash-weirdo from the Art Institute through a village.

I'm an observer floating above the scene, but even from my distant vantage point, it is clear that the villagers, brandishing torches, are trying to exile him. I can't quite make out the garbled dream speech well enough to understand why, but I see that he has blood on his clothes. Someone else's, I assume. The man's eyes flash, and in an instant the leader of the villagers is on the ground, convulsing. My heart races faster. The rest of the villagers run toward him, but the strange man holds up a hand, as if asking for a brief pause. I see him mouth a word, and even though it's not English, I understand. *Forget.*

A thrill of horror runs through me as the villagers come to a standstill. The man says something more, but I can't make out what. He looks strong, fierce. As one, the villagers turn around and walk back toward their homes, then break into a run. They trip over the body of their leader but do not notice him, do not stop to help. They look frightened. When they are gone, the demon man steps forward. The man on the ground has stopped convulsing, but his breath comes in shallow pants. He tries to scabble away but merely grunts ineffectually. The demon leans down, his hands reaching for the man's throat, and I wake up.

In the space left by the dream, I lie in the dark. I don't usually dream so vividly, and the intensity of the images conjured by my subconscious presses into

me. It's cloudy, and although it's almost eight a.m., there's no light coming into my room, keeping me in bed even longer than normal. But in time, as always, I get up. I'm just about finished getting dressed when I hear a knock at the door. Fear jolts through me—has the anti from Thursday returned to harass me? But through the peephole I see brown hands.

I keep the chain in place and crack open the door to find the man from the Art Institute. The man from my dreams.

I lift my phone to snap a photo of him. He looks back at me, seemingly undisturbed, and I glance down to find his mild expression captured on my screen completely undistorted. From my rudimentary internet research, I've learned that hallucinations may carry over into photography, but usually the images are deformed or different because the brain cannot maintain consistency. I zoom in and out of the photo, trying to catch myself, until he clears his throat.

"I assure you, I'm real."

I stare blankly at him from across the chain on the door. "I'm—that's not—what are you doing here?"

"Can I come in?" he asks. He smiles, but it looks pained. It reminds me of the way he behaved at the Art Institute.

"What do you want?"

"My name is Muya, and I can help you."

"Ah yes," I say sarcastically to hide my fear. "You can help me with... stalking?"

"You are being stalked, but not by me. I can help." He is absolutely deadpan. I should shut the door in his face, but I have poor self-preservation instincts, and apparently my sense of curiosity isn't entirely dead.

"Wait one moment," I tell Muya. I text Aai.

there's some shouting in my building

going out to investigate

if I don't text you back in a half hour, check on me!!

I could be dead in half an hour, but at least I won't be lying alone for days. I cast around for a weapon, just in case. I grab a somewhat blunt steak knife that I use to cut vegetables and unhook the chain, letting a possible threat into my apartment. Muya shucks off his shoes, which almost makes me giggle.

As though he can read my thoughts, he says, "I don't know what you think of me, but I'm not a monster. Nice knife, by the way."

"I think you're a rakshasa," I say, then immediately feel mortified that I let the words slip out. His eyes widen, but not as if he thinks I'm crazy. He looks like I've found him out. I let his surprise fuel me. "You can't be here for anything good."

Rakshasas can be bloodthirsty, but they're also known to live and let live. Something tells me that, as a chronically unlucky person, I should prepare for the worst even if most only commit acts of true evil when provoked.

"Why let me into your home, then?" He settles down into one of the two wooden chairs, an eyebrow raised. His posture is too stiff to portray true comfort.

"Because I want answers, and you've offered yourself up to provide them. I have to leave in thirty minutes, so let's make this fast."

"Do you want answers?" He leans forward, elbows resting on the table. He's dressed in a button-down and gray slacks, a jarring contrast to the Indian clothing I've seen him wearing in my dreams. "You don't seem able to believe the truth. You named me rakshasa, but you didn't *believe* it, not really. The truth is that demons are real, and this modern world has convinced itself otherwise. You should know that already. You have been gifted the ability to see us as we truly are. And yet you spurn it, waste it."

Each word is spoken deliberately, with a precise coolness, making him sound deeply persuasive. I feel myself wanting to believe him. If demons are real, it would mean that I haven't been hallucinating.

"I've seen maybe two of these so-called demons in the past week after a lifetime of not seeing any at all. What, did they just suddenly move to Chicago?"

Muya glares at me. "It is wasted on you!"

"Excuse me?"

“All that power... put into someone who cannot make basic logical deductions.” I don’t know whether to laugh or be offended. He continues, “Five days ago you touched the statue and freed me from my prison. In so doing, some of my power transferred to you. That is why you can see demons. That is why you can reshape your world.”

“I can’t reshape shit,” I reply.

“All right, then. If you’re not going to use the power, give it back to me. It is mine, after all; you stole it from me. Do it, and your ability to see will go away.”

I consider his offer. On the off chance that he’s telling the truth and this isn’t an elaborate hallucination, I shouldn’t give up the ability to see the malevolent forces stalking me.

Muya gives me a slow, grim smile. He looks at me not like an equal, but like a rat that has learned to dance. “Ah. So you are unwilling to release it. Perhaps you are more intelligent than you seem.”

It’s then that I realize I’ve been a fabulous idiot. I love judging TV characters for failing to use their phones, and here I am doing the same thing. I pull out my phone, open Google, and type: *Muya Indian demon*. Nothing comes up.

“What are you doing?” Muya demands.

“One moment,” I say. “Responding to a text.”

“That’s rude,” he says.

I type: *Muya Indian demon Shiva*. Bingo.

“What would you know about that, Muyalagan?” I say slowly. Muya’s eyes widen. “I didn’t know Apasmara had another name. But it fits—the reluctance to give information, the short stature, the statue you came from.”

He reaches into his pocket to pull out a smartphone and taps its screen thoughtfully. “The internet, is it? A great tool of ignorance. I’m not Muyalagan, but you could say I am of him. He was a great asura, and I am a small piece of his magic.”

“So you’re a manifestation of the demon of ignorance?” I ask, each word tinged with more incredulity than the last. How can a “small piece” of a demon with a Wikipedia page be sitting in my living room? I wouldn’t have believed any of this just a few days ago, and yet I’m going along with it.

“That’s not important,” Muya says. He shakes his head, and I feel a brief flash of sympathy for what must be a bewildering new experience before I remember who he is. What he is. Apasmara is evil. “There are worse things than ignorance. There’s...” He trails off, looking a little afraid.

“Are you trying to pull one over on me?” I ask. “I wasn’t born yesterday. But that body you’re wearing probably was.”

He snorts. “This shape is so familiar to me, it’s like a second skin.”

“Ah, well, you know what they say about a second skin?”

“What?”

“It’s no first skin.”

Muya scowls, then his expression smooths. “Listen.” His voice is a command that my brain obeys. “You freed me from that statue, and you took some of my magic. It’s made you a target. You’re in danger. I don’t like to deal with humans, but I will offer this. Give me back what you stole, and I’ll help you in return.”

“I don’t have magic,” I say.

He laughs. “You named me rakshasa. You could see the truth of me. That is your magic.”

I take a deep breath. “Who do you think is after me, then?”

“I don’t know.” Muya exhales loudly. “I don’t like not knowing. But I would not come here asking for something without offering something in return. I’m not a heathen. Once I learned you had enemies, I had planned to come here with their heads on a platter, to barter for my magic, but that’s no longer possible.”

“Oh my gods. You’re afraid. I freed you from the statue, so you’ve imprinted on me like... a little duckling afraid of its own shadow. I bet you think that slick-looking demon-man—”

“Did you speak to him?” Muya is clenching his hands so hard his knuckles are actually turning white.

“You—you can’t be serious.” I pause to consider the situation and remember that I work in the abortion world. I know better than to discount improbable threats. “I didn’t tell him anything.”

“But he knows how to find you,” Muya mused.

“So what?” I retort.

“You know nothing of power,” Muya says. “Demons have more power than a human could ever comprehend and hold. I’ve lived for centuries, long enough to know that you humans cannot be trusted with magic. You are liars, backstabbers, and idiots by nature. You will not be able to withstand whoever is after you.”

“Who hurt you?” I ask sarcastically, but when Muya flinches, I laugh. “What, nursing a broken heart?”

“That is not something you need to know,” he snaps. “I am trying to help you, you insufferable idiot. So give me back my magic and let me.”

“Why don’t you just take it?” I ask. “If you’re so powerful…”

Muya gives me an incredulous, almost pitying look. “If you think I can just separate the magic from you that easily, my fate has been linked with a fool’s. However it came to you, it’s part of you now. The easiest way would be for you to hand it over. If I find an alternative method—you might not survive.”

“You might think I’m stupid, but I know better than to give you something for only the vague promise of help. I need a lot more first. Here.” I take his phone and input my number, under the contact, *Your Only Friend*. We both laugh for a moment before I remember with a start that I shouldn’t be joking around with a demon. This is just a transaction: I have something he wants, and even if I don’t trust him, I would be foolish to reject him outright. “By my estimate, you’ve gotten far more information out of me than I have from you. If you want my help, you need my trust. Give me something I can work with.”

He looks intently into my eyes. “You really know nothing?” He shakes his head. “The power that is in you now—my power—you were not the first human to touch it. I have shared it with others, people I chose, unlike you. They were able to feel the imprint of each other through that lineage of power. Though I did not choose you, the power is the same. Dig within yourself and find that connection. Then perhaps you will believe in me.”

“What, you’re telling me to unlock my seventh chakra to find the power within myself?”

“Yes.”

Muya looks so serious that I bark out a laugh. “And how, exactly, will I find this connection? Drugs? Have you been a dealer all along?”

He rolls his eyes. “I can’t tell you everything. Each one of my chosen had a different way of looking back, something that made them feel peaceful, transcendent. Some walked in the fields or bathed in the river or practiced meditation.”

“You want me to wade into the Chicago River?”

Muya just shrugs. “Whatever you want.”

—

I used to be one of *those* kids, a weirdo with an unshakable belief in magic. I found these faux-scientific books about magic in the library, a whole series entitled *Dragonology*, *Fairyology*, and *Demonology*. The first two contained little gimmicks like “dragon scales” embedded into the pages that even my child-self dismissed. But *Demonology* was a different story. The book housed tales from around the world about demons, recontextualizing great historical acts as instances of magic. Demon magic. In India, the book claimed, the greatest rulers made deals with benevolent rakshasas and asuras to protect their people, their strength fueling armies, their foresight saving entire regions from ruin. Armed with this knowledge, I spent my childhood dreaming of magic, finding and devouring other books on the topic. At the time, we lived in an apartment complex in Rogers Park, so I was never without playmates. While other kids pretended to fly or teleport or turn invisible, I explained that there was no historically verified documentation of those abilities. Enhanced speed or strength, sure. The ability to bring rain or heal wounds, yes. Elemental magic, absolutely. Unsurprisingly, I wasn’t very popular. It didn’t bother me—I was more occupied with searching for a demon to grant me my own magic. Although the books all said they had died out, I still believed I could find one. Then one day, a playmate of mine laughed derisively at me for believing in demons. I remember asking Aai about it later, cheeks burning with shame. And though she spoke to me kindly, I could see the laughter in her eyes, too.

Maybe that was when the trajectory of my life changed, when I internalized, deep down, that the foundations of the world I lived in were shaky, that there was no special magic that could change that. And yet I want it to be real. I want

to unlock some secret power, I want to believe that some sort of impossible magic is at my fingertips if only I can find it. Once Muya has left and I've texted Aai that I'm fine, I meditate. I try it on my own, using the breathing exercises Aai taught me, and when that fails, find the YouTube video she sent me and follow an older Indian man's droning instructions. I take a brief break to email the potential volunteers signed up for training that we'll be doing it remotely this evening instead, since there's no way I'm trekking out to the clinic with everything going on. Then I fill up the bathtub and put on relaxing string music. It's the first time I've used the tub since I moved in, and I immediately hate it. My skin itches and the part of me outside the water is cold. The bubbles have a cloying, fruity smell. I heave myself out of the tub. I'd pulled my hair up into a bun to avoid getting it wet in the bath, and when I catch my reflection in the mirror, I realize I always knew what I was going to have to do. From the moment Muya said I had to find my inner peace, there was only one option. I grab a simple kurta from my closet, tie my dupatta around one shoulder to the opposite hip, and let my body take over and do what it's wanted to do for years.

From the moment I first danced Kathak, I was terrible, but I couldn't stop. "Practice makes permanent," my dance guru would always say. But my problem wasn't that I didn't know the steps. I was a bad dancer because I thought too much. And then, out of the blue, it all clicked for me. One moment I was continuing to struggle, and the next, just for five or ten seconds, my brain let go. I was immersed, my body flowing as emotions poured out of me—I didn't remember what happened after. I loved it. It was my meditation. It's why I haven't danced in years, because I didn't want to taint that joy.

But now, I discover the muscle memory hasn't left me. From the moment my right foot steps forward to start the namaskaram for the session, my brain starts to let go. It's awkward and imperfect, but I manage, the bol ringing in my head—*ta thei thei tat aa thei thei tat*—erasing all other thoughts. I push myself to perform one of my old technical pieces, a twenty-minute classical set of progressively more difficult compositions. And as I slip into my flow state, I meet a woman.



CHANDINI

In the fifteenth year of Chandragupta Maurya's rule, a girl was born to an unassuming family in the wealthy town of Supara. The family was comfortable, and that would have been the end of her story, except that the girl was different. Chandini, they called her, and from the start she was drawn to the moonlight. When the stars were bright, she would run down to the river and escape into the trees and fields. Nobody knew where she went or what she did, and although Supara was a large town, people always knew the business of their neighbors. Whispers followed her. Chandini's family did not know what to make of her, but they knew that these goings-on jeopardized her chances of marriage. Her brothers tried to follow her but ended up lost. And whenever her parents checked her bed, she was still sleeping in it. Yet the neighbors spotted her in all manner of places.

There was plenty of magic in Supara. The demons gave their gifts freely in those days, and though some of them were certainly of a malicious disposition, their intentions were as varied as the humans themselves. Some demons had the gift of prophecy and dispensed blessings and curses to those who made proper tribute, others granted their chosen few the strength of Bhima or the skill of Arjuna. There were still others that might coax plants to grow taller, more laden with fruit, or less susceptible to rot. Such power was as regular as breathing, as the monsoon seasons, as existence itself. Chandini's family benefitted from this magic, but they had no great patron.

"What are you doing?" Chandini's mother demanded of her one day.

Chandini wrinkled her brow. "I am building my life."

“You are ruining your life!” her mother said. “You will never marry, and then what? You have never labored in the field or hunched over needle and thread.”

“I am going to be a physician,” Chandini declared.

Her mother snorted. “You? You are not learned, you cannot read, you are a woman. If you think running out into the woods—”

“Peace,” Chandini said, and her mother abruptly forgot what they were speaking about.

Soon, Chandini found herself at the bedsides of women laboring to bring children into the world. She helped women who suffered mysterious bleeding and pain, and no symptom was too small or insignificant for her to try to help. She was not always successful, and slowly it became clear that despite her nocturnal wanderings she had not acquired any sort of healing magic. But she always came and she always tried, and for that reliability she soon became sought after.

Her parents did not approve, but she did not care. She was an adult, and they were ultimately grateful for her help at home. Besides, she was quite perceptive; she seemed able to sense the invisible magic that flitted throughout the town, and this sight brought the family good luck, not through magic itself but through knowledge of it. They began to believe that Chandini was simply very learned, and she was, although, of course, that was not the whole of it.

Chandini’s life may have continued in this way. But Supara was a wealthy town. One day a man came to the door of her home. He was worried and frantic but trying to hide it. This posturing behavior was not uncommon; the other husbands often showed up in a similar state. His fair skin, however, was uncommon, as was the way he called for Chandini by name, suggesting a familiarity, and the way she came running to meet him, blinking and confused.

“Muya?” The name fell from her lips before she could stop it, even though she knew her elderly parents were hovering behind the doorway.

“Chandini!” he exclaimed, and grabbed her by the hand. “We have to go. *Now.*”

“Go where?” she asked. When Chandini spoke, she looked at his abdomen instead of his face, for unlike the others around her, she could see that he was far

shorter than he initially appeared, that his skin was reddish, and that horns sprouted from his head.

“Always with the questions,” he grumbled, but then grew serious. “An army is coming to raid this town. If you want to be safe, then we must leave.”

Chandini drew away from him. “I know you do not think much of my people, Muya, but I do.”

“It will do you no good to die with them,” he hissed. Others gathered around them but perceived only a curious buzzing, Muya’s words too garbled to make out. “There are other humans in other places, if that is what you crave.”

“Muya, do you care about me?” Chandini pressed a hand to her chest. He usually spoke to her with a calculated disinterest as he taught her the ways of wielding his magic and power.

“No,” he said calmly. Then, after a beat, “Yes, of course. You’re my... my—”

“Friend?” Chandini asked, laughing when Muya turned even redder. “Then you will find another way.”

Muya stood still for a moment, considering. “I suppose we could hide this house from notice.”

“But what about my friends, and cousins? I would be sad without them.”

Muya rolled his eyes. “This street then.”

“Then my cousins’ cousins will die.”

“At this rate, you’ll have me hiding this entire town,” Muya said, sarcasm dripping from his voice.

“Yes, that’s the idea,” she said, smiling sweetly.

“You—I—” She saw the moment the fight left him. “I’m not sure that’s possible.”

“Are you a demon of ignorance or not?”

“Even the greatest of my kind could not do it,” he said. “But there may be another way. Come, there is little time.” He grabbed her by the wrist and began to pull her along, leaving her parents and neighbors in a confused haze behind her.

Muya took her along the main path out of the town. “I am going to give you more of my power,” he said. “It will take two of us to achieve this. You have to trust me.”

She snorted.

“Have I ever lied to you?”

“No,” she conceded. “It is amusing all the same. How will this power be any different from the other gifts you have given me?”

“I’m not giving you a *gift*. I’m giving you a part of me. When you die, it will return to me.”

There was no more time to explain further, for just then the promised army came into view, camped in tents around the bend. Chandini gasped when she saw it.

“Follow my lead,” Muya said. “When the time comes, you must pretend to be ill and spread that illness to others. Meanwhile, I will make the town look different than it is.”

“You’re not making any sense!” Chandini felt a sharp pain burrowing into her skull and tried not to cry out as the heat of it settled within her. She felt a sparking at her fingertips, unusual even among the gifts Muya had given her. When she looked up, she saw someone approaching, their garb denoting importance.

“Please, help!” Muya cried out. “Thank the gods, the soldiers of the emperor are here. You will aid us, yes? Oh, we are saved!”

Chandini schooled her face into an expression of desperation, and with a light touch of her gift, ensured that all those around her remained ignorant of her true self.

“Where do you flee from?” the man demanded. Soldiers ran to flank him, and Chandini saw cruelty in their bearing. These men would tear the town apart if allowed.

“Supara,” Muya said. “There is a horrible illness overtaking Supara. That is why you have come, yes? To render aid?”

The man squinted suspiciously. “We have heard of no illness.”

“It starts as a cough, and weakness. But then comes the rash of boils,” Muya told him, horror emanating from his voice. “They do not heal. All who develop them die. Nothing is working, not the old remedies, or the new. They have taken to burning the homes of all afflicted, but my wife and I know there is no safety there. Oh, please, take us to your capital.”

Chandini forced the tears to come, to fall down her face.

“You,” the man ordered a soldier, “go to the gates and tell me if it is true. You two wait here. How fast does the disease progress?”

“Sometimes in a matter of minutes. Other times it takes longer, but it generally spreads quickly,” Muya said. For a moment, even Chandini was taken in by the sheer power of Muya’s speech. Chandini coughed. She did not fake it well, but Muya’s power—no, her power—fell thick around her, and when she lifted her hand to her mouth, a boil appeared on the back of it. “No,” Muya whispered. “No!”

Just then the soldier came running back. “Sire, there is smoke rising from the town! There are dead bodies outside the gates. It must be as they said.”

The man flinched away from Chandini and Muya. Chandini coughed again and willed the soldier to be ignorant of his own body, to think himself sick, and in a moment he doubled over, coughing alongside her.

The others recoiled and drew their tunics over their faces.

“Stay back!” one of the men shouted.

Chandini collapsed on the ground and willed the soldier unconscious as well. Muya crouched over her body, pretending to tend to her.

“I can’t believe it worked,” she whispered.

“There is a price,” he said. “What I have given you—you are more like me now. Not a demon, but... you must be careful in the mortal world. You may hurt someone.”

“A blessing and a curse,” she said.

“I’m sorry,” he murmured. “It was all I could think of.” With Muya’s face tipped close and his power now hers, Chandini could see the whole of him. His truth was striking.

Chandini looks right at me. She smiles, as though she knows I’m there. The rest of the scene is frozen, everything else fading away.

We are strong, she says, eyes red and shining. *Choose action.*



8

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DEMONOLOGY

It's embarrassing, but after just an hour of dancing, my legs are too tired to continue. I remember when I could dance for hours, performing full shows for three nights in a row with no problem. But now, I can barely make it through a warm-up tatkar and basic tukdas before my feet started to ache. By the time I finish my main set of todas, my arms burn from being held up for so long. I stumble through a namaskaram and collapse on the floor. My body is overheated even though my apartment is cold, and I'm covered in sweat. I should shower, but I probably won't be able to get up for at least an hour. Now that I've stopped dancing, my brain starts thinking again. Chandini saved her whole town with the help of Muya. Muya, who just left my apartment. Chandini seemed to look right at me at the end, watching me watching her life. *Choose action*, she said. As if it's that simple. My whole body hurts and I've definitely got blisters on my feet, but there is something tingling beneath my skin, a current that has been moving through me ever since I touched the statue. Magic, Muya would have me believe. Demon magic.

I search Apasmara again, thoroughly this time, and come up more empty-handed than I'd like. If this weren't my real life, I would think it was pretty funny that we know so little about the demon of ignorance. I learn that he's a dwarflike creature (the Muya I've seen most definitely is not), represents not just ignorance but greed and epilepsy, and has some sort of astrological significance.

Given that I have a distaste for astrology as it is, anything requiring the decoding of ancient Indian star charts is definitely a dead end. I call the Art Institute research desk for a bit more clarity, getting bumped around a bit before someone says, “Oh, you want *provenance*.”

After spending more time on hold, a bright, female-sounding voice joins the line. “Provenance research desk. Who do I have the pleasure of speaking to?”

“Uh, N-Nina,” I say, panicking and providing the name of one of the nurses at the clinic instead. “Hi. I have a question about a statue.”

“My name is Brittany,” she says. “Happy to help! Do you know the name of the piece?”

“It’s a Nataraja statue,” I say. “N-A-T-A-R-A-J-A. I’ve seen it in the museum for years, in the South Asian art exhibit.”

“Hmm.” I hear the clacking of keys, before she continues, “That’s odd. I know exactly the statue you’re talking about, but I’m not seeing it in our system.”

“Was it sold?” I ask.

“Even if it was sold, it should be in our system,” she says, and I can almost hear her frown. “There’s no record of it.”

“Oh, well, never mind then.”

“Can I put you on another brief hold?”

“Of course,” I say. I hope she’s not going to cause a fuss. I’d rather not call any more attention to the situation. But after several minutes, Brittany returns, sounding slightly out of breath.

“Thanks for waiting, Nina. I work this job to make a little extra money, but I’m a postdoc and know how to do archival research. I never get asked to use my skills, so I got a bit carried away. Weirdly, the file on this piece wasn’t there, either. I don’t know, someone could have pulled it for something.” She barely pauses to take a breath. “So I checked our donor files, and I found it, first try. I don’t have any information on where it originally came from, but if you have a pen and paper, I can give you the name of the donor, at least?”

I scramble to grab a notepad. “Go for it.”

She gives me a name that sounds like old oil baron money, and I double-check the spelling. “Thank you so much,” I say. “Sincerely. This piece means so

much to me, and I... it means a lot that you went to all this trouble.”

“Happy to help!” Brittany says. “I had fun! Feel free to call back if you have any more questions.”

“I definitely will,” I say, although I sincerely doubt the Art Institute can answer questions about demons. “Thank you. Have a great day.”

Immediately after hanging up, I remember that I never called Aai to explain what happened this morning. She’s probably about an hour away from coming down here to verify I’m fine with her own two eyes.

Sure enough, she picks up so fast the phone doesn’t even get the chance to ring. “I was wondering when you would call, especially after your mysterious texts.”

“Sorry, Aai. I’ve been busy.”

“Have you been eating?”

I roll my eyes. “Yes, I just had a sandwich.”

“So what are you busy with?”

“I was actually... practicing Kathak.”

Aai is silent for a few seconds, and then asks, “How was it?”

I hear her barely controlled glee, and feel a bit bad for telling a half-truth. “It was nice. Very nice. I’m weak, though.”

“That’s okay, that’s okay, I’m just—it makes me so happy to hear that you enjoyed it. Good for you.” Aai sounds like she might be tearing up.

It took me six months to finish physical therapy after my accident and get cleared to dance again. But I couldn’t bring myself to do it. Dancing belonged to a past Nisha, an ambitious Nisha, a Nisha who could rely on the world to make sense. I couldn’t sully Kathak with my apathy. Aai kept suggesting I take it up again, until one day she gave up.

“The dancing made me think about our old stories,” I say. “About rakshasas and asuras and all. It made me think about when I was a kid, how I was so scared of Ravana that I thought he might jump out of the bushes to grab me...”

Aai laughs. “There are plenty of people who still believe, especially back in India, that rakshasas are real. And I’m sure some still claim that the reason Hindus are so learned and powerful is because we conquered rakshasas and

asuras.” I hear the click of the gas stove turning on and smile to myself. Aai must be making chai.

“Ah, more nationalist talking points.” I sigh.

“Come on, Nisha. Not everything is some political conspiracy. These were stories passed down through generations. I heard that my great-great-great—”

She cuts herself off abruptly. Aai almost never talks about her family. I speak to her parents through WhatsApp on birthdays and Diwali, but I know nothing about her childhood, her cousins, her village. All I know is that she came to America when she was eight months pregnant and built our life herself. And I know her family must have kicked her out—because of me. So before she can become too sad, I joke, “So if there *was* a demon under my bed?”

Aai gives me a small, forced laugh. It’s a real question, but she’s right that it would make a poor joke. “Well, I’m always telling you to pray. Maybe if you did, you’d be safe... I can ask around at mandir about adult dance groups for you. You could come with me?”

I don’t go to mandir anymore and she knows it. But I also know that if I truly am dealing with rakshasas and other demons, I should visit. It can’t hurt.

“I’m kind of busy right now, but in a week or two?”

“That sounds good, baccha,” she says. “That sounds good.” I can practically hear Aai’s wonder and happiness, and I hate myself a little more.

—

Later that night, after I’ve run a pretty lackluster volunteer training and am unable to sleep, I find myself falling down an internet rabbit hole about demons and demonology. On a poorly designed blog that looks straight out of the aughts, I read a pull quote that catches my interest: *Beware of false prophets, who come to you in sheep’s clothing, but inwardly they are ravenous wolves. You will know them by their fruits. Do men gather grapes from thornbushes or figs from thistles?—Matthew 7:15.* I feel compelled to investigate further, although I cringe at the animated angels framing the text. And because I have no self-preservation instincts, I use the find function to search for “abortion.” Sure enough, there are

quite a few comments about seeing demons at abortion clinics, but nothing useful. So I start reading the comments from the top.

I saw a woman, her face as dark as night, with horns emerging from her enormous hair. I saw her forked tongue.

Holy racism! Just underneath it, a different user, anonfarmer47, wrote:

Nobody believes me, but I met a demon at a crossroads. Not a literal crossroads, but a fork in my life. I did not know which path to take, and he appeared to me at night. He seemed to be a normal man at first. I thought he was there to ask for directions, but instead he said I had called him. Something about him pricked at my skin. A huge oil & gas company had already sent a few different representatives my way, the lone holdout on my block, to convince me to sell my house. I was standing in the way of what promised to be millions, maybe. I told him to go away, said I wasn't interested in making any deals with the company. And he said to make a deal with him instead, that he'd make all my dreams come true. I wasn't sure if he was a competitor or what, so I just laughed and asked for a million bucks. Next thing I know, he's spreading his hands, and I swear to God, his eyes flashed red. There was a crack of lightning in the cloudless sky. Behind him, his shadow expanded.

I am a God-fearing man. I ran inside faster than you could say the Lord's Prayer. I know that I saw the devil, and worse, I may have forged a deal with him. I researched frantically how to release myself from such a contract. But in time, when nothing happened, my wife convinced me that it was a dream. We stayed in that house, and I believed her. I believed her up until the day she dropped dead, of no cause at all. The doctors could find nothing wrong with her. There was no point in being in that house without her. She was the reason I had stayed, she had been the one who loved the place. I accepted the company's offer and moved to the city.

On the day I moved into my new apartment, there was a knock at the door. It was the devil. I made to close the door, but he held out a hand and stopped me. He passed me an envelope, then he disappeared before my very eyes. Inside the envelope was bank information for an account in my name, with one million dollars deposited in it.

I am shocked to reach the end of anonfarmer47's story. Underneath it, the comments are skeptical.

Demons don't behave like that. They don't work for corporations, and they don't keep their promises.

I'm sure it was traumatic to lose your wife. Perhaps seek therapy.

The devil doesn't give out millions, or everyone would make a deal.

I feel so angry on behalf of this man that I have to take a few deep breaths to quell my body's fight-or-flight response. I'm scared. That man's story doesn't prove anything, but his descriptions of a banal-looking man with an aura of wrongness making mysterious offers hits too close to home. I don't know what to make of it, but I am starting to realize just how much trouble I am in.



IF EVERYBODY'S SPECIAL

That night I dream of something far more sinister than the persistent strangers I've met over the last few days. Dark and looming, the demon in my nightmare is but a shadow.

I will speak plainly. You have power but no need of it. If you give me your magic, I will repay you in the currency of your world.

I feel the sentiment echo around me and flinch away from the sound, but when the words touch my skin, they possess the soft caress of satin sheets.

"Who are you?" I ask.

A demon, of course. The shadow billows, its amorphous form constantly reshaping. I do not wish to add to your many burdens. I am offering to lighten your load. The power you carry weighs you down.

"That's convenient."

I intend to be honest with you. The process will be painful. But I can give you money, influence, whatever you would like as compensation for the brief moment of pain.

"Did you send that man to my door? Daniel something? And the ones around the clinic?"

Yes. Humans briefly under my spell. Generally useful, but I can see now that you are more sophisticated.

"Flattery will get you nowhere."

It is simply the truth. I have no need to lie. You will give me your powers because you are intelligent enough to understand that it is the right choice. There will be pain, but you will bear it. And then you will have what you want. If you do not willingly give it to me, then there will be more pain, lasting pain, and no reward. The choice is simple.

“This is a dream,” I say.

I will soon send you a sign. You will recognize the truth.

I step back in alarm. “How—”

If you do not give in, I will destroy you.

“So fucking what?” I mutter aloud to myself as my eyelids flutter open. I’m surprised at my own vehemence. Some part of me believes that I should have died years ago, that nothing matters. But the bit of me that still cares wills my heart to beat faster, my brain to flood with adrenaline, anything to snap out of the apathy. Despite my apathy’s best efforts, I roll out of bed and go to work.

—

I get in early enough to arrive as Dr. Levy pulls up.

“We on for lunch?” Dr. Levy asks. We don’t usually have a lot of reason to interact, but we both work the skeleton shift on Mondays—a lot of clinic staff have the day off, since we’re open on Saturdays, but some of us alternate Saturdays to pick up Mondays. Since neither of us has time to actually eat a real meal, we duck into the empty patient room whenever Dr. Levy has a brief moment to share granola bars and chat.

“Of course,” I tell her. “Anything I should be aware of?”

Dr. Levy shakes her head, then groans when a bus arrives in front of the clinic. She gestures me inside, and we both wave at Diane.

“There’s a protest bus out front,” I say as we pass by.

“Just what we needed.” Diane sighs.

Dr. Levy’s jaw jumps. “They’re targeting blue-state clinics now until they can get a national abortion ban passed. They’ve already closed just about all the clinics in states where they can manage it. They’re dangerous. Be safe out there, okay, Nisha? You kids think you’re so invulnerable, but I’ve heard stories.”

“Better me than a patient,” I say flippantly.

Dr. Levy’s hand grabs my wrist. “Better a patient gets turned away and you both leave with your lives.”

“Dr. Levy, what is it?”

“I don’t want to scare you, but I have a friend on the East Coast who said one of their escorts was threatened with a gun this morning. You don’t know what these people are willing to do. I know we all focus on the patients, but your life is important, too.”

Muya seemed to think I was in danger, and now a very sane, very *good* person is warning me of the same. Aaron walks in before I can respond, and I’m too embarrassed to say anything emotional in front of him, of all people.

“I’ll catch you at lunch?” I ask her instead.

Aaron opens his mouth as if to say something to me, but Dr. Levy raises her hand. His mouth snaps shut, and I can see the tension in his shoulders. Maybe they’ve been having conflict—maybe he’s showing his true colors.

“Sure. I should have extra time today with this one doing the charting.”

I can’t help but give Aaron a little victory glance as I leave. I *adore* Dr. Levy.

—

I don my vest and go stand outside in a patch of early morning sunlight to stay warm. The protesters look a bit fuzzy for some reason, and I squint at them, forcing my vision to clarify. Thank gods for sunglasses—I don’t want any of them thinking they have my attention. After a moment, the blur resolves into something far odder: I can perceive a slight aura enveloping them, an unseen force that seems to make them just a little louder. A little bigger. A little scarier. The protesters are already big and loud and scary, and they definitely do successfully deter a few patients without the help of magic. But they haven’t managed to put the clinic out of business yet, and I won’t let some demon supercharge them into becoming a real threat. I think of Chandini, of Muya, and wonder if I could lift the magic off them or neutralize it somehow with my own.

I envision the aura physically separating from the protesters' bodies and dissipating into the air. Nothing happens. Okay, fair enough. I focus on the protesters themselves, concentrating on sending them a message the way I did with the little boy. *You don't know why you're here. Forget your purpose.* I can feel the magic within me itching under my skin, building to an ache at the center of my forehead, but I can't direct it. It seemed to spill from Chandini with ease, but I guess I'm just incompetent.

Our first patient of the day approaches on foot, and I abandon my fanciful idea and rush to help her. She winces at the noise. As a short Black woman hunched in on herself, she's definitely an ideal target. I dart forward, putting myself between her and the antis. She gives me a grateful smile, which looks remarkably similar to a grimace, and I see that her eyes are watering.

"They're going to dismember your baby!" someone shouts. "Do you want them to experiment on your baby's parts?"

She flinches. "That's not true, right?"

"Not at all," I assure her.

"It's just, I saw that video—"

"It was doctored footage," I say. I've seen it too, back when it surprised me that the antis were willing to manipulate video footage and lie. The woman is looking up at me, eyes wide, so I fall back on the facts. "If the pregnancy is far enough along that there's more there than just a clump of cells, the remains are properly disposed of in accordance with the law. There are pretty strict guidelines about this, and even if there weren't, we wouldn't use anything we took from your body without your explicit consent. A large proportion of late-term abortions are for wanted babies who didn't survive. In those cases, patients often want—and are allowed to have—funerals."

"Okay." She takes a deep breath and keeps moving forward.

Another protester shouts about Black Lives Matter, and how we're killing Black lives.

"I didn't think I'd hear them say that," she says, looking over her shoulder. She adds, in a whisper, "I heard that the people who started abortions wanted to eliminate Black people."

“I’m happy to give you more information,” I tell her. I’m not sure if she wants a lecture from me, but she nods, so I let myself sink into the history. “Abortion has existed since ancient times. There have always been people who got pregnant and didn’t want to have a child, and midwives who knew how to end those pregnancies. It’s true that abortion was banned after the Civil War by people who were worried that white people weren’t having enough babies compared to Black people and immigrants. And it is also true that one of the women who helped found Planned Parenthood wanted to stop Black people from having children. I think that horrible history is less about abortion and more about how this country has always treated Black people—and I’m sure you don’t need me to tell you that.”

“Yeah,” she says softly.

“The important thing is,” I continue after we’ve walked to the front door, far enough away from the antis that they aren’t so loud anymore, “you don’t have to do anything you don’t want to do.”

She curls an arm around her stomach. “My parents gave up everything so I could have a better life. I can’t throw it all away just because I got knocked up.”

“Okay,” I say. “Is that what you want?”

“I think I’d be a good mom,” she tells me. “I really want to be a mom.”

“You don’t have to decide anything today.” I nod my head toward the door but don’t open it. “We won’t charge you if you choose to leave instead and think about it. Or we can do a pregnancy checkup if you—”

“No. I can’t be a good mom right now. It’s hard, because, what if this is my only chance? But I still want to do this. They just... got in my head.” She pushes the door open and looks at me, a real smile on her face. For a moment, as sometimes happens, I wonder what Aai’s life might have been like if she had made this choice. “Thank you.”

After that, the patients pass by in a blur. One tells me, with a trembling apology, that she’s not here for an abortion but is miscarrying. I want to tell her the distinction doesn’t matter to us, but I swallow it down. Whatever she’s going through is more important than some stupid educational moment. At one point, Aaron steps outside to offer me hand warmers.

“Are these bugged?” I ask, only half joking. He presses his lips into a line.

“I was just trying to be nice. Don’t take them, then.”

I snatch them out of his hands.

Around lunchtime, an older volunteer named Pamela arrives to cover the escorting just as Dr. Levy pokes out her head, looking for me. We go to our usual room, and I dig into my purse for some sweets I packed to offer Dr. Levy.

“An excellent lunch,” she says. “Now, what’s on your mind? You’ve seemed a little down recently.”

“I’ve been thinking about the bigger picture. I guess I’m wondering if you think things can get better. If there’s something we can do? What would you do if you had a magic wand?”

“Do you have a magic wand?” Dr. Levy asks with a laugh. She pops an entire burfi into her mouth. “I assume you’re asking because you’re thinking about law school again? If so, good. Every clinic that stays open because a good lawyer is on their side means hundreds more women who’ll get to make their own choices about their bodies. As for things getting *better*, that’s well above my pay grade. Plenty of folks talk about state-by-state strategies, but I don’t know that there’s a *Roe* moment in our future unless we win back the federal government and the Supreme Court changes. But what do I know? I’m just a doctor.”

The more she speaks, the more my heart sinks. I was hoping that the silver lining to the chaos of the past few days would be using this power to live out my fantasies of changing the country.

“Sorry,” Dr. Levy says when she sees my expression. She’s moved on to her Lärabar now. “I know that’s a depressing answer. Everything is depressing recently. I heard that our new alderman has soured on the clinic. Sees it as an eyesore and a nuisance. We’re going to have our hands full just keeping this place open.”

Abortion clinics all operate by the grace of their surrounding communities. There’s still stigma, and protesters, and danger, and traffic that come with them. They’re not like restaurants or bars, either. People get in and get out. So sure, we’re not the most popular business in the neighborhood, but we’ve never had serious issues with the alderman. And every election, both alderman candidates have been pro-choice—it’s a nonissue in Chicago.

As if reading my thoughts, Dr. Levy continues, “Yeah. Of course he’s pro-choice, but in his own neighborhood?” She scoffs. “Everyone’s an abortion NIMBY, especially with the anti groups making lucrative offers for abortion clinics’ property. What will happen will happen, but you’ll be fine. You’re a bright woman.”

“It’s not me I’m worried about,” I say softly.

“I know,” she says. “Nobody here worries about themselves.” She tosses her wrapper in the trash and heads out, leaving me sitting on the edge of the exam table, head spinning.

I can’t think of a way to use Chandini’s approach right now. It’s not like I can convince every anti-choice protester that we’re actually doing good work. But maybe there’re others like Chandini, waiting to be found. Suddenly I can’t wait to get home so I can try again.

—

I begin the warm-up tatkar, slowly speeding up until my mind lets go of anxieties and thoughts in favor of reveling in the sensations. I stretch my arms out at different angles and ground myself in the stamp of my feet. My hands, and each of their fingers, extend and relax in time with the music, and I have never felt more connected to the world.

I see flashes of a tall, dark girl. Broad-shouldered and strong. The music switches to the next song in my playlist, a set of natwaris and paltas. My body is moving, and my mind—it sees.



TARA

Tara was born on a moonless night, and so her parents named her for the stars. It was a time of stability. Their town was not prosperous, but they lived near the coast and did not want for food. Change was coming, though. Everyone knew it. The Gupta emperor was weak. He was dying of an old wound and had no children. The empire's hold on the west was already tenuous, and it was likely that some of the greater powers in the region would make their bid when the last Gupta died.

Perhaps it would have been wise for each city and town and village to fortify themselves, but they were not used to living as islands. Instead, they sought to strengthen their ties to each other. Tributes went out and came in from every direction, and so did people. Those with demon-granted gifts accompanied the caravans, seeking to persuade, or predict, or stir up trouble, according to their interests.

Tara had been gifted with the ability to see the truth. When a demon came to town singularly focused on finding her, she was only five years old. Her parents were half afraid, for sometimes the demons came to hunt, and the townsfolk fought back with sword and fire. Sometimes the demons simply passed through, and the townsfolk housed them with watchful eyes. But her parents had reason to hope, for sometimes the demons came seeking a child with whom to share their gifts, and the townsfolk prayed for something useful. This demon, Muya, slept only two nights under their roof, claiming he had once been well acquainted with their town, though no such record existed. He saw Tara playing, and the next day took her aside for a quiet conversation, after which he passed a hand over her head and left. When asked, Tara said only that Muya had

promised to help her to see. In time it became apparent that what Tara could see were demons and their influence. By adulthood, she could use her power to see even the barest hint of magic in the world.

Tara's town was governed by an elected council, led by a chief who she often accompanied on business. And so it was she alone who saw the veil enveloping a ship that came into the harbor of a bustling port city. There was something wrong about it. Something sick. She tugged on the chief's sleeve.

"We must go, uncle," she said. "Now." The chief had known her since she was a small girl, and so he did not argue. They left that same day.

"What is it?" he asked as they approached their home.

"Plague," she said. She hadn't recognized it right away, but now she knew it with horrified certainty—the gods' hand of death ready to fall over them. It did not matter which Gupta emperor took the throne next, for they might not be alive to hear about it.

His face paled. "Are you sure?"

"I am sure."

"Stay close, then," he said. "You must speak to the council."

The elders were convened that same night. The chief had seen Tara's panic as well as her resolve, and he believed her. But he could not outvote the others. Tara explained herself with a shaking voice. She was still nervous about what she had seen. Her family had produced many physicians and midwives, but she did not have the stomach for it. Seeing suffering affected her too strongly.

"Are you sure?" an elder probed. She did not know Tara well but had always been kind in passing. "Perhaps you overreacted. We know you have a weaker constitution. The city can be overwhelming. There is no shame in admitting it."

"I am sure," Tara said. She did not sound sure, even to herself.

"We cannot afford to close ourselves off. We will make ourselves a target. People will think we have something worth protecting."

Tara took a breath to steady herself, remembering the pranayama her grandmother had taught her. She pulled a breath into her stomach before releasing it, and raised herself to her full, substantial height.

"I assure you all, there will be no wars when the plague comes. Only death. We have a chance to protect ourselves. We have walls, we have a gate. We have

stores of food, and farms within the walls. This chance will not come again. I am sure, already, it is spreading in the dark parts of the coastal cities.”

She could tell that she had managed to convince them with the firmness of her words, and she enjoyed the way they listened to her. Sometimes, in her dreams, she saw other women, strong and powerful. She felt their touch as the vote came in unanimous. The town closed.

For the first few days after the announcement, the townspeople walked with their heads bowed in fear, flinching away from each other as though their friends and neighbors might carry the illness. Then they seemed annoyed at this new regime. Everyone could still live and work, but they had enjoyed regular passage through the gates that were now closed. Ten days later, a messenger came to the gates. The guards would not admit him.

“So you have heard,” the messenger said, shouting so those on the wall might hear him. “I come from the coast. An illness is fast spreading, and your people should be on watch for it. At first it seems like any illness, then it takes an awful turn. Black growths sprout from the body, and no Ayurvedic treatment can heal it. Even the best physicians, those who have been blessed to close wounds with their bare hands, cannot do it. They say it is the work of a mighty demon, here to destroy us.”

“How is it spread?” the chief called, having been summoned.

“Nobody knows,” the messenger replied.

“So you would risk this town, coming from an infected city?”

The messenger shook his head. “It is everywhere. It must already be in your town, even if you don’t know. And I am healthy, at least.”

“Thank you,” the chief said. Supplies were lowered to the messenger, and he was gone.

That night, the townspeople checked each other anxiously for fever, for growths. They all looked at Tara like a blessing. Like a woman of power.

Messengers began to arrive from all directions. It was as though a black wave of death was sweeping across the empire, stopping only at the walls of the town. First it was scores dead, then hundreds. Then thousands. Then the messengers stopped coming, and the refugees arrived instead. They were fleeing the plague and thought themselves healthy, had come to beg for admission. Although it

pained the town to turn their own cousins away, they did. Surplus food lay untouched in the fields beyond the wall, and they offered it in shouted words from a careful distance. Then the refugees stopped coming, too.

A month went by like this, then another. The people began to wonder whether the outside world might be safe. Whether the plague might have passed. They grew weary of eating rationed stores and asked to return to their normal lives, to leave the walls of the town. The council refused, arguing that if the land was safe once more, there would be messengers and convoys and celebrations. But no walls hold forever.

One day, a young woman disappeared from the town in the middle of the night. She had been Tara's friend, but since the town closed its borders had not spoken to her. The woman's sister had left the town when she had married some years back, and Tara knew with a sinking heart that she had run away to check on her. Every day, Tara walked the perimeter of the wall, searching for her friend. Five days later, her friend returned. She looked as though she had aged ten years in her short time away.

"It's horrible," she called up to Tara. "My sister survived, but her children and husband are dead. My nieces and nephews are dead."

"I am sorry," Tara said. "I am so sorry."

"It seems to be getting better. But you are right, it's not yet over. I am sorry I doubted you."

Tara swallowed. It was hard to look at her friend. The chief approached, touching Tara gently on the shoulder.

"I do not know what to do," he confessed. "She is one of ours. Should we admit her?"

Tara knew. She knew. But still, she looked, because she had to be certain. The disease hung over her friend. It was faint, a haze that her eyes wanted to glance away from, but it was there. Her friend saw the verdict in Tara's face.

"No. No! I feel fine. I'm fine!" she pleaded.

Tara's eyes pricked with tears. She could not bear to think of her friend going through this disease—and alone. She wanted so badly to admit her into the town. Some people survived. Perhaps her friend could, too, after a period of isolation. But when she looked behind her at the town she loved, and thought of

the hundreds of people who depended on her to keep them safe, it was not possible.

“I’m sorry,” she said. “Give her food and water. If she remains healthy for a week, we can admit her.”

“Tara!” her friend called. “Please!”

Tara came back the next day, because she had made the choice and had to bear the consequences. Her friend was fine. The next day, she was still fine, though angry. But the next day, her friend’s eyes were bright with fever.

“I’m sorry,” Tara called, but her friend did not know who she was.

The following day, her friend was gone. The guards said she had become lucid in the night and walked away toward the forest to die. She wanted Tara to know she forgave her.

Tara would never forgive herself. She went home, where the chief was waiting for her, having already heard the news.

“You made the right decision,” he said. “Whatever regrets you might have—”

“I don’t regret it.”

The chief did not look surprised. “You will make a fine chief one day.”

Tara looks right at me. She nods as though she knows I’m there.

We are unyielding, she says. Choose hardness.



10

GILDED AGE

Tara's story is quieter than Chandini's, but even more impressive to me. Her sorrow ushers me through four uneventful days wreathed in a thick cloud of despair. I spend my nights in bed, scouring the internet for information. Although there are plenty of novels and films about making deals with demons and stealing magic, there's not really any definitive how-to guide for battling real-life demons or saving your abortion clinic. Academic and library databases are similarly a bust. Muya hasn't contacted me at all either, leaving me without any real sources of information. On Saturday, I lie in bed for hours, becoming increasingly paranoid, but when Aai calls, I pretend I'm fine and instead tell her brightly that I danced again.

"Even if you don't want to come to mandir this weekend, you should at least do your prarthana," Aai says.

"Okay."

"You can do it while falling asleep, Nisha. It's not a matter of belief. It will be meditative for you. It will help your anxiety and make you sleep better."

"Right." I can't help it, I'm annoyed. Praying has not helped me once in two decades, but that never stops her from suggesting it over and over again. We both know that she wants me to pray because she's worried I'm angering the gods.

"Don't be rude," Aai says. "I'm only trying to help you! You're sad all the time, you never want to go out, you eat badly, and you don't work out. What did

you eat today?”

“I microwaved a frozen meal.” I know that’s only going to make things worse, and not for the first time I wish I could tell outright lies to Aai.

“You see?” Aai snaps. “I could be cooking for you, but no! If I suggest something good, you just start getting mad instead of even trying it out. Fine! Be unhappy! What do I care?”

“Your stupid little prayers aren’t going to cure me! Shouldn’t you be happy that I’m doing something good for the world? Doesn’t that matter at all?”

“Are you happy?” Aai shoots back, louder than is necessary.

“That doesn’t matter. I’m telling you praying won’t fix me. When will you let this go?”

There’s a long silence on the other end, during which I check my notifications. JJ texted me.

You free tonight?

There’s no way I’m up for a party or gala or whatever fancy event JJ is inevitably about to invite me to.

I’ve been invited to a fundraiser at the Art Institute!

Want to come?

We used to love going there, remember?

“I have to go,” Aai says at last. “I have a function to get to. Have fun lying in your bed.”

I make the decision then. It’s been days, and the dream-demon’s promised sign has failed to materialize. I should be safe now. “I’m going to a function, too, actually. A party.” There’s acid in my voice, and I know Aai hears it.

Even so, she says, “That’s really great, Nisha. I’m just trying to help.”

I take a deep breath. “I know. Love you, Aai.”

“Love you, baccha.”

I hang up and scrub my eyes. A chance to return to the place where this all started is hard to pass up. In fact, I should have thought about going back there to investigate sooner.

I'll be there! Excited to be your hot date!

JJ sends me the two-women-dancing emoji, and I roll out of bed to try to find an appropriate outfit. I manage to find an old dress that I bought before the accident that somehow still fits. Floor-length, green satin, with a semi-daring back. I slip on black leather sneakers underneath, since there's no way I'm walking around in uncomfortable shoes all night. I intend to make full use of the Art Institute.

When I arrive, walking up alongside fancy cars in the valet line and taxis, I feel excited despite myself. I've never experienced the Art Institute after hours. JJ texted that she's running a little late, which is very in character—in fact, I was planning on it and arrived earlier than we agreed so that I'd have some time to myself.

I head directly for the South Asian exhibit, which is even emptier than I last saw it, and search for the statue. I don't really know what I'm hoping to discover, but if there's a way to stuff Muya back into the statue and undo everything that's happened, I need to know. It looks like they've finished reorganizing, but after a few laps, I can confirm that the statue is no longer there.

"Looking for something?" a voice whispers in my ear. I whirl around, instinctively bringing up my hands in defense, and smack Muya in the face.

"What?" He sounds wounded.

"Don't sneak up on women!" I snap. "Or anybody! Didn't anybody teach you manners?"

"I'm a demon," he hisses.

We glare at each other for a moment before I relent. "I was looking for the statue."

"I destroyed it," he says immediately.

For a moment I think he's joking, but his tone is serious. "You *what*?"

“The day you freed me. I used my powers to disguise the theft, and smashed it to bits. Then I threw the pieces in the river. I am not getting trapped again.”

“So you were the one who wiped it from the museum’s records?”

He shrugs. “Humans. Very easy to fool.”

“Is the statue the only thing that can trap you?”

His eyes narrow. “Why do you want to know?”

“Shouldn’t I know the weaknesses of my allies?”

“Are we allies?”

“I saw Chandini,” I say in response. I’m studying his face for his reaction, and I get one. A slight twitch of his mouth, a widening of his eyes. His body tenses.

“Very good,” he replies at last. “What did you see?”

“She turned away an army.”

He seems to relax. “Ah. She was the best of my chosen.”

“Not Tara?” I ask.

“I barely knew her. I’d learned to stay away from your kind by then. Maybe you came here to look for the statue, but our connection... it has nothing to do with that. It was fate that brought you to me. The statue was but a tool.” Muya seems almost bored.

“So then what are you doing here?”

“The same thing as you, I imagine. Admiring the rich and powerful while searching these artifacts for anything that could help.”

“Help with what?”

“Taking my power back.”

My mind catches up to his implication a moment later. “How, by force?”

“It’s not personal. I was trapped by humans. I’d rather be in charge of my own destiny.”

“Why tell me all of this?”

Muya’s glance sweeps over the room and he shakes his head, but before I can push further, I hear, “Nish! There you are! I knew I would find you here.”

“Later,” I hiss to Muya, since I definitely do not want him to meet any of my friends.

I turn my attention to JJ. She looks absolutely amazing in a bejeweled blush halter dress, her hair in an updo.

“You look so good!” she lies.

I roll my eyes. “Thanks, but that’s nothing compared to...” I gesture to her outfit. “You’re radiant.”

She grins, her pale cheeks coloring slightly. “Well, have you met anyone interesting?”

“You know how I am with faces,” I tell her. “I wouldn’t know if I had!”

“Well, this is the fundraiser for WomenCare. It’s a national foundation that raises money to help poor women access healthcare and combat maternal mortality.”

“I don’t think I’ve heard of them before,” I say.

“It’s one of those rich-people things,” JJ says with a laugh as though she is not a rich person too. For years I didn’t realize that she was wealthy, because she liked to pretend that she was as befuddled by the moneyed as the rest of us. “Foundations that people only ever talk about at galas. They don’t do the work directly, just take in money and send it on.”

“Ah.” That is in fact a rich-people thing. People are going to drop obscene, greater-than-my-yearly-paycheck amounts of money tonight. Maybe I can make a few connections.

“Um, but maybe don’t mention the clinic tonight,” JJ adds with a wince. “The work we do is great, and most people here would think so, too, but there are some older folks who we don’t want to alienate, yeah?”

“Yeah. Of course.” I’m reminded how JJ always saw the world in shades of gray. I appreciated it in college when everyone was still learning who they were. I try to appreciate it again now.

She elbows me gently in the side. “Hey, don’t be sour about it. Relax, have fun! You love this place. We’re all dressed up. They’re going to serve us little snacks on trays.”

I smile despite myself. “Oh, horse devourers?”

“Are you—you’re kidding, right?” I crack up, and JJ starts snickering as well. “Oh my god. Horse devourers. I’m going to use that on my mom sometime.”

It feels good to laugh like kids in the middle of the Art Institute. For a second, it’s like being back in college. We fold over onto each other, cackling, and

just when we've managed to catch our breath, a passing server carrying a tray makes us lose it all over again.

—

After JJ and I have wandered through the Greco-Roman sculptures and eaten a variety of delicious horse devourers, someone grabs her arm, and I find myself as alone as one can be among the glitzy Midwestern wealthy, which is to say, pretty alone. I take a deep breath. As always, I feel so much better than I would have lying in my bed, and I make a mental note to thank JJ for getting me out. But while my mind is clearer, something about the room feels... off. A fuzziness has fallen over the crowd, one I recognize as magical influence. I take a step forward, intending to find Muya and put a stop to whatever he's doing, when someone cuts me off.

"Nisha Kulkarni, right?"

A portly, balding, relatively nondescript man in his fifties or sixties stands in front of me.

"Who told you?" I ask, trying to make it sound like a joke.

"You know who," he says. "He told you that he would send you a sign, and he always keeps his word. A good sign for a potential partnership, right?" I take a step back and collide with the wall. Nobody else seems to notice us, but I'm not sure I can run away without attracting attention. I scrutinize him more closely and notice the aura emanating from his center, a deep choking purple oozing around him. The whole room is cloaked in it. I have no idea what it's doing, but I'm sure it's nothing good. "Do not fear. So long as you give him—"

"I don't understand. How did you find me?" I cast about for JJ, but she is nowhere to be found.

He laughs. "You're very predictable. He knows you. And, of course, your power is a beacon."

"Fuck," I whisper, and he wrinkles his nose.

"No need for that kind of language," he says, his voice grating. "He understands that you need more information. You have power, a demon's power. You cannot use it, not really, because you are a human. He is a demon,

and he would like it. If you give him what he wants, he will never hurt you or your loved ones.”

“He’s not even here himself. Is he scared? He must be pretty weak if he’s so desperate for the power I got without even trying.” I know I shouldn’t antagonize him, but I can’t stop myself from masking my terror with bravado.

“He may want your power, but he is not weak.” There’s a flash of anger in the man’s eyes, but despite my veneer of confidence, the only thing I feel is all-consuming, thought-devouring fear. “Sooner or later, you will give in. Money? Influence? Love? Simply name your desire. Alternatively, I’d advise you to remember that you have no defenses against him, and he will destroy your life.”

It’s not a great villain monologue, and something about it gives me strength. “My life is already destroyed.”

“You ought to take this seriously.” He grabs my wrist. “What do you *want*?”

My eyes close, and I see the clinic with no protesters outside it. I see a woman smiling and waving as she enters. And then I see myself smiling back at her. There’s a lightness about this version of me, one that I recognize from years ago.

“Whatever you want, it could be yours,” he whispers.

With his words, the scene turns sour, wrong. I see it for what it is: a veneer. A demon can’t fix depression. I yank my hand away.

“I am taking this seriously. I’m not giving you anything.”

“Your funeral,” he says. When he steps away from me, I start feeling sick. The haze in the room intensifies, and I stumble forward, about to fall over, when someone catches my arm.

“Are you okay?” they ask.

“I’m fine,” I reply as I search for an exit.

“What brings you here?” she asks. I almost laugh at the inanity of the question.

“My friend invited me. I love the Art Institute.”

“Are you affiliated with the cause?”

“Um, not exactly.” I remember JJ’s warning and try to stay vague. “I work at a health center in Rogers Park. Up north.”

“Oh, they’re doing great work over there,” a man says as he joins us. A few others have gathered around us as well, standing in the way of any possible

escape. “I’ve heard that cutting just one more abortion clinic in this state could save as many as sixteen hundred women a year. The Rogers Park Pregnancy Center is the real deal.”

Of course. The demon brought a cabal of antis to this fundraiser. I should be shocked, but I feel numb to the emotion. I give the stranger an unfeigned nervous laugh.

“I don’t think it’s that many,” I say.

“Ah, don’t be so modest,” he replies. “We always have a hard time dealing with those Planned Parenthoods, but these small clinics are simpler targets, much easier to close down. Just a few minor incidents, talk to the right people, and there you go. And if you get rid of them, you weaken Planned Parenthood. Wait times go up, women stop coming all the way to this ridiculous state—I’m from Indiana, you know. But we need people like you in these liberal states.”

“Shall I tell them who you really are?” the demonic man from before whispers in my ear, suddenly right behind me. The jolt of fear that rushes through me seems to thicken the stink of his magic. “Shall I direct them to your clinic?”

The monologuing anti looks at me expectantly. “Thank you,” I say, feeling the demon’s grip on me grow stronger.

Tara told me to be hard. But what does that mean? Am I really going to give up my power to save the clinic? With all these bodies pressing around me, I can’t think. I don’t know what to do. My fear is feeding him, and that only scares me more.

“There you are, Nish!” I startle at JJ’s voice. She pushes through the sickly cloud, meeting the gaze of the man behind me before I can warn her away. “Who are *you*?”

He steps away, and I turn around to see him looking confused. *Who am I?* he mouths, and I realize that he’s just some guy. I don’t know if he is possessed or just a lackey, but I can fight a simple human. The viscous purple miasma, the crowd of antis, it’s all here to make me feel threatened, weak, so that whatever demon is pulling the strings can capitalize on my fear and get what he wants. But according to Muya, I can manipulate those around me as well. I feel a tingling sensation under my skin, a bit like fire and a bit like a heavy blanket. I may not be

particularly skilled or powerful, but I can cut through bullshit with the best of them.

“Who is he?” I ask JJ, grabbing her hand with my clammy fingers, trying to push my magic into the air. “He just started talking to me.”

“I’m... Thomas?” the man answers. He has forgotten himself.

“I don’t think you’re on the guest list,” JJ accuses him. She can probably see that I’m nervous, and I love her for trying to protect me. “Uncle Gary?” she asks a man in the crowd.

A man I haven’t yet met steps forward, tugging on his collar as though overheated. “Good to see you, JJ.”

There’s an air of confusion in the crowd that I capitalize on, reminding everyone, *You don’t know this man. Who is he? How dare he?* Nothing happens. Maybe there are too many people here for it to work. My heart pounds, but I concentrate on Uncle Gary and the purple smog around him. *You don’t know who he is. Why is he here?*

Uncle Gary, bless his heart, turns to the man and says, “I don’t think we’ve been introduced, have we? Or perhaps we have, apologies, the evening blends together.”

Thomas, or whoever he is, looks afraid. I harness the feeling of his confusion, his alarm, and knowing that I put it there, try to channel Muya’s power again. *Who are you?* The violet fog begins to thin.

“Funny, the last hour feels like a blur,” a woman next to me murmurs.

“Tell your boss he should be ashamed,” I whisper to Thomas. “What a pathetic attempt. Can’t even best one little human.”

Thomas’s eyes flash red. Something has snapped within him, the demon puppeteering him regaining control. “How dare you? You are nobody!” His energy surges, and people turn back toward us.

“You’re insane,” JJ says, voice firm.

Go away. You don’t know who we are or what is happening.

It finally works. The miasma disappears, and the crowd disperses. I’m almost giddy, but I school my expression into one of disdain.

“I don’t imagine I’ll see you again,” I say to Thomas, who seems to have been rendered speechless.

The man blinks, pressing a hand to his head. He looks at me with a blank expression. "Who are you?"

"What a weirdo," JJ says with a nervous laugh. She takes my arm and turns us away. "Sorry you got stuck with Uncle Gary."

"He wasn't so bad," I offer.

"Oh, good. I was worried he would start talking about his political views. He's a little... how to put it? Overly religious." JJ makes a gesture with her hands as if to say, *What can you do?* I think about how that other man was talking about the crisis pregnancy center and implying that there are already staff waiting in the wings, following a concrete timeline.

"Do you know him well?"

JJ frowns. "Unfortunately." She doesn't elaborate, and I don't ask her to. All of a sudden I'm exhausted. "Want to go upstairs?" she offers. "I know how you feel about the impressionists."

I can't burden JJ with everything that just happened, because I can hardly explain it myself. So instead I throw my arms around her in a brief hug.

"Thank you for coming back for me."

JJ pats my shoulder awkwardly before disentangling. "Come on, talking to people isn't that bad. But let's make our escape, take a breather upstairs."

"Only if you're ready for me to talk your ear off about bales of hay," I reply.

"I wouldn't have offered otherwise," JJ says, linking her arm through mine. I try to cling to the feeling of lightness in my chest, to remember this feeling of victory and friendship. In this moment, I don't think I could feel any more powerful.



11

TRAIN WRECK

I collapse into dreamless sleep and wake resolved to be more careful. I doubt the demon pursuing my power is gone, but I know now that I can beat him and whatever other threats he sends my way. I while away my Sunday on poor housekeeping efforts, more focused on what to do about Muya than my bathroom's cleanliness. He's a demon by his own admission. A demon of *ignorance*. And it's true that ever since I freed him, I've been able to use his powers, but that doesn't mean we're on the same side. He could be playing me. It's not lost on me that he's ultimately trying to take my powers—but at least he has a claim to them. Though I didn't consciously steal them, I do feel very slightly guilty for taking them. Enough to give him the benefit of the doubt at least.

For the next few days, I get lost in the chaos of the clinic. The protesters seem normal, without magical influence controlling them, so I deal with the usual—counseling patients, fielding emails from donors explaining how they just can't find the money for us this year, and talking to partners about volunteers.

By Wednesday, I've relaxed enough into the regular rhythm of my daily life that I don't scan my surroundings for magic. I don't think about demons. And... I glance at my phone while crossing the street to read a text from Aai.

Haven't heard from you

in a bit, you okay?

Are you eating?

“Jump!” someone shouts, and I dive forward on instinct. A car screams past me, so close that the side mirror glances against my jacket.

“What the fuck?” I shout.

The woman in the car is covered in magic, so obviously demonic it nauseates me. Muya’s hand is on my elbow, and I realize he was the one who warned me. The car backs up, as if to take a second pass at me. When I blink, I feel a stretcher underneath me. Time to keep my eyes wide open. Muya and I both speed-walk in the direction of the clinic. The car seems poised to run at us again, but for some reason it’s driving toward us at approximately three miles an hour.

“What is happening?” I demand.

“They’re trying to kill you,” he mutters. Then he shouts over his shoulder, “If you kill her, the magic dies, too!”

“I wouldn’t want to think you’re saving me for altruistic reasons,” I say, and his mouth twitches slightly.

“You’re taking this well.”

It’s not my closest call with a car, but I’d rather not think about that. “Why isn’t it working?”

“The demon controlling her driving is strong. And mad,” Muya grits out. Only now do I hear the strain in his voice.

“Demon-on-demon violence, huh?” I ask.

The car is starting to speed up, and it drives over the curb and onto the sidewalk. The clinic is still a thirty second sprint away. If Muya fails, I’m dead. It’s instinct that motivates me to help, a long-buried urge to survive.

You have no idea why you’re here. You don’t want to be here. You don’t know why you’re here.

The car stops.

The woman inside rolls down her window to yell, “Get out of my way!”

“You almost hit me!” I shout back.

“Oh, so you’re one of those crazy feminists?” she replies. “Making things up. Always needing to be the victim!” She lays on the horn and flips me off. I flip her

off right back. She reverses at top speed, and the moment she's on the road she tears away. Muya sighs in relief.

"You're not very strong," he says. "But at least you tried to help me save you. Whoever it is, his magic is powerful. And he's using a fair amount of it to obscure his true identity by sending proxies on his behalf."

"How does he keep finding these people?"

"Some temporary mind-bending, maybe making deals with people who serve a larger role in his plans, there's no way to know."

"Can you figure out who it is? Stop it at the source?"

"I'm afraid that's seeming more and more dangerous. I'd rather just keep you alive long enough to reclaim my power and be on my way."

"Was what you said to that woman true? That my power would die with me?"

"It is, and I don't trust you to stay alive on your own. You'll die with my power and condemn me." His voice conveys his deep annoyance at having to watch over such an inconvenient, squishy vessel.

"Step away from her!" a voice booms, and I turn to see Jeff, approaching me in a neon vest. We jog toward the safe ground of the clinic parking lot.

"Yes, I'm the real threat," Muya says drily for only me to hear. He shoves me forward a little bit, and when I turn to tell him to stop, he's gone.

"Was that man being aggressive to you?" Jeff asks, looking around. He seems as confused as I am about Muya's disappearing act. "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine," I say, knowing there's nothing he could do about it anyway.

I run inside to grab my vest, then take my place on the edge of the clinic property nearest to the sidewalk, arms crossed, staring down the protesters. There are a lot of large dudes with big beards here today, their gory signs out in full resplendence. They're definitely the most likely to get violent, but I actually don't mind facing off against them as much as I do the women. These types of men are so off-putting, escalating immediately into shouting and threats, that nobody actually pays them any mind. It's the soft-spoken, suburban mom-types who are most convincing—and thus, most dangerous to our patients. They lie with calm tongues, claiming moral authority as mothers. I see a couple of them out today.

Sure enough, the moment a patient walks by, one of these woman hustles forward, holding a flyer. I squint at her, but she looks perfectly ordinary.

“Hi, hon,” she says. “Are you here for the clinic?”

The patient, a young white woman, nods uncertainly, as I step up to her side. “Just keep walking,” I say softly. “They can’t bother you on clinic property.”

“You don’t have to go in there,” the woman says. “They won’t tell you how many patients have died because it’ll scare you away. And they’ll charge you money to hurt you. We have a facility set up just one stop down the Red Line that offers free ultrasounds and pregnancy counseling about all your options.”

“Free ultrasounds?” the patient echoes.

“Yes, hon. We believe pregnancy is a miracle. I have three little miracles myself. We don’t try to profit off you.”

The patient looks to me. I’ve been slowly herding us toward the property line, and we’re just a few steps away now. “How many of your patients have died?”

“None,” I say. “Of course, we’ve treated thousands of women, so it’s possible some have died from any number of reasons later on. But we have never had a patient die from any care we provide here.”

The patient turns back to the protester. “Your clinic, can I have an abortion done there, if that’s what I want?”

The woman falters. “We can give you a free ultrasound and counseling to talk through all your options. We can help you.”

“I see,” the patient says. “Thank you.” For a moment, the woman smiles, thinking she’s managed to con someone out of her appointment, but instead the patient walks confidently toward our door.

“Was what she was saying true?” the patient asks me before walking inside.

“It’s true they don’t charge for services,” I tell her honestly. “But from what we’ve heard, they don’t even have licensed technicians to perform ultrasounds. If you’re here for pregnancy screening or to talk options, we offer everything. Abortions, yes, but also prenatal care, adoption counseling, whatever you want. And of course, well-woman visits, birth control, Pap smears—I don’t want to assume.” I’ve found it’s best to be forthright and informative. The patient brightens.

“Thanks,” she says. “I think I’m pregnant, but I have no idea what I’ll do yet. The first step is confirming, right?”

I can’t dispense individual medical advice, so I just smile. “I think Dr. Levy is in today, and she’s great at explaining things. You’re in good hands!”

The patient goes inside, and I turn back to the antis scowling at me. I give the woman from earlier a bright grin and a little wave. But before I can get too cocky, I hear a siren. There’s not a lot of police or ambulance activity in this area, so I’m shocked when a Chicago police cruiser pulls up to the curb. At least it’s not ICE—we live in fear of the day that they might show up. It’s happened at other clinics. But we’ve been trained to respond to both ICE and police, and I draw upon that preparation as the officers angrily stalk over to me.

“Are you an employee of this clinic?”

His air of authority urges me to answer immediately, but instead I ask, “I’m sorry, officers, can I see some ID?” The man who spoke looks incredulous and angry as he pulls out his badge, and his partner follows suit. I make a mental note of their names, since I don’t want to grab my phone for a picture and get shot. I’m a small brown woman, so it’s unlikely, but still. “Thank you. Am I free to leave?”

“Answer the question,” Officer Davis snaps. He’s a youngish white man with a heavy spray tan. Officer Jones, an older Black man, shifts uncomfortably behind him.

“Am I free to go?” I ask again. If I’m not, there are legal rules they have to follow. And if I am, I’m going to go inside to ask Diane to call the lawyer our clinic has on retainer.

“We’re just asking a few questions,” Officer Jones says. “We got a call that someone matching your description was shouting obscenities and threats.”

Part of me wants to point out that given the scene outside, it would be very unlikely that I’d be the one shouting anything, but I know better than to allow my words to be twisted. I weigh my options, given that repeating my question a third time is just going to piss them off.

“Is there a problem, officers?” Aaron asks from behind me. It takes everything in me not to whip around, but I’m careful not to make sudden movements. When he reaches my peripheral vision, I see he’s wearing his lab

coat. His posture has changed. I used to tease him about it, the way he would put on an authoritative white-man persona when it suited him. I can see it work, too. Officer Davis relaxes a little bit.

“We got a complaint that this woman was shouting obscenities and threatening the people gathered outside. Flipped one of them off.”

“Her?” Aaron asks with a little laugh. He gives me an extremely condescending look, as though I’m barely capable of saying my own name. “There’s definitely been some mistake. She’s quiet as a mouse. Must have been a passerby. A lot of people walk past here, and not everyone is friendly. Maybe one of the nearby store owners saw something?”

To my amazement, Officer Davis asks Aaron a couple more softball questions, shakes his hand, and then the officers just... leave.

“Thanks for the rescue,” I say, sincerely. “Those *fuckers*.”

“So that’s not normal?” Aaron asks.

I shake my head. “We all usually have an understanding not to involve the cops. They’re getting bolder.” I play back today’s events, and it strikes me then that Aaron and the demons threatening me appeared on the same day. Still, I sense nothing out of the ordinary about him. A chill runs down my spine at the coincidence, and I try to shake it off. “Well, I should give Diane the details so she can send it up the chain. Don’t you have patients?”

He makes a slight move as if to touch my arm, then thinks better of it. We walk back into the clinic in awkward silence.

—

I spend my workday Googling demons, wondering if I could possibly identify the one who is after me on my own. Unfortunately, human possession and murderous rage seem par for the course for most demons. I’m deep into medieval history when I hear a knock on the open doorframe of my office. I look up to find Aaron, a brown paper bag in hand.

“I’m sorry about earlier,” he says, his mouth twisting in an awkward expression. “I hope what I said to the cop didn’t offend you.”

“It was necessary,” I say. My voice is flat.

“Yes, but... I felt bad. I got you lunch.” He holds up the bag. “I know you get sucked into your work sometimes and forget to eat.”

“You don’t know me anymore,” I say, even though he’s right. If anything, the depression has made it even harder for me to feed myself.

“If you don’t like Saigon Sisters...” I stand up, and he takes a step back. We both laugh awkwardly before he hands over the package. “I’m sorry,” he repeats. “I just want to apologize again properly for ghosting you, for being an anti, for making assumptions. Even if you were having an abortion, I shouldn’t have reacted that way.”

He gave me an almost identical spiel at the museum, and the goodwill his gesture earned him instantly dissipates into suspicion.

“Thanks for the food. I appreciate it. But if you’re hoping to buy my forgiveness...”

“I know,” he says immediately. “I know I can’t do that. I’m so, so sorry. What I did to you—”

“Forget what you did to me!” I interrupt. “I mean, it was pretty horrible, but who hasn’t been in a shitty relationship with someone who hides their shitty beliefs and then ghosts you?”

“Sorr—”

“The worst part is you were out there actively harming other people. Harassing women. You hurt *them*. What if you helped turn away a woman who needed care? How can I forgive that?”

Aaron hangs his head. “You can’t. You’re right. After I saw you that day, I talked to Michelle, and—”

“Michelle? Our Michelle?”

One of my good friends in college also remains one of the only genuinely pro-life people I’ve met. *Of course god exists. He commands us to be pro-life*, she once said to me. I thought the friendship was probably not going to last if she intended to bring up religious politics unprompted, but then she followed it up with, *That’s why we need gun control*, and my jaw dropped. Michelle was against abortion, but she was for gun control, expanded healthcare, and free childcare. And she never said a word to me about the abortion Aaron assumed I had. She simply continued being a good friend to me until she moved back home to

North Carolina to organize against the death penalty and we naturally drifted apart.

“Is there another Michelle?” Aaron asks. “I thought maybe she would understand my side. But she told me that at the end of the day, there is no true proof that life begins when she and I believe it does, only faith. She said that you never tried to push your religious beliefs on me, so it wasn’t fair for me to punish you for not adhering to mine.”

“Damn.”

“She said that people should be able to decide for themselves until we had more proof and that if I really cared about saving lives, I wouldn’t be protesting outside a clinic, I’d be protesting outside a prison.”

“I had no idea she was that badass.” I’m filled with a surge of affection for Michelle. If the antis who claimed to be pro-life were anything like her, there would actually be fewer abortions—people who wanted children but couldn’t afford them, needed to flee abusive partners, or didn’t have access to birth control would all have the resources they needed.

“Yeah, she pretty much chewed me out, but in that nice way of hers. And then she said that I shouldn’t have broken your trust by telling her at all. Our conversation got me thinking about what being pro-life actually meant. She said all I was doing was hurting people. She asked me what I would think if I had succeeded in turning away a woman who needed a Pap smear and later died of cervical cancer. I wonder every day what might have happened to the people I convinced to leave. I’ve read *The Turnaway Study*. I’ll never stop thinking about it.” Listening to him speak, I’m realizing that for all my righteous anger, I’m still just personally hurt, too. I don’t know what to say, because he’s giving me a perfect explanation. The perfect apology. But my heart can’t let it go. Unfortunately for me, Aaron seems to have retained his ability to read me like a picture book. “I can’t un-be there, and I can’t un-ghost you. So I’m just... trying. I hope you like your food.”

I squint at him. “Did you practice that?”

“Several times,” he admits.

I press the heels of my hands into my eyes. I keep finding myself oddly charmed by his presence, but my anger stubbornly remains. “I’m keeping my eye

on you, but until I find evidence otherwise, we can probably be respectful colleagues, for the sake of the clinic.” Aaron raises an eyebrow, and I avoid looking into his eyes, instead focusing on the smell of the pho. I hope he got bánh bao, too. “I can’t... I don’t know if I can forgive you. If you’re really in here saving lives, then I don’t want to be causing problems. But if you do something out of line, don’t think I won’t get you removed from the clinic.”

I don’t actually know if I could convince Dr. Levy to fire him, but I think she would listen. For now, though, he’s performing abortions and treating ectopic pregnancies and miscarriages and helping women safely carry to term. Saving lives. “You’ve seen now, the risk of the work. So if you’re in it, I can respect that. But we’re not friends.” There’s no way that the hurt Aaron caused—in that moment, when he ghosted me after seeing me at an abortion clinic and weeks later, after what he had feared actually came to pass—can be undone. But it’s in the past. I have bigger problems, I remind myself. Aaron leaves, and I enjoy my Saigon Sisters takeout in peace, staring at the clock and waiting to go home. I need a better strategy, and more information.

The moment five p.m. arrives, I bolt home, tie my hair back into the worst messy bun I’ve ever made, and guide myself through a namaskar, tatkar, and todas. My brain is too frazzled to truly get into it. I keep thinking about the sensation of the car mirror brushing my back. I take a break to stretch and slow my breathing, but it doesn’t help. My heart is still thudding far too hard in my chest. I’m going to have to break out the good stuff. I scroll through my dance playlist and pick one of my favorites, “O Re Piya,” letting the flute’s music sweep over me. The moment Rahat Fateh Ali Khan’s transcendent voice starts singing, my body moves. The mix of classical beats and soaring melody takes over my body. I bend and sway, my feet keeping time with the sound of the bells in the song. I spin, lifting my arms to the ceiling, and release myself.

I’m dancing. I’m falling in love. I know it cannot last, but I would leave everything behind for this feeling.

I am consumed.



LAILA

Laila's parents were prescient. They saw what was coming, the wave of conquest by foreigners with a strange religion, and named her in the new tongue. They intended for it to be a talisman of protection, not realizing that it took more than a name to keep her safe. But they gave Laila their caution, and that was their true gift.

When Laila was not yet a teen, she met a man who was not quite a man. He treated her like a younger sister, revealing to her the paths of the world. He touched her hand, and her eyes opened for the first time. She saw the spirits and creatures that others ignored. Her friends laughed at her as she claimed to follow fanged, winged beasts through the twisting village streets, for they saw only stray cats. She saw too which of the villagers had powers. The priest's family had long been blessed with good memory and the ability to read the augurs. A few farmers could sing to the plants and make them grow strong, or heal their animals with a touch. But a few seemed so outwardly unremarkable, that she wondered whether they knew about their powers at all, or whether they kept them hidden—perhaps their powers were embarrassing, for what other reason could there be to keep such a thing secret? Her parents cautioned her about asking prying questions.

On the night the invaders burned down her village, she was by the river with the man who had given her the power to see. Muya, he called himself, but she knew that was perhaps not the whole truth of his identity. He did not seem nice, but she had never seen him hurt anyone. When Laila asked him why he spoke to her at all, Muya went quiet. She knew very little about him, except that he was not human and that he *loved* rivers.

Later, it would be hard to remember what happened.

She sensed a great disturbance ahead and went to ask Muya what it meant. The night was moonless, so it took her some time to reach their usual meeting place. Then she heard screaming. Muya grabbed her arm, restraining her from fleeing. She started to shout and he clapped a hand over her mouth. She bit his hand, and he whispered something in her ear. Her eyes closed. She slept.

She woke at the riverbank to the smell of smoke. Her head lay on some bunched-up cloth. Muya was looking out at the horizon, a hard expression on his face that she had never seen before. She sprang to her feet and started running before he realized she was awake. Muya was hot on her heels, but she managed to make it to the tree line near her village—and stopped short. There was a pile of bodies in front of her, and it included her parents. A scream died in her throat as her gaze passed over the soldiers patrolling the smoking buildings. Many of them were gifted, burning bright and terrible with some sort of magic she had never seen before.

“They will bring their own people here to live.” Muya’s voice was quiet and solemn.

“Why?” She had many other, better questions, but this was the only one she could voice.

“Why not?” he responded. “Perhaps your village did not pay its taxes, or pray to the right god, or bow to the right king. You humans have never needed more reason than that.”

“I—” She turned away, covering her eyes.

“That was the wrong thing to say,” Muya said softly. “You are young. You have lost much. But you will find a new home, and it will get better.”

Something in Laila snapped. It was instantaneous—a bloodlust she had never felt before surged through her veins and settled into her bones.

“Yes,” she agreed. “It will.”

Laila’s parents had taught her caution, so she waited and bided her time. She fled to a converted town where she covered her head and learned to act like one of them. She had learned midwifery at her mother’s side, but she did not wish to bring the babies of her enemies into the world, and instead became a mediocre herbalist, practicing warcraft by night. Muya flitted in and out of her life,

helping her to hone her power and bringing her warnings. He knew that she was set on revenge and did not dissuade her from her mission, but neither did he encourage her. In time, she returned to her old village, which had indeed been repopulated. These strangers were paler skinned and spoke a different tongue. And though they seemed like any other people, Laila could only see them as monsters. Monsters who deserved to die.

She picked the darkest night to set the village ablaze. First, she cast a thick fog of ignorance over the town, just as Muya had taught her, so that they would lie dumb and docile in their homes. She locked their doors from the outside and brought her torch to their thatched roofs. Then she turned to face the village guards. She recognized a few from the original assault. With the aid of Muya's second sight, she could see that perhaps, if they concentrated, their magic could put out the fires. So Laila hardened herself with her memories. She remembered her parents and friends, lifeless, their bodies only half burned, and she could almost feel their souls around her, trapped because of *them*. She remembered the way the soldiers had brutalized her people and defaced her gods. She struck the first guard with her power, dumbfounding him, then followed with her sword. She saw the threads of another guard's magic stretching to the fires, and turned to him.

"Stop!" she called. "You will not be able to put the fire out."

"How—" The moment of distraction was enough. She sliced through his arm first, and then through his head.

The rest of the guards fled, and Laila laughed. It was sharp and piercing. They ran as though the spirits of hell were behind them. But Laila did not follow. She waited and watched until the village was rubble. Then she salted the earth. If her people could not live there, nobody would. She hoped this was enough to satisfy the souls of the dead, to free them to be born again.

Her work done, Laila went to the river and waited for Muya. She did not wait long.

"I saw what you did," he said.

"And?"

"You asked once why I like rivers." Muya sat beside her. "It is because I had a friend once. My best friend. And she loved rivers. They remind me of her."

“Did she die?”

“Yes.”

“I’m sorry.” Laila could sense in Muya a deep and abiding sorrow and saw that they were kindred spirits.

“Nothing can bring them back,” Muya said.

“I know. But I can at least live in their memory.”

Muya sighed. “I do not know if your parents would have wanted this for you.”

“What do you know of my parents?” she snapped.

“More than you might think,” he said. “I have known generations of your family. What will you do now?”

“I don’t know,” Laila said. “But I have heard that in the south, the invaders are lesser.”

“They are everywhere,” Muya replied. “Though it feels impossible to believe, most of them are ordinary people seeking to live in peace. Perhaps, now that you have exacted your revenge, you can live nearby. There are plenty of villages here that did not meet the same fate.”

She liked the sound of that. Muya left, and she stayed, dangling her feet in the water.

When Laila looks at me, I am prepared.

We are fierce, she says. Choose revenge.



12

MIRRORS AND SMOKE

When the song ends, I'm panting and covered in sweat. I touch my fingers to my face, and they come away wet. I've been crying. My knees buckle, and I let myself crumple to the floor.

Laila's story—it sickens me. Her pain, her desperation, her actions. Her power, Muya's power, my power, can be used for far more than playing defense. It makes me never want to use it again. And yet, I sympathize with her. Maybe the demons are right, maybe I should give it up, go back to my normal life, and forget I ever knew about this world. Even if I wanted to use Laila's method, I couldn't. I don't even really know who my enemy is. So instead, I do a Nisha Special: nothing.

I remain paranoid, searching for demons in every corner. I shut myself up inside my apartment whenever I can, shuttling from work to home and back again until my Saturday morning shift is over and I can simply lie in bed. But on Sunday, I feel stir-crazy. I'm usually fine with endlessly scrolling my phone, but right now, I want to move. I try to dance, but the memory of Laila prevents me from sinking into it. I'm afraid of what I could see next.

If a magical demon is going to get me, they can find me inside my apartment just as well as outside, I reason. Which is how I find myself in a nearby park, watching dogs chase squirrels. I wonder if the squirrels see the dogs as a sign of the good season to come—winter ending—or whether it's always terrifying. At

UChicago, boys used to joke that our motto should be “Where the squirrels are cuter than the girls.” Not Aaron, though. I sit on a damp bench and try to collect my thoughts. The demon pursuing me has made a few different attempts, but with days of nothing in between each one. I’m not a genius, but it feels like a pattern. Like maybe the demon takes time to plan each one or is weak and needs to recharge afterward—maybe that’s why he would pursue even my small amount of power. It’s a lot of conjecture, but I become more and more convinced of my own slapdash theory. Following this hypothesis, he’s due for another attempt on my life.

The next morning, I wake up sweating at five a.m. and decide to head to the clinic. Maybe that will make me feel better. As I climb up the stairs to the L platform, I’m taken aback by how quiet it is. I’ve never been out here this early, and I’m glad for that. It’s a scary, still kind of silence, not calm or peaceful. The nape of my neck is crawling.

At the top of the platform, there’s one other man waiting. I glance at him, and then scoff. “Waiting for me?” I ask Muya.

He smiles. “Of course. I had a sense you would come up here, and I wanted to show you something.”

I don’t respond, backing away. My phone is in my hand, ready to emergency dial.

Muya rolls his eyes. “If I wanted to hurt you, I would have already!”

He moves, faster than my eye can track, and grabs my free hand. I scream, but there’s nobody around to hear it. Then Muya’s magic surges through me—or maybe my magic surges toward Muya, and for a brief moment, I see the totality of the world. Everything is shimmering, everything is magic. I look down beyond the platform, and the dull Chicago earth is practically glowing. The sky dances, the air itself is saturated with the feeling of beauty. I exhale, and the world returns to normal. I turn to Muya, who is grinning from ear to ear.

“See? We share the same magic. Knowledge is the fabric of the world, and this is what it looks like dormant. Ignorance and knowledge are two sides of the same coin, and the ability to remove knowledge, to cause anyone to forget anything—it is far more powerful than you can imagine.”

Part of me wants to ask him to bring it back, that vision that filled me with such elation, but I bite my tongue.

“What’s your point?” I ask instead.

“You don’t seem to understand what you have, or the danger you’re in. You don’t seem to understand what we could do together. Look, there’s a train approaching the station. We could stop it.”

“Now you have telekinesis?” I’m half joking, half concerned.

“No. Power over minds, over ignorance, is so much stronger than that. The train operator is already anticipating stopping. If we both make that train operator forget he needs to reach the station first, that part of his mind will be veiled. And he will stop before he gets here.”

I feel Muya’s magic straining, and my own magic wants to respond. For a moment, I resist, but then my curiosity takes over. And as the magic surges, the train stops.

“That is what the entirety of my power could do. I could stop armies. But the whole is more than the sum of its parts; divided, it is much weaker. I want my magic back. I could be the most powerful ally you have ever had.”

It is when he starts talking of *want* and *power* that I remember myself. I yank my hand out of Muya’s, and the world seems instantly duller. The hum of magic is gone. We both wear matching looks of disappointment as the train starts again, our hold over the conductor lost. “Think on it,” Muya says, moving to leave. His voice is stiff and distant. “You are in more danger than you think.”

“I know. Please, wait. I know. But I need this power to protect myself.”

“If I had all my power, I could protect you.”

“Then why were you so eager to share with Chandini, Tara, Laila... should I go on?”

“That was a different time. A world filled with demons and magic. There was enough to go around. There isn’t now.”

“So what’s fueling the demon coming after me?”

Muya’s face contorts into an expression I can’t quite place. “Some demons cannot be killed. The world is always giving them power.”

“Like ignorance?” I quip, but he nods.

“Yes, like ignorance. Like any human folly. And—” He cuts himself off.

“And what?”

“And I don’t know why I would give information to some human who doesn’t trust me. Who stole from me.”

“I didn’t steal from you, I freed you. You should be thanking me, not disdaining humanity.”

He grimaces. “I always hope humans will be better than you are. But I am always disappointed. You have only benefitted from this relationship so far. It is true that you freed me, but you only allow me to be half myself.”

“Surely you are more than your power,” I say. I could add that his power has put me in danger since the start, but I don’t. He will only use it as another reason for me to give it up.

“A classically human belief,” Muya says. “Demons are their power, nothing more and nothing less. If you do not want to help me, then I will continue to search for how to help myself. Just—stay safe.” He leaves, and I don’t call after him this time. His opinion of me is clear.

—

I get to the clinic by seven a.m. I don’t have the keys, so I pace around the perimeter. I don’t see anything out of place, but my magic is deeply, deeply unsettled by Muya’s tricks, and Laila’s face still haunts me.

I don’t hear Diane until she waves her hand in front of my face and I startle. “You okay, honey?”

“Just tired,” I say, trying to smile.

Diane seems to understand. “You good to escort this morning?”

“Yup,” I say. “I’m going to blast Beyoncé. No tears allowed.”

She ushers me inside, where I take five minutes to warm up and put on my vest before heading back out to brave the wind. It’s one of those days that veteran Midwesterners would insist is “pretty good, actually, if it wasn’t for the windchill,” which means it’s terribly cold. I connect my Bluetooth to the old boom box and start playing *Cowboy Carter*. It’s that kind of day. Around seven thirty, the first few protesters show up, and the medical staff sets up for the day.

When I step inside to ask for the day's projected patient count, Diane looks at me suspiciously. "What is it?"

"I just... I have a funny feeling." It's clinic shorthand for a paranoia that sometimes takes hold given all the threats we get. Usually, we let that person poke around and assuage their fears without judgment.

Diane squeezes my arm. "I'm sorry. I know it's been really intense around here. Are you okay?"

"I'm okay," I say. "The last two weeks have made me antsy, I think. You know how it is. I'm just going to..." I gesture back at the office, where I plan to search my spam filter for anything suspicious before the day officially starts.

I don't find anything in my email besides the usual violent rambling, *I'm going to rape you and murder you, you murdering bitch!* I head back to the front just in time to find JJ pulling on a clinic vest. I follow her out.

"All quiet?" I ask.

"I just got here," JJ says. She looks a little nervous. "It doesn't look great, but hey, that's what I signed up for!"

"Forty Days is special," I tell her.

Her eyes dart over to the protesters. "Do you ever wonder why they do it?" she asks.

I shrug. "I know why they do it. They hate women and want to yell at them —"

"But not all of them, right? Some of them are women."

I laugh. "Plenty of women hate women, but no, you're right. Some of them truly believe that human life begins at the moment of conception, contrary to scientific evidence and the consensus of what—ninety-seven? ninety-eight?—percent of OB-GYNs. So to them, we're murderers. They believe it because their religion says so. Never mind that many have themselves had abortions or taken their daughters to have abortions."

JJ frowns. "If you really thought that murder was happening, routinely and regularly, wouldn't you want to do everything to stop it?" She hastens to add, "I don't agree, of course. But I'm just saying."

"I guess so. But you don't see them advocating for policy changes that could lower the maternal mortality rate in the United States, or protesting police, or

coming out against the death penalty.”

“Sure, but my point is that if they think we are committing murder, I guess I can understand why they would try to stop even one.”

“Except,” I say, “they believe it because of one interpretation of a millennia-old text. The Bible itself doesn’t say anywhere that life begins at conception. The line they always quote, ‘Before I formed you in the womb I knew you,’ is about their god planning to send down a prophet, not a statement about conception. But they refuse to believe they could be wrong. And anyway, their personal beliefs shouldn’t control the decisions of people who don’t share them. Though many people might wish it, this isn’t a Christian theocracy. It’s supposed to be a secular state, no matter how hard they try to make it otherwise!”

JJ grins a little. “There you are. You’ve been kinda quiet, but now you’re out!”

“Were you baiting...” I trail off. I smell smoke.

“What is it?”

“I’m not sure. Just wait here in case any patients show up.”

Whatever I’m smelling is coming from the back of the clinic, but as I head toward it, I feel my steps slow. I’m so tired all of a sudden. I should sit and rest. I *need* to sit and rest. I close my eyes just for a moment, and feel a hand on my shoulder.

“Nisha? Nisha? Are you okay?” I force my eyes open to see Aaron looking down at me. “Are you sick?”

I am here for a reason, though I can’t remember it. I only know that something is wrong. Suddenly, magic sings in my veins. I grasp it, wondering why these threads of power are activated, and my mind clears. The demon after me was in my head just now, trying to stop me from investigating.

“Nisha, what—”

The smell of smoke hits me, stronger this time. “Do you smell smoke?” I ask.

“No.” Aaron looks worried.

“I have a hunch.” My immediate surroundings are clear, but the smell grows stronger. “Fuck,” I mutter, trying to energize myself. “Fuck!”

Aaron follows at my side as I pick up the pace, and we round the back. A small fire blocks our path, and what smells like flammable liquid is everywhere.

Aaron curses, even as my training takes over. We have to document and evacuate. Technically, I think we're just supposed to evacuate. But without documentation...

"Take a picture!" I tell Aaron, who shoves his keys in his pocket and grabs his phone. I'm already dialing Diane. The call connects on the first ring. "Diane, evacuate. Call 911. Fire out back. Looks like arson." She doesn't respond. "Diane?"

She's certain of her safety. They all are.

A shadowy figure emerges from around the corner, covered in gray cobwebs. The whole building is draped in his stringy, filthy influence.

Who are you?

My name does not matter, Nisha. You are about to die, unless you give in.

A small fire isn't going to kill me. Humans aren't that fragile.

I would stop arguing if I were you.

The cobwebs descend over my body. With great effort, I take a step forward, gathering my strength until I can lunge toward the figure. I stumble forward straight through the dissipating shadow.

You're not even powerful enough to actually take form.

I'm too powerful for a corporeal form. You're almost out of time. Five, four...

I ignore him and turn my attention to the building and the people within.

Your safety is a lie, I tell them, focusing on his web of power.

The strings shudder, and a few snap, but the larger network of sticky tendrils remains intact. I try again, focusing on Diane through the phone.

YOUR SAFETY IS A LIE.

"Nisha, honey, what is it?" Diane sounds sleepy.

Three, two...

"There's a fire out back! Evacuate!" I imbue the words with the power I felt this morning, with Muya's ability. I can make them forget the demon's influence, even for a bit, if I try hard enough. I hear her leap into action, shouting instructions at the staff around her, and sag from the exertion. Aaron approaches the fire, and only then do I spy the glimmer around the flame itself. The red burning too hot.

One.

“Aaron!” I shout, and he takes a step back, but it’s like he’s moving through molasses. I grab for his hand, and what feels like the strength of Laila’s spirit floods through me. I yank him two steps away and—

The world explodes in a shock wave. Our bodies are thrown back several yards, and I fall on my hands and knees. Aaron’s phone shatters just ahead of us. We’ve been pushed clear of the building and into the empty parking lot. The flames lick the side of the building, climbing higher and higher. We have to move.

“Aaron?” I ask.

He’s facedown, but breathing. He could have a concussion or a severe traumatic brain injury or already be in a coma. Aaron groans, his arms twitching. This is nothing like my accident, I try to remind myself. I’m panicking. I can’t breathe. I pull my shirt over my nose and touch Aaron’s neck to find a pulse. It’s strong. He mutters something that I can’t hear but doesn’t get up. I don’t know what to do. He’s too heavy to carry.

“Wake up,” I command. I grab his face in my hands, my skin buzzing. I can see that the fire’s supernatural shimmer has fallen over his skin like soot. I try to scrub it off him to no avail. I channel my power, of ignorance or knowledge, whatever it is, and shove with all my might. “Wake up!”

There’s a surge between us, of what I don’t know, and then Aaron gasps awake. Coughing. Breathless.

Alive.



13

SECOND-DEGREE

The clinic is closed for several days. There's an investigation. The security cameras show an unidentifiable woman with dark hair, a mask, and a hat starting the fire and pouring gasoline around it to make sure it spread. The perpetrator was very deliberate, setting it up so that it would take several minutes to reach the building. But I know the explosion is my fault. I denied the demon what he wanted and he retaliated.

As soon as I'm released from the hospital, Aai takes me to her house. She washes my hair in the tub, like I'm a small child, but afterward my hair still stinks. Aai prays for hours each night in my room as I stare at the ceiling.

I want to cut off all my hair.

The antis all claim they saw nothing. Apparently one even suggested that we set the fire ourselves to try to hurt them.

Aaron texts. Then he calls. I do not pick up. Even though he almost died, too, I'm pissed at him, though it's muted underneath my depression. In an alternate universe, Aaron was rooting for the fire to raze the clinic to the ground.

The building isn't significantly damaged. Some windows shattered, but we were lucky to have called 911 so quickly—the firefighters were there within minutes of the blast. But I don't feel lucky. I feel shaken, and stupid. The clinic will reopen on Friday, after four days of treating no patients. Because of me. It's my fault. If I was like Laila, I would track the demon down and make him pay,

even if I don't usually believe that violence should be repaid with violence. It probably wouldn't improve my situation, but at least it would be something. If only I was brave enough to be fierce.

Thursday afternoon, I manage to crawl out of bed to find a pair of scissors, since Aai isn't answering my texts. I go downstairs to the kitchen and find Aaron holding a cup of chai and talking quietly with Aai. Aaron was hurt, but when he got to the hospital, they discovered only a few bad bruises and a laceration on his scalp. No concussion, no broken bones. We barely escaped, and I know the demon will be back. Aaron waves at me, but I ignore him and Aai and get the scissors out of the drawer. I'm not wearing pants.

"What do you need scissors for?" Aai asks.

"To cut my hair."

It only made the local news for two minutes.

Aaron rises to his feet. "I'm sorry. I should go. I just wanted to make sure you were okay, so I texted your mom, and she told me to come over. My family isn't—they can't—" He takes a deep breath, and I wonder for the first time what it must be like for Aaron to do this job when almost his entire family is dyed-in-the-wool anti. "I didn't mean to intrude."

"It's fine," I say. "You guys enjoy your tea. I'll cut my hair in the bathroom."

"I can take you to a hairdresser," Aai says. I'm sure she doesn't want me to cut my hair, but she'll never say so while I'm in this state.

"I'm good." As I stare down at the scissors, I feel less and less like cutting my hair. I trudge into the living room, lie down, and cover myself with a blanket. The bed is too far away.

Aai sits on the free end of the couch by my feet. Aaron sits on a comfy chair a few feet away.

"Thank you," Aaron says.

"You already said that." He didn't remember what happened, so I told the paramedics he stumbled into the blast wave and I dragged him away. We were both lucky.

"I could be dead. You saved my life."

I snort. "Let's notify the protesters."

“I’m actually pretty sure that saving the life of an abortion doctor is *not* considered a good thing to them.” He sips his tea, but I can tell he’s trying not to laugh.

It turns out that I’m desperate for this kind of ridiculous interaction. “No, you don’t understand. They’re pro-*life*. They value saving lives, I’m sure of it!”

“Next you’ll tell me they support parental leave! Food stamps! Housing assistance! What’s next, opposing the death penalty? Do you think they’re commies?” he jokes. Aai returns to the room with a plate of cookies in her hands. I didn’t realize she’d left. I’m so hungry that I grab one and scarf it down like I’m seven. Aaron takes one, too, and nibbles at it. “Seriously, though,” he says after I’ve demolished my cookie. “Thank you.”

“Don’t worry about it,” I tell him.

Some of my fatigue has returned, but I feel a lot more clearheaded. Maybe I’ll take a shower. It’s so stupid, but every single time I get pushed into a depressive funk, I feel better after seeing people and eating something. And yet, every time I convince myself that it won’t work, that it won’t be worth it.

“I do worry about it,” he says. “How did you know there was something back there?”

“I could smell smoke,” I say. But now that I’m turning over what Aaron said, it is a bit odd. He claimed not to smell the smoke, but he followed me anyway—was it to help me, or to stop me? Sure, he got hurt. And yet the woman targeted my office exactly, in a small, mostly unused part of the building that only clinic staff know about. “You really couldn’t?”

“Julie couldn’t, either. Why do you...” He must see something in my face, because he leans forward, speaking quickly. “I wouldn’t do anything to hurt you, you know that, right? It was right next to your office, I—”

“You’re being an idiot,” Aai interrupts, her tone sharp. “Nisha is not insinuating that you hurt her.”

I look over at her in surprise and realize she’s upset. I’ve been awful to her for days. Aaron stands up, sensing the tension.

“I’m sorry again to intrude. I’m glad you’re okay. I... god, I feel—”

“It’s fine. Really. Don’t worry about it,” I say. He makes a hasty retreat, and even before the door closes, I’m sinking back into apathy. My old, comfortable

friend.

—

I lie in bed reading and rereading the few articles about the fire. There are a couple of Facebook posts about how the fire is so tragic, but several more celebrating the fact that god took divine action against us transgressors. The text-based apps tip more in our favor, with a healthy contingent of people decrying the arson. And then there are the articles by local news organizations, each full of person-hiding language. The same way their headlines proclaim “Black Man is Shot During Confrontation with the Police” instead of “Police Shoot Black Man,” it’s all “Fire Breaks Out at Local Abortion Clinic” and not “Anti-choice Arsonist Sets Fire to Local Abortion Clinic.” I’m sure if a dark-skinned man was caught on camera, the headlines would lead with that. I’m well and truly caught in the whirlpool, forgetting how to swim or kick or find the surface—I’ve forgotten everything but how to scroll.

Eventually, Aai snatches the phone out of my hands. “Enough, Nisha!”

I grasp for it, and she dangles it out of reach. “I’m not a child,” I whine. “Give it back.”

“I’ll give it back when you snap out of whatever *this* is and get out of bed! It’s been days. Please, baccha. Talk to someone. I’ll find you a therapist. But you can’t keep living like this.”

“What do you know?” The words boil out of me. “That’s rich coming from someone who didn’t know what a therapist was until two years ago. Why don’t you go pray about it?”

Aai wordlessly drops the phone onto my nightstand and walks away. For a moment, I feel triumphant. Then I swing my legs out of bed and chase after her. What the fuck was I thinking? Depression makes me mean. Aai has been bathing me and feeding me like a child, has done and sacrificed everything for me her whole life, and I just insulted her for no reason at all. I pause outside her room when I hear her talking on the phone.

“She just... I don’t know what to do.”

Rima Aunty responds from Aai's eardrum-bursting speakerphone. "She's ungrateful. She has no idea how lucky she is."

"No, no... Nisha says a lot of things when she's depressed. If I had listened to all of them, I would have, as she once put it, literally jumped off a bridge."

My heart clenches. I did say that once, when I was in the hospital after the accident. I deeply regret it, but she never said anything, so we moved on. I was hurt and scared and lashed out against the one safe person in the world.

"Have you tried slapping her?" Rima Aunty asks.

"Children," Aai responds. I would pay years of my life never to hear Aai speak about me in that tone again, especially to Rima Aunty. "There's nothing you can do."

"She has had a lot of difficulty in her life," Rima Aunty says. I wish the phone would mangle her words, but they are clear as day. "But it's nothing compared to what you have gone through."

"It's not a contest. I wanted Nisha to have better options than I did." Aai laughs, an ugly one I rarely hear. "Look how that turned out. This country gave her a car accident, depression, and now this."

"She's rude, but capable. You should be proud. Some of the boys in this generation can't even wipe themselves." I cannot believe that Rima Aunty is defending me.

"She could have been a brilliant lawyer, a doctor, anything. But she's stuck, and now she will just struggle forever." I know Aai wouldn't want me to hear this conversation, but part of me feels relieved to witness her say aloud what I always knew to be true, that I am a disappointment who wasted all the opportunities she gave me. Aai sounds regretful, which makes me want to carve out my own heart. My throat feels tight. "I tried to give her everything."

Aai did give me everything, and I have nothing to show for it. Even Muya didn't choose me the way he chose other people to share his gift with. I stumbled upon his power by accident.

Nobody chose me.

But my clinic is in danger. I'm an adult. I should be able to solve my own problems without continually burdening Aai. I grab my things. They're still talking when I quietly close the front door.



DEAL WITH THE DEVIL

On my mad dash to the train station, a car pulls even with me. At first I flinch away, hand already reaching for my phone, but then I recognize Sanjiv Uncle, one of Aai's many acquaintances.

"In a rush, beti?"

"I'm late for the train," I say, then add, "Aai offered to give me a ride, but I didn't want to bother her."

He insists on driving me all the way into the city, and it's actually a pretty pleasant ride. Sanjiv Uncle has always been very sweet. He tells me he called Aai on the day of the fire to check on me, and extemporizes on how horrible the attack was. It feels nice, even if I don't know him well. I shoot a text to Aai telling her I'm heading back to the city and not to worry, and relax into the conversation.

Temporarily soothed, I'm caught completely off guard when I arrive home to find a man sitting at my kitchen table. I've already, like a complete idiot, closed the door behind me. I immediately turn around, lunging for the door, but he moves faster than I can follow to block it.

"I wouldn't scream," he says. "That will not go well for you, I assure you."

I try to remember what sequence of buttons on my phone leads to an emergency SOS call. I accidentally trigger it once a week, but now my mind is blank. I back away toward the window.

“Please, Ms. Kulkarni, there’s no need for theatrics.” I look around, wondering what I can use as a weapon. “Wouldn’t you like answers?” I pause. I would like answers, but not from whoever this is. He takes my hesitation as an opening. “In a show of good faith, allow me to introduce myself. My name is Asmodeus. Please, don’t look afraid. I know the Prince of Demons, Lord of Lust titles are intimidating, but I assure you I only want for us to help each other.”

My ears are ringing. I use my magic, searching out his power, and then—

I can’t help the gasp that tears out of me. He’s not cloaked in the same sickly aura of power as his lackeys. The entirety of him is limned in light. It is very nearly beautiful. The scope of his magic is vast, and yet contained in the most frightening display of control I have seen yet.

“Let’s sit,” he says. My legs obey, though I can tell he has not cast a spell on me. He wields a charisma so effective that he doesn’t need magic to make me do this. In a few long strides he sits across from me at my small table. “My employees have made several blunders. I should have remembered that if I want something done right, I should do it myself.” He chuckles, and it feels warm instead of creepy. I dig my fingers into my thighs, trying to regain control of myself. “I would tell you to relax, but it usually doesn’t help. So instead, I’ll offer to answer three questions for you to establish trust. What do you want to know?”

I still don’t know what to make of this, but I spent a lot of time as a child wondering what I would do if I was offered three wishes. “This isn’t one of my three questions, but what assurance do I have that you’ll tell the truth?”

He laughs. “I can see you’re well read. I won’t count this against you. You’ll have no assurance that I’m telling the truth. But I have no incentive to lie. Demons have different ways of interacting with the world, according to our nature, just as you have yours. It is not in my nature to do something as base as lie. I get what I want by being the most powerful in the room. I do not believe in hiding.”

That’s a lot of words for *you’ll just have to take it on faith*. Clearly, though, I can’t make him leave, so I take a few deep breaths and consider my next steps carefully.

“Why are you targeting me? Surely there are others with more power than I have.”

“There is not a lot of demon magic left in the world. Most demons are dead, and the ones who are left are hoarders. You, a human with demon magic... it hasn’t happened in decades. That is why I’ve been pursuing you.”

As he speaks, I study him properly. He’s tan with dark brown hair and brown eyes, handsome. If he was a politician, he would win in a landslide for his relatability.

“What would you use my power for?”

“Increasing my own, of course. My primary trade is making deals, soul pacts. I’ll tell you for free that I haven’t been asked to commit a murder in years. It’s mostly about money and power. But the human souls I collect in exchange house merely a fraction of the power currently contained in your pinkie finger.”

I’m down to my last question, and I’ve still learned nothing useful. “Why try to kill me if you want my power so badly?”

Asmodeus’s eyes harden, and I see the demon inside. “I’m disappointed that you wasted your final question on something so obvious. If I can’t have this power, nobody will. Certainly not a human who has defied me. There have to be consequences for failing to obey me. If I had been you, I would have asked something else—how did I set that fire, perhaps. How I control others. Something to help save your sorry skin.”

My mouth opens, then snaps shut. He’s right. “I don’t care about my sorry skin and I don’t really care how you’re possessing poor souls or tempting them into predatory deals, or whatever.”

He steeples his fingers, and I keep silent. “You raise an interesting point, one it took me some time to understand myself. You’ve been threatened, nearly run over, caught in a deadly fire, and yet you don’t seem to care much about surviving.”

“You could always take a stab at me now,” I say. I’m not sure why, but I feel confident he won’t.

Asmodeus smiles at me. “Why do you think I went after your clinic? You may be shockingly unmotivated to save your own life, but with a bit of time, I always find the leverage I need.”

Fear spikes within me. “It’s just a job.” I know I’ve made a mistake. I should have said nothing at all. And he sees it too.

“In the absence of your compliance, I could arrange something special. An air strike, perhaps? Or I could buy up your land and have the clinic bulldozed. Poor optics for humans, but I don’t particularly care.”

“If you have such power, why haven’t you already destroyed us?”

“If the fire wasn’t enough, I will take it under advisement. I simply thought you might prefer the carrot to the stick.”

I swallow. “Let’s say I consider your offer. You want my power, and in exchange I get what? To keep my life? My job? That’s a pretty bad deal for me. You could still kill me after you get what you want, and the humans opposing us will certainly still keep trying to put me out of a job.”

“You can have riches, if you would like, or power, enough to protect what you love.”

“I need some time to think.”

“My patience wears thin, Ms. Kulkarni. I don’t negotiate like that. You say yes now, or I will resort to other means of persuasion.”

It’s that line that cements it for me. “I’m very stubborn.”

Asmodeus sighs and rises to his feet. “Rest assured, Ms. Kulkarni, I will have what I want.”

—

I sit on the floor in a corner of my apartment, trying not to hyperventilate. I don’t know how long I’ve been there when a key turns in my lock. I scramble to my feet, hoping it’s Aai coming to take me home. Pathetic.

Before I have the chance to speculate further, Muya calls, “Nisha, you there?”

I try to smooth out my clothes so I don’t look like I’ve been crouched over and shaking in the dark. I doubt I’m successful.

“I’m here,” I answer. In a way, I’m kind of relieved. He is quite literally the devil I know. His magic helped save Aaron’s life.

He flicks on the lights, and we stare at each other for a moment. “So you are indeed fine,” he says in a flat tone. He’s holding a long, thin object and when my

gaze falls on it, he slips it into his pocket—he must have picked my lock.

“Aw, Muya, were you worried?”

He scowls. “Even someone as ridiculous as you can acknowledge that you are in danger now, yes?”

“Yes.”

“So you will agree to a deal?” he asks. “You give me your magic, and I will deal with this threat for you.”

“How would you go about dealing with it, hypothetically?” I ask.

“I have my ways,” Muya says, and I burst out laughing.

“So you don’t have a plan at all. What have you been doing all this time?”

“I’ve looked into your little problem.”

“And?”

“I’ve been continuing to search for a way to reunite my power without your consent. I have searched artifacts and sites of magical concentration, even tried to awaken native magical creatures. But there is nothing that can help me but *you*.” He gets more worked up by the minute and almost spits the final word.

“Well, you missed the Prince of Demons by about an hour,” I say. “Maybe he can help.” Muya hisses, a quick, inhuman sound. “You’re familiar?”

“How could I not have known?” He shakes himself. “It’s been so long, and these Western demons...”

“What is the deal with them anyway?” I ask.

“I was trapped in a statue for much of what happened,” he says. “But I imagine your kind hunted down all the demons they could find, thinking themselves conquerors and protectors.”

He sounds angry, understandably, and I’m beginning to appreciate why he has such contempt for me. We stare awkwardly at each other for a few moments before I break the silence. “That demon—Asmodeus—he realized... I was stupid. I let it slip that I care about the clinic, and now I get the feeling that he’s planning something bigger, maybe even working with the humans already targeting the clinic, I don’t know.”

Muya gives me a sharp nod. “I’ll look into it, then, and in the meantime, you should keep digging into the past. See you soon.”

He leaves as he's still speaking, apparently the demon of ignorance and Irish goodbyes.

I begin a simple palta footwork pattern, trying to steady myself in the beats. I alternate sides with tatkar before finishing the palta with a flourish that would have made even my hypercritical guru proud. I scan my playlist and spot a Lasya I learned a decade ago. It's not often performed in Kathak, but our guru insisted that we learn both a Tandava for Shiva and a Lasya for Parvati. I am not particularly sensual, but I've always loved the grace of the Lasya. I put on my headphones, tightening them until they're a little uncomfortable, and begin to dance.

I bend and sway, and my sides groan in protest. I have lost those hard-won muscles, in the hospital bed and in the intervening months spent under my own covers at home. And yet I feel grounded, present. I move my feet in small, deliberate steps. I am not the destroyer, but I am still powerful. For a brief moment I can inhabit another person. Another world.

And finally, finally, I let go.



HEERA

Heera was born just as the world changed. The world was always changing, but this was different. The power of the Bijapur Sultanate was waning and there were murmurs that the Hindus might seize power back. By the time Heera was an adult, the whispered prophecy had come true. Her people had long been under the rule of others, but now there was a Bhosle rumored to be the greatest leader the land had ever known, and he was one of their own. Though born to petty war chiefs, he had a greater vision. He was going to be a great king. He just had to make it there.

Heera never thought herself extraordinary. She could see magic and sometimes make people forget small, unimportant things, but these were child's tricks, minor powers to get out of minor troubles and nothing more. Demons had not yet realized that humans were slowly causing their extinction, so they still blessed children with gifts in exchange for guarantees of peace. With precious gifts—the power to heal broken bones, channel the strength of ten men, call to the elements—they thought they could stave off the inevitable.

Heera married when the time came, a kind man not too much older than she, and quickly fell pregnant. She bore three children, two boys and a girl. It was then that the dreams began. She dreamt of other women, other lives. Each time she awoke, she felt a yearning to leave her home. She felt that she was needed somewhere else. The Marathas, preparing for a final conflict, had recently finished building a permanent hill fort not far from their town. Heera watched the stone walls go up while she took her children to her parents' village, and a premonition of war shivered through her. But Heera held herself back. She loved her children and her husband. She loved caring for their animals, going to the

market, cooking. She loved her normal, everyday life. She had never wished for anything more. The unknown frightened her.

One day, she could resist the urge no longer. It jolted her awake in the night, her heart pounding, her stomach tugging her forward. She lay on her mat, wishing the feeling away. It would not go. So Heera rose early, and before her husband left for the fields, she caught his arm. He was a good man who had grown to love his wife very much. When he saw the look in her eyes, he clasped his wife to him, fitting her chin on his shoulder.

“We will be fine,” he said. “You have another destiny to fulfill.”

She shook her head. “This is my destiny. This is what I love.”

“We will be here when you return,” her husband promised.

She blinked away her tears and set out toward the hill fort. Soon enough, a man approached her.

“Sister, where are you going?” he called out.

“I do not know,” she said. “I am trying to find my people.”

The man took in her dress and the mark on her forehead and smiled. “It is too dangerous for you to be alone,” he said. “Come with me and rest, and then we will take you where you need to go.”

Though it went against all common sense and propriety, she abandoned herself to instinct and followed the man into the forest, along a path only he could see. In time, they emerged at the top of a hill, the entrance to the fort. Heera reared back in surprise, which the man mistook for fear.

“Peace. This is the fort of your people.”

Heera followed him inside, and was immediately surrounded by chaos. “What is happening?”

The man’s expression was grim as he took in the Maratha soldiers rushing to and fro. “I found you while I was scouting. The armies of Afzal Khan will be upon us soon.”

“We are finished,” another man said, listening in on their conversation. “You saved her from one certain death only to bring her to another.”

Not for the first time, Heera regretted her decision to leave home. But she was here now, and there was nothing more to be done. She was taken to the women’s quarters and tried her best to make herself at home.

For four days, she assisted the servants with their tasks and heard the lieutenants' whispers that the armies of Bijapur had marched on the nearby town of Wai, destroyed idols, and set up an ambush. The only thing everyone could agree on was that they were in danger.

"We must surrender, knowing what we know now," one soldier argued.

"We have wielders of magic on our side!" another countered. "They helped us take Pune. Surely we will be sufficiently powerful here, too."

"That was just an army, this is Afzal Khan! He has never lost a battle. His armies do not just have magic—he says he has a demon fighting for him, too. Who knows what dark bargains their kind have made?"

Heera's powers had been growing under her skin, and now the time had come to use them. She spotted the scout who had brought her here and approached him.

"Sir, I can help you," she said softly. The other men did not take notice.

"I remember you," he said with a small smile. "How can you help?"

"I think I can stop their demon," she said to him.

"All right. What do you need?"

She blinked up at him. "You believe me?"

"I am a scout not just because of my sharp eyes. I can see those who may be important," he said. "In this way, my family has long been blessed to be the left hand of greatness. When I saw you, I had a vision of you facing off against a great shadow."

She inhaled sharply. "I have no skills that will work against entire armies, but I can stop one man or demon."

Several hours later, they met at the gate. Heera had been given a man's clothing to disguise her, and the garments only enhanced the strangeness of the whole affair.

"Shivaji himself has agreed to take a meeting with Afzal Khan tomorrow morning," her friend told her. "We must succeed or else all hope will be lost."

The Maratha soldiers spoke of Shivaji Bhosle with a reverence befitting the man who had united them, but the scout's voice was tinged with fear. Heera thought she would feel panicked, but her stomach was settled for the first time

in months. She knew the way. She had centuries of experience, after all, just under her skin.

And so Heera and the scout ventured to the camp of the sultanate. She was so concerned with not tripping in the unfamiliar garb that she kept her eyes on her feet the whole time. It was only when the scout threw up a hand to stop her that she realized they had arrived.

“What now?” she asked.

“Their demon is foreign, barbaric. Each night, he hunts and feasts on wild animals.”

“And if he attacks us instead?”

The scout shrugged. “Risks must be taken in war. I place my life in your hands.”

They skirted around the edge of the camp until they reached a small stream. The man nodded to himself. “We shall follow this.”

She followed him down the slippery stones, once again focusing on not falling, until her friend took a sharp inhale. Ahead of them, a man-shaped creature knelt on hands and knees. His hair was replaced by flames, tusks protruding from a line of teeth and smeared with the blood of the young deer that lay before him. At the slight sound, he looked up and pinned them with his gaze. As they stood paralyzed in fear, the demon rose and approached them. He cocked his head at Heera.

“You can see me,” he said. His voice was low but human-sounding.

She looked out of the corner of her eye at the other man, who was also staring at the demon.

“We can both see you,” she said.

The demon laughed. “Your friend sees me as a man. You see my other shape.”

“What other shape?” the scout demanded, and Heera’s eyes widened.

“You see, child? Now, as entertaining as this is, I am going to have to kill you. For the lady, though, I will make it quick. Painless.”

For a moment, Heera hesitated. She knew how to do it, just a quick touch, but her body froze.

As the demon reached for her, she said, “Why must you kill us? We’re just trying to escape all the fighting. We will not tell a soul. Please, spare us.”

The demon laughed. “You’re a poor liar, child. You are spies.”

“Why do you serve your general?” Heera asked. “You’re more powerful than him.”

“Why indeed?” the demon said. “That mystery you will take to your grave.”

The memory was at the top of the demon’s mind, or so she hoped. The patterns of demons were far beyond her knowing. She grabbed his wrist, and with all the power available to her, she removed his memories. His loyalties. Anything that tied him to Afzal Khan—his desire to kill them, the reason he was here at all. She had never used her powers so significantly before, but it came easily, as it always had. She could not see into his mind—she could not see into anybody’s—but she could feel his memories becoming inaccessible. The demon began to shake, and her friend pulled her away. As he held her, she realized that she was the one shaking, not the demon, who had fallen back on all fours.

“Can you run?” the scout whispered. She did not respond. Her mind felt scattered. She felt herself being picked up, and then watched as the landscape shifted around them. When she came back into full awareness, it was dawn. She was crouched on the forest floor. Her feet felt steadier underneath her. The scout put a finger to his lips. “Listen,” he said.

She strained to hear, but her heart was beating too loudly.

The sound of an explosion rent the air. Birds shrieked, and Heera screamed, covering her ears, but her companion whooped, a triumphant sound.

“It is the first signal—Shivaji has slain Afzal Khan!” He began to laugh, and Heera laughed, too. It was contagious.

“Should we not join them?” Heera asked.

“We do not want to distract them, or worse, be mistaken for the enemy. We will wait to approach the fort until the cannons sound again, and we will know the Bijapur army too has been routed.”

When the sun was high, the signal came, and they made their way back to the fort. The flag of the Marathas was flying overhead, the agreed-upon sign of triumph. The mood was giddy, the battle won, and although her companion was immediately swept up in the celebration, he brought her along as he made his way to the war room. Shivaji himself was there, addressing his most trusted lieutenants. He nodded his approval to the scout when they entered.

“This fort has earned its name as the place of greatest valor,” he said. “Now it truly is Pratapgad.”

The men cheered the name. Heera cheered, too, but she realized that the pull that had been driving her for so long was gone. She sagged back against the wall with boneless relief, melding into the background. The scout conferred with Shivaji, then returned to her.

“You must have a prize,” he said. “A place at court? An elevation to nobility? You would be an asset to this new empire.”

Heera declined with a joyful smile and a full heart. After the armies of Afzal Khan had been fully dispatched, she declined even a guard to accompany her on her journey. Instead, Heera went home to her husband and her children. She never wanted to leave again.

“Where did you go, Mama?” her youngest child asked.

“It is not important,” Heera said. “Nothing you will ever have to worry about.”

She looks at me, a beatific smile on her face.

We can be happy, she says. Choose to be content.

What the hell kind of bullshit advice is that?



15

TRAINING STATION

On Friday morning, Aai calls me on my way to work. It's our first day back, so we're cramming in patients who couldn't be accommodated elsewhere and are up against gestational limits for various procedures. I can't imagine how it must feel to have booked a hotel for an appointment, only for our clinic to be set on fire. Aai called me last night, too, but I didn't respond. I was too busy interfacing with demons, and though I want to tell her everything, I know I can't.

"What is going on, Nisha?" Aai asks. "You scared me, leaving that way! I know you're not okay. Do you need me to come get you?"

"I was very rude," I say. I'd practiced this response. "I did not think you would want me around."

"You went through something very traumatic," Aai says. "I understand."

It sounds like what actually happened is that Aai reached an understanding with Rima Aunty about how much trouble I am, but it's not like I can be angry about that. I deserve it. And Aai deserves to vent to her friends without me spying on her.

"I appreciate that, but it didn't feel right to keep burdening you."

"Burdening me?" Aai asks. "Since when is that something you worry about?"

"I'm sorry. I know I've been a bad daughter—"

"Nisha, what are you talking about? Maybe you should come home. I'm not sure you're in your right mind."

"I'm good, really!" I sound crazed even to my own ears. "I'm just trying to be self-sufficient."

"Now is not the time to experiment with self-sufficiency!" Aai snaps. "Have you even been eating?"

I round the corner and am confronted with absolute madness. "Sorry, gotta go. Love you!"

Two groups of protesters, split down a clear dividing line, are fighting *with each other*. Jeff is watching with open-mouthed delight. There's Catholics for Life on one side, evangelical men's rights activists on the other, and a group of schoolchildren huddled on the grass who don't seem to belong to either. My eyes linger on a large sign featuring an image of a toddler, its mouth open in a rictus of pain, blood gushing from unmarred skin. It doesn't make any sense, and is captioned, "What Planned Parenthood Doesn't Want You to Know."

"What is that?" I whisper to Jeff.

"A masterpiece," Jeff whispers back. "One of the kids saw that sign and asked about it, then that dude with the crazy beard said that's what they do to little kids inside. Then that kid told the others that they were brought here..."

I clap my hand over my mouth, because I don't want video of us laughing to end up on right-wing blogs. The Catholics and the MRAs do fight sometimes, since they prefer different tactics, but I've never seen something like this before.

"If your kid is scared of clowns, don't bring them to the circus," I say, and Jeff has to turn his back to regain his composure. "So now what, they're fighting over whether or not clinic protesting is child appropriate?"

Someone shouts, "Heathens!" and gets an immediate, "Fuck you!" The situation only devolves further, since now the children's ears have been marred by profanity. It's beautiful, but after a few more minutes I need to go inside. Diane tears her eyes away from the CCTV when I enter.

"Having fun?" she asks.

"Definitely." I notice some pretty blue flowers at the front desk. "Have a secret admirer?"

"They're for you," Diane says with a smirk. "There's a card." I frown at her, all enjoyment from the scene outside evaporating. "They won't bite, sweetie. We've looked them over, even used the metal detector in the back."

At least I know it's not a hidden bomb. I pluck the white card from the bouquet.

N—

See? I'm using my powers for good. Let's talk this afternoon. I'll meet you at the train.

—M

At that moment, Aaron pokes his head out.

"Nice flowers," he says, eyebrows furrowed. "They're for you?"

"What, I can't get flowers?" I ask. It comes out snappier than I intended.

"They're from an admirer," Diane stage-whispers, and the line in his brow deepens.

"Nice," he says, then turns to speak to one of the patients in the waiting room.

Diane snickers. "He's jealous, honey."

"What?" I hiss, looking around to make sure nobody can hear her. But she has a well-calibrated whisper, as is needed to work in a clinic, and everyone else is several feet away. "Definitely not."

"You guys have great chemistry," she adds. "I can totally see it. I mean, sure, you avoid each other because of your past drama, whatever it is. But I can see it."

"It's definitely never happening," I say. "It's a simple story. We dated for a few months when we were in college. It was fun, we liked each other." Well, I loved him, but saying so is just embarrassing. "One day, I went with my friend to Planned Parenthood. She was nervous about getting an IUD. I saw Aaron protesting outside. It was like ice water had been dumped on both of us. Afterward I tried texting him, because I thought—I don't know, that I could change his mind? He ghosted me. And then his best friend told me it was wrong to get an abortion without telling Aaron first."

"That's awful." Diane gasps, and immediately gives Aaron the stink eye. "I get it. He's reformed now, but whatever's between you..."

“We left it unresolved, that’s all. But it’s never happening.”

What I don’t mention is that less than two months later, I tried to get in contact with Aaron. But he ghosted my calls, and so I went alone into that same Planned Parenthood to get my mifepristone and misoprostol. I take a deep breath and push the past aside. So many things from before my accident feel like they happened to a completely different person, but everything with Aaron still feels like part of me.

“The flowers look nice up here,” I tell Diane, sliding the note into my pocket.

—

When there’s a brief break in the schedule, I walk the perimeter of the clinic. There are scorch marks on the building, but nothing else that could be helpful. I walk around and around, as though something will emerge from the brick and steel to solve my problems. Sometimes protesters walk around the clinic on the public sidewalks, as I’m doing now, every day for six days. They believe that, like the walls of Jericho, the walls of the clinic will come down. The building doesn’t give me answers, but being out here reminds me that it is sturdier than the antis would have me believe. I touch the side and feel myself steady.

Since my usual office is not habitable due to smoke, I enter the small meeting room to check my email. At the top of my inbox is a message from the police. They have decided the incident was just a “prank” and had nothing to do with the “political elements of the clinic’s work.” As such, they will “do their best” to catch the “child” responsible, but more serious crimes take precedence. They refuse to even look into the Christian terrorist groups that regularly try to bomb clinics like ours. Disappointing, but expected. As veteran clinic escorts like to joke, someone could grow a whole baby in the time it takes the police to lift a finger for an abortion clinic.

For the last few years, I’ve poured myself into this place. I came here from my first job out of college working at a start-up nonprofit that was supposed to “shake up” housing on the South Side but actually mostly helped slumlords and refused to work with “undesirable” tenants. I was alone—my friends had moved away and I hadn’t made any new ones—so when I got into law school, I took

myself out to a celebratory dinner in the city instead of going to Aai's like she had asked. I stepped off the curb, and I woke up in the hospital. Aai was sitting at my bedside, looking like she had cried out enough water to fill Lake Michigan. The hospital had apparently failed to realize that I had broken a rib until it pierced my lung and I almost died. Medical malpractice. Even though I didn't remember the details, I was afraid to even leave the hospital room. My brain felt too fucked up to do anything but stare at the ceiling. From my bed, I called the law school that had admitted me for the following fall and explained, dry-eyed, that I needed time to recover. I said that I'd be working at a clinic but would be back next year.

Then *Roe* fell. The clinic started getting more patients every day. I'd wanted to go to law school to protect abortion rights for another generation of women, to do something great, something special. But I learned that the law didn't protect people. No one person could stop the endless rollback of civil rights, and certainly not me—a shell of the girl who had applied in the first place. I would be wasting a seat that somebody with actual drive and passion and courage could fill. Instead, I spent every iota of energy—not much, admittedly—on the clinic. I built a robust volunteer program and helped with outreach, even handing out condoms and flyers on Devon Avenue, Chicago's Little India.

I can't let anything bad happen to this clinic. I wonder if I should track down Asmodeus and take the deal. It occurs to me that I haven't had time to research him with everything else going on—stupid of me. Google overflows with hits. Asmodeus is sometimes considered the demon of wrath or lust or revenge, and is sometimes a prince and sometimes a king. He may or may not hate water and may or may not have once been bound to a rock.

I see a patient's car approaching, and put my phone in my back pocket. The patient exits with a young child, and I jog over to them. There's a firm look in her eye, and the child smiles and waves at me.

"Is there any way someone could watch him while I'm at the appointment?" she asks, her tone low. "Sorry. I'm Lauren. This is my beautiful boy, Jason. I don't want to scare him."

"Not usually, but... maybe I could sit with him in the waiting room, if that works?"

There aren't many patients left for the day, so I think it will be all right. Jason and I play hand-clapping games and I Spy. He tells me about his mom and clams up about his dad, so I have a good guess as to what's going on. He's all the way from Texas and has never been to Illinois, but tomorrow his mom is taking him to the zoo. It feels good to tell him about the monkey enclosure at the Lincoln Park Zoo, and add that he might be able to see penguins. It feels good to lose our games on purpose to see him smile. It reminds me, for a moment, that there's so much more out there that is touched by our clinic.

Muya meets me on the platform, as promised, dressed in a stylish wool coat.

"Are we stopping another train?" I ask.

"I'm going to teach you how to stay alive."

"Hard task," I mutter.

"It is astounding that you've made it this far," he says. "But you lived. So even though you seem to be limping through life, you must have some little bit of fire in you. And now you have my power."

"So you've changed your tune?"

"No, I've realized that your particularly feeble mind requires some attempt at kindness to accomplish our goals."

Before I can parse that, Muya seizes my hand.

"This is all moving a bit fast for me," I quip.

"Just shut up and *feel*."

Warmth suffuses me where Muya's fingers touch mine. The heat carries through my palm and into my elbow, and with it, understanding. Muya's power holds instruction, knowledge. I shudder and instinctively pull my hand away, but Muya's grip is too tight.

Be patient, he warns.

This is how it felt, when Asmodeus spoke to me. A voice inside my head that almost sounded like myself.

It's just a different form of communication. He couldn't read your thoughts, if that's what worries you.

You read my thoughts.

I felt my own power.

I look over at him, ensuring that he can see me roll my eyes. I concentrate once more on the tendrils connecting us.

Ignorance and knowledge are fundamentally connected, and knowledge is about memory. It is not innate, it is learned. If you're in a fight, you probably can't make someone forget how to fight. But you can make them forget why they're fighting. See that woman? I look over to see a woman climbing up the steps to the L platform. *Reach out, lightly, and make her forget why she's here.*

She might be in a rush!

The next train isn't for five minutes. You're going to use restraint, and only influence her for half a minute, at most.

I reach out toward her, channeling the brightness I feel inside me.

I thought ignorance would feel dark.

That's because you're ignor—TOO MUCH! Muya stops me, and I recoil, drawing back into myself. *Too much, you're going to need far more subtlety to get by. Concentrate on the duration of time you want to affect.*

This time, I deliberately try to use only a small bead of magic.

You don't know why you're here. You won't know until you get to the bottom of the stairs and remember again.

This time, Muya doesn't stop me. We watch her stand at the top of the platform, blink dazedly, look at her phone, and head back down the stairs.

The real test will be if she comes back. In the meantime—

“Hey, get a room!” A crowd of clearly drunk college-aged boys has just reached the top of the platform and decided to jeer at our intertwined fingers.

Good opportunity for crowd control. Make them forget we exist.

They'll just see us again.

The brain is a funny thing. Instead of trying to use your power on them, think of the power cloaking us. Make us immune to observation; make their brains unable to process the sight of us.

We are invisible.

Not invisible. That's different. Just... unknowable.

We are unknowable.

I have no idea what I'm doing, and though I try to shape the power, it falls apart. I can hear Muya sigh in my head.

I will do it to you first, so you can observe.

The power pulses from him easily, a thin matrix that covers me in a gossamer film. I glance toward the boys, and though they look in my direction, their eyes see through me like I am part of the station. The woman from before is back, looking mildly annoyed, and she too doesn't seem to see me. Muya has made me resistant to cataloguing, resistant to memory. I try to replicate it on him, spinning out the same net over his form.

Clumsy, but yes, that's the idea.

Would it kill you to say "good job"?

"Good job," Muya says aloud, then clutches his chest. "Oh, my heart!"

"Asshole," I mutter, though I can't help but laugh.

"Your train is coming. This is where I leave you."

"You taught me how to do two things."

"So you're two hundred percent more competent than you were before," he snarks, letting go of my hand. "I'll keep poking around, but at least now every time I leave I won't have to worry about you dying and taking all my power with you."

The train arrives, and people stream out. Normally I'd run right in, but I realize I'm reluctant to go. I'm actually enjoying spending time with Muya, a demon who hates humans and thinks I'm incompetent, who is only here to take away my power.

"What's wrong?" Muya asks.

"Just worried that you'll be lonely without your only friend," I say.

"Projecting, are we?"

I board the train just as the doors close. When I look back at him, though, he's waving.



JAB, CROSS, UPPERCUT

On Saturday, the protesters are extra awful, and coated with Asmodeus's oily magic. It's as if, having heard about the fire, they think we're more vulnerable. Just one push away from folding. I see at least one coach bus arrive, full of protesters, signs, and other shit. Someone is setting up what looks like a TV monitor by plugging a bunch of power cords into a car. That car is definitely going to catch on fire, but they certainly won't hear it from me. I see Steve, holding a sign but looking quite downcast. When I catch his eye, he squares his shoulders and approaches me. I backtrack, then remember that I have magic and just survived a fire.

"I was very sorry to hear about what happened," he calls out. "Someone could have been hurt. I want you to know I don't support that."

Part of me wants to burst out laughing. It was literally his people who did it! But I guess it is nice that one of the antis here today doesn't want us to die.

"Thanks," I offer. Then a patient walks over and our weird little truce is forgotten.

I get the first few patients inside with no problem, until a mother and young daughter round the corner. At first I think they're going to the shopping complex down the street, since the daughter looks eleven or twelve and usually the parents of older children come in on schooldays. They're both looking at the protester gauntlet with apprehension. Then I realize that the kid's bulky jacket is

trying to hide a pregnancy. Unfortunately, I notice this at about the same time the protesters do, and they start screaming and jeering in an insane cacophony. The mother tries to curl herself around the kid, and I sprint up to them.

“Come on,” I say. “We need to move.”

But the girl is rooted to the spot, staring at the ground. The mother tugs her arm.

“Don’t force your baby to destroy a precious gift from god,” one woman says, her voice sickly sweet. “What mama wants her child to have an increased risk of suicide and cancer? You’re going to be a wonderful grandma.”

The mother’s hand curls into a fist. “My baby is *twelve*,” she hisses. “Get out of her face.”

“You must be so scared and emotional,” the woman says. The other protesters are still shouting about hell and the devil, but clearly she’s been elected to play good cop. “I know I would be. But this is a gift, and you’ve got to make the right choice—”

The mother puts her hands over her daughter’s ears. “Her cousin *raped* her,” she says. “So shut the *fuck* up.”

“Girls this age are so adventurous,” the woman says. “They make up all sorts of stories. But god wouldn’t gift her a baby if it had been rape. Women’s bodies are designed to carry life, after all. It’s the consequence of her actions—”

I don’t actually hear the rest of the sociopath’s word salad, because I notice a subtle shift in the mother’s eyes and launch forward just in time to catch her fist in my hand. Going to jail for assault is not what she needs. My eyes water from the hit, and the mother gasps.

“Let go of me!”

The protester grabs my arm, a mean smile on her face. “Let go of her.”

“You don’t want to fight,” I say, and both of them snort. “Let me go and leave her alone!” I shout, and power surges through me. I release the mother’s hand and shake off the protester; both stare at me blankly.

Clearly Muya’s training worked. I barely tried, and my power did as I asked. But the situation is volatile and there’s no time to reflect. I focus on the girl.

“Want to get inside?” I ask, offering my hand. “It’s okay if you need time, but it’s less loud in there.” The girl seems to unclench slightly. I cannot begin to

imagine what she's going through. "Let's just take one step. Every step will get quieter, okay? Just one step." And she does it. This is how I bribe myself out of my stupors sometimes, but this girl isn't lazy, just overwhelmed. "Amazing work! It's so loud out here, sometimes I forget that I can walk away, too. One more step, yeah?" The girl takes steps forward. I'm aware that her mother is moving with us, cussing out the protesters along the way, but my focus is on the girl. "Okay, one more."

All of a sudden, the girl sprints forward, knocking into a protester and continuing until she's all the way inside the clinic. Her mom and I run after her, and I feel overwhelming relief.

"She just joined track and field," her mother says, sniffing, and I see she's begun to cry. I don't blame her. "Don't worry, I reported it to the police. But she's still going to suffer more than him." Before I can respond, she's entered the clinic to find her daughter.

I think of Chandini, and strength. I just launched myself into a fight, something I'd never normally do. I turn back to the street.

—

Halfway through my shift, I see a likely patient coming toward me. I'm about to ask if they want to be walked inside, when I make sudden, jolting eye contact with Muya, who is standing across the street. My stomach sinks. Has he learned something new since our last meeting? He looks relaxed, strolling among the protesters as though he belongs there. I wrench myself away to focus on the approaching figure, and hustle toward them as fast as I can. A protester darts forward, crossing the street and stepping onto our curb. The patient flinches backward, stumbling on the uneven pavement, just as the protester in pursuit collapses, twitching. I lose sight of Muya but turn my attention to the patient.

"I thought he was trying to rush me!" the patient says, hands over their mouth.

"Let's get you inside," I say.

They nod, and we move toward the building's entrance. As soon as the door has closed behind them, I sprint back toward the protester, despite my better

judgment. The rest of the antis are standing around him, but I'm pretty sure not one person has called 911. I've seen people fake seizures before, in an effort to show patients the effects of our "wickedness," but as I look down at him, something feels very wrong. I get on my knees and see saliva dribbling out of his mouth. Only the whites of his eyes are visible. We're not supposed to engage, but I make the call.

"911, what's your emergency?"

I glance up and see Muya jogging away, giving me a jaunty wave over his shoulder. I remember, belatedly, that Apasmara is associated with ignorance and *epilepsy*.

"Hello?" the operator asks, and I manage to stammer the clinic's address. I check the man's wrist for an emergency bracelet of some sort, at the operator's request, and someone shoves me away.

"Get your murderous hands off him!" a man shouts in my face.

"Sir, I'm trying to help. He's having a medical emergency."

"God is working a miracle through him!" Anti-choice and anti-science often go hand in hand.

"Are you there? Ma'am? Are you all right? An ambulance is on its way. I see you're near a health clinic. Is he a patient?"

"He's a protester," I say. "It's an abortion clinic. I work for the clinic—"

Whatever I'm going to say next is interrupted by the screech of tires. A car brakes just before hitting the crowd of protesters, who jump back on instinct, leaving me alone with the seizing man and the two protesters closest to us. Aaron jumps out of the car, his eyes wild and trained on me.

"Aaron, help him!" I gasp. "There's a doctor here now," I say into the phone.

Aaron seems to realize what's happening and leaps into action.

"Wait..." a voice says. "That's an abortion doctor!"

The operator asks me if I want to stay on the phone until the ambulance arrives, but it's clear nothing more can be done, so I say no and hang up. Then I stand and put myself between Aaron and the protesters. The man opposite me is skinny, tall, and filled with pent-up rage I can tell is moments from exploding.

"This is assault!" the woman next to him screeches. She's pulled out her phone to record us saving a man's life.

“How soon is the ambulance coming?” Aaron asks. He sounds very calm, but I can tell he is worried.

“It’s on its way,” I say. “The nearest station isn’t far.”

“There isn’t much I can do,” he says. “He needs a hospital.”

As if on cue, a siren becomes audible, rapidly getting louder. The skinny man lunges forward—why, I don’t know—and I step sideways so that he collides with me. We both stumble, and the distraction keeps him from mowing down Aaron. Two paramedics are already rushing toward us.

“That murder doctor is killing this man!” the woman shouts. A swarm of protesters approach from the other side of the road.

“Maybe it was a vaccine!” another anti calls out.

“Is anybody related to this man?” one paramedic asks, as the other crouches down to speak to Aaron and set up a stretcher. Nobody comes forward. “Please step away and let us do our job.”

The protesters don’t listen, and I realize the person speaking is a Black woman. When her white colleague asks “folks” to disperse, it suddenly happens. She glances back at me and we share a look. Then she helps load the protester into the ambulance.

Before the antis can turn back on us, Aaron and I retreat to the entrance of the clinic.

“What was that?” we both demand at the same time.

“He just... collapsed and started twitching,” I say. “Obviously, they weren’t going to do anything about it. Good thing you were late to work.”

“Seriously?” Aaron asks, annoyance seeping into his voice. “I do rounds at the hospital, then come here for procedures. I was right on time.”

“Shouldn’t you have gone with the ambulance?”

“I really didn’t provide any medical care, so—”

The door swings open, revealing Diane and Dr. Levy.

“What the hell was that?” Dr. Levy demands.

Just then, I see a woman turn onto the clinic’s street. She has a frightened but determined look on her face that I have found often distinguishes our patients.

“I’ve got to go,” I say. There’s no way I can find the words to explain.



HELL AND HIGH WATER

That afternoon, Dr. Levy calls me into the clinical wing to talk to a patient who wants to keep her baby but is in dire need of social services. I walk her through some basic applications, and Dr. Levy pops back in with a sample pack of prenatal vitamins after we're finished. As soon as I step out, I'm asked to sit with a patient who is resting after a procedure to clear out a miscarriage.

"She just needs someone to talk to, and I have other patients. But call me if you need anything," Dan explains. He and Nina, our two wonderful nurses, seem particularly harried with our load today, so I'm happy to sit and listen as the patient vents. She started miscarrying at twelve weeks in Texas and was told it hadn't progressed enough for the doctors to provide treatment—there was still the barest flicker of electrical signals. Her friend had a miscarriage last year, went into sepsis, and almost died, so she decided she wanted a D&C right away, got on a plane, and saw us the next day. She wants a baby and is hoping she can conceive again soon. She's strong and resourceful—and, as she acknowledges, lucky to have the money for a last-minute flight. I mostly offer affirming responses. Eventually Dr. Levy comes in to discharge her, and the woman hugs me before she leaves. It's a nice surprise, and I find myself smiling as I turn to Dr. Levy.

"It's a good thing she came in," Dr. Levy says. "The stories from there—horrificing." She looks like she's going to say more, but her cell phone rings. "I

have to take this, but wait a moment, will you?”

I take a couple of steps back as she answers her phone, and my good mood instantly vanishes. “Dr. Levy, how can I—Janey? What’s wrong?”

Janey is her child, eight years old and, from my few interactions with her, as tough as her mom. I retreat farther down the hallway but try to listen in.

“You—you’re safe?... With the teacher? Okay. Did you see?... No, baby. Have your teacher give it to Dad when he gets there, okay? I’m so sorry. I’m so sorry. It’s going to be okay. Can I talk to Mrs. Genard?... Thank you for staying a bit later. She shouldn’t be taking the bus. You must know... Is there security footage?... I’ll file a police report if that’s what it takes. It’s disgusting... We get things in the mail, but to threaten my daughter in person? She didn’t mention a... So it was a message for me?... Yes, my husband will collect it, and he will want to speak to the principal. Yes, okay. Thank you.”

Dr. Levy’s eyes are heavy, her shoulders slumped as she turns back to me. “In the chaos of the post-soccer pickup, someone shoved a bloodied baby doll into my Janey’s hands. It had the words ‘Your Mother Did This’ written on the front, and apparently there was a note addressed to me on the back.”

I don’t know how to react appropriately. I am so damn mad for her and her daughter I want to punch a wall. Dr. Levy is the heart of this place, so of course the antis will stop at nothing to hurt her.

“I’m so sorry,” I say at last.

“Yes, well. It’s not the first mutilated doll I’ve received, but going after my daughter? I’m going to find the parent who did that, and I’m going to destroy them. Once I get the footage—” Her phone rings again, and I notice her hands are shaking as she answers. “How is she?... She’s a strong kid, but how fucking dare they... I’ll wait.” She puts herself on mute and turns her phone on speaker. “My husband is a lawyer. The principal will be showing him the security footage any moment now, I’m sure.”

“Hello?” her husband says. He has a commanding voice, and I straighten as Dr. Levy unmutes herself.

“Yes?”

“We’re watching now... that’s him!” he exclaims. “Some man shoved—he’s leaving. Wait, rewind.” We both hover around the phone expectantly.

“That’s not a parent,” says another voice. The principal, maybe.

“A man was loitering across the street, walked in behind a group of parents, threatened Janey, and then just left.”

“How did they know what she looked like? Are we being surveilled? How could they allow a random person on school grounds?” Anybody else listening to Dr. Levy would think she was completely in control, but having worked with her, I can tell there’s real panic in her voice.

“Janey’s been in the school paper before,” her husband says. “Any stalker could have—but how could they just walk in?”

“They shouldn’t have been able to.” The principal does sound apologetic, but it’s too little, too late. “They should have been checked in by the gate monitor. Look. All the other parents show ID. But he just waltzed by, like magic. We will have to review our security protocols. You have my sincere apology. This was unacceptable.”

There’s a crinkling of paper against the phone, and then Dr. Levy’s husband says, “We will be taking this to the police. The note—it’s a threat. ‘Whether you do this the easy way or the hard way, we will prevail, and your den of sin will be destroyed.’”

Dr. Levy meets my eyes. I wonder if she sees guilt there. I recognize those words. Asmodeus is making good on his threat. *Like magic*. He is coming for the clinic, and it’s my fault.

—

I stick by Dr. Levy’s side as much as possible for the rest of the afternoon, though she pulls herself together fast. I ask her twice if I can do anything to help, but she says her husband has it handled. Though she is rattled, she keeps her appointments.

“They’ve traveled a thousand miles to be here, and I’m going to what, chicken out?”

Still, at the end of the day, she squeezes my shoulder, and I can tell my presence helped. Little does she know I’m trying to ease my own conscience. It’s already getting dark when I leave, and I’m not surprised when Aai calls. She’s

been trying to reach me, and though I don't want to talk to her again, I can't ignore her call.

"Nisha, a friend of yours is here," she says. Her voice sounds strained.

"JJ?" I ask. It would be weird for her to show up unannounced, but maybe she's struggling with the fire and looking for me.

"He says you have a mutual friend... Asmodee? Some odd name."

My heart stops, followed by a moment of total stillness in my body. My surroundings just... stop. I want to fall on my knees, or tear my hair out. But I'm frozen.

"That's not a friend."

In Marathi, Aai says, "I opened the door and he forced his way in. Who is this?"

There's nothing I can do. I am absolutely powerless. If whoever Asmodeus has sent wants to hurt Aai, he will be able to do so before I can make a single move. I never told Aai about the demons, because I thought she would call me crazy. Because I didn't want Aai to panic. Because I'm an idiot.

"What does he want?" I ask instead.

"Excellent question," I hear an unfamiliar voice say in the background. "Ma'am, may I speak to Nisha?"

"Give him the phone," I tell Aai. Then in Marathi, I add, "Our doctor's daughter was just attacked. The clinic is getting more dangerous. Once he has the phone, say you're going to the bathroom and leave the house. Do not be in the same room as him."

Aai passes the phone, and I hear her murmur about going to the bathroom.

"Hello."

"So you're the new puppet?"

"Don't fear for your mother. I won't hurt her."

"What is Asmodeus doing?" I can hardly breathe. The night closes in.

"He's getting what he wants," he says. "He's done waiting. His benevolent offer of magic for a blessing is off the table. You will—" He breaks off. "Your mother made a run for it. Smarter than she seems, hmm? It doesn't matter. We know how to reach her. It will be nothing for us to end her life, but if you give

him your magic, she will live. You will live. That is the bargain now. Understood?”

“You threatened an eight-year-old. Why should I trust that you won’t just kill us both after I give you what you want?” I ask, crying.

“Make your decision. Now. Or I’ll track down your mother and—”

“I’ll do it,” I say. “I swear. I just—let me get my affairs in order. I’ll meet you outside my apartment, Wednesday morning.”

“I suppose he can wait until Wednesday... but he will meet you outside your clinic.”

“But—”

“Do you think you can dictate your own terms? He will meet you at your clinic. Make your peace.”

There is only one reason he would want to meet me at the clinic. Already I can imagine everyone there dead because of me. But the idea of Aai—I can’t even finish the thought. I tested his patience. I wanted to be strong, to stand up to the bad guy. But now, I’ll still have to give this demon my power, and he will make me suffer, for no other reason than his vengefulness.

—

By the time I make it home, Aai has texted me that she is back in her house, locked in and secure. My training has paid off, though, because despite my fear and turmoil, I scan my surroundings the way Muya taught me and see a demon at my front door. I squint, preparing myself to run, and realize it’s Muya himself.

“Thank gods,” I say. “Asmodeus—he threatened my Aai. He threatened my friend’s child. I don’t know what to do.”

Muya’s smile slips. “There goes the mood,” he says, before drawing a key card from his pocket. It has an address printed on it. “I stole this from the protester when I induced his seizure. I sensed he knew more than the others under Asmodeus’s influence. It’s for an office space in Edison Park. I thought you might want to investigate with me.”

“Right now?”

“You said yourself that your Aai is being threatened. It doesn’t sound like we have much time.”

Five minutes later, I’m on the bus with Muya, both of us silent and contemplative. We only start talking once we’ve disembarked, because Edison Park is quiet after dark.

“That anti you stole it from, he wasn’t a demon, was he?”

“No.”

“So then how will his key card help us?”

“I’m just following my instincts.” I don’t respond, and Muya motions toward a building. “This is the one.”

“Not worried about cameras?” I ask. “Can they also ‘become ignorant’?”

“In a manner of speaking. I’ve been working on it,” he says. His response doesn’t give me a ton of confidence, so I tug my hood over my head and bundle my scarf up so my face is barely visible. Muya frowns at me, sensing my unease. “Is something the matter? I thought we came to an understanding.”

“Just remembering that you tried to kill someone today.”

“I was trying to steal this key for you, and I had to cover my tracks. I thought it would make you happy, since he’s one of your enemies.”

“Don’t try to put this on me. I don’t want them to die! I just want them to change their minds or leave us alone.”

Muya snorts. “You’d probably have more luck with murder, but fine. Let’s go.”

I follow him through the office door and into a hallway lit dimly with nighttime fluorescents. Muya walks past several offices, including a dentist and a pet toy company, until he arrives at an unmarked door. The card opens the lock, Muya flicks on the lights, and—

It’s a letdown. I was expecting, I don’t know, a conspiracy-theory corkboard, or a demonic altar of some kind. But it’s just a small, open office filled with cubicles and desktop monitors, a cookie-cutter start-up space. Muya surveys it with a look of disappointment.

“This is it?” he says, as if to himself.

“Are you sure we have the right place?” I ask.

He gestures to the key, then offers me his hand, which I take as an invitation to combine our magic to search deeper. Muya issues a general instruction: *Lift the veil of ignorance*. Nothing happens.

“Damn,” he mutters. “Since we don’t know what we’re looking for, it’s hard to channel the magic to find it.”

My whole life is at risk; the water level is above my eyes. I can’t give up now. We’ll just have to resort to old-fashioned sleuthing. There are dinosaurs at every company who keep printouts. We’re already here, and I’m desperate. I approach the first under-desk mini file cabinet. It has its own lock, and the part of me that’s read too many crime novels pulls on a pair of gloves. For once I’m thankful for Chicago winters, since they’ve prepared me for this moment. I shake the cabinet a little bit and it sounds empty. I move on to the next. Muya follows my lead and tries the next one after that. My mind races as I remember we’re trespassing, with no guarantee of success. But then I shake the next cabinet and it’s so full I can’t even move it. I pull out my wallet, where I always keep an extra bobby pin. My hands are shaking so badly, I worry I’m going to leave an obvious scratch. I take a deep breath, focusing on the sensation of my knees against the floor to ground me. After a few seconds, the drawer springs open.

I reach in and pull out what looks like a financial report listing various office expenses. Boring. The next document is more of the same. Halfway down the stack, I find a memo. At first, I assume it’s again unhelpful but then see that it is addressed to the Rogers Park Pregnancy Center. It sounds familiar. In the letter, written in January, one of the center’s donors, “Mr. Fleming,” expresses interest in shutting down our clinic, calling it a “node point,” a place that doesn’t provide a particularly high volume of abortions, but whose functioning is necessary for other clinics to stay open. He describes the potential domino effect if our clinic fails. I flip the page, and my heart stops. There, clearly printed, is my name. All of our names are in this document. Diane, Dr. Levy, Geeta, the nurses, other administrative staff. Next to each person’s name are a few notes, mostly publicly available information, but beside mine, I read “potentially swayable.” There’s nothing different about my profile that might make them think that. Perhaps it’s my age? I’m the youngest by a mile.

I keep reading, but unfortunately, the letter doesn't offer many more details. I pass it on to Muya and keep searching the space. By the time I've finished checking two more cabinets and come up empty-handed, he's done reading it.

"See?" he says. "They could be working with *him*."

"The clinic faced several threats before you demons got involved. And I don't see any proof on this single sheet of paper—one that we had to commit a *crime* to find—that the people behind this sham 'pregnancy center' are under Asmodeus's influence." Even as I say it, though, I remember why the center's name sounds familiar. The man at the Art Institute gala mentioned it.

Outside, I hear the sound of a police siren. My eyes snap to Muya, but he doesn't look afraid or worried. I creep toward the back door of the office.

"We have to go," I whisper. The sound is getting closer.

"You're going to abandon this now?" Muya's voice hardens. "Just when we might actually discover something? What, too scared to uphold your end of the deal?"

A door opens nearby and I don't wait a moment longer before sneaking out the back and running until I've reached the bus station. Muya can take care of himself.

Despite the fatigue seeping into me, there's only one option left after a night of false starts and half-truths: I have to dance.



USHA

Usha was born into calamity. Her father was killed by British invaders for a crime he did not commit, and her mother died in childbirth. Her mother's elder sister, Radhabai, was a midwife and could not forgive herself for failing to save the most important patient of her career. Although Radhabai was plagued by deep melancholy, she took in Usha, who grew up a happy and determined child. Her aunt would not let her out of her sight, and so at a young age Usha became accustomed to all the features of pregnancy and childbirth: the screaming babies, the pain and blood as the mothers sought to push their children safely into the world, the happiness after success, the despair after failure. The death. There was never any question that Usha would become a midwife, too.

Radhabai told Usha stories of her family's past. All families wanted to believe their ancestors had been great, gifted with magic that changed the course of history. There were some odd features of the tales Radhabai told: the storied were all women, they each did unglamorous things, and the gift skipped generations. But Usha ascribed these peculiarities to Radhabai's natural eccentricities. When Usha entered adulthood without gaining any new abilities, she did not give magic any further thought.

Magic was dying out as humanity succumbed to the endless industrialization of the world. As the number of healers dwindled, Usha's calm head and steady hands put her in high demand in Pune's bustling streets. By day, she treated the wives of some of the wealthiest merchants and most respected officers in the city. By evening, she attended meetings about self-determination and tended to women living in the slums. And by night, she was known to have herbs that could help a woman who had too many mouths to feed already, whose husband

beat her, who was unmarried and would be cast out. She slept only occasionally, and she was content.

One day, before dawn, she was summoned to the house of a woman who had received a physical abortion from a man who worked like a butcher. Despite her best efforts, Usha could not save her. She went home to wash off the blood, and no sooner had she finished than she was called to the house of a wealthy family. The Joshis were fixtures of the community, and Usha had delivered the heir to the family after a labor so long and grueling that a lesser midwife might have lost her patient. When Usha placed the baby boy in his father's arms, the man promised Usha she had a friend for life.

And so Usha went to the Joshis without complaint, without sleep, and was shown into a room where two women sat. Her former patient greeted her and introduced her husband's widowed sister, who kept her eyes fixed on the ground. The widow remained silent as her sister-in-law explained that she was pregnant, the product of a shameful affair. Usha was told that the widow must have an abortion.

"I could marry him!" the widow shouted without warning, and Usha recognized a fire within her. "He is Brahmin. We could marry, have the child—"

Her sister-in-law slapped her cleanly across the face. Usha did her best not to flinch.

"You have already brought enough shame into this household," she hissed. "You know you cannot remarry, and the cook's son is entirely unsuitable no matter his caste. You will remember your place."

Usha would not treat a patient against their will, no matter how difficult a situation it put her in. But she also could not refuse aid, knowing what might happen to this woman if she kept the child. It was true that despite the recent British interference in the laws around widowhood, there was little chance this woman could remarry without attracting judgment and stigma from the entire community.

"The herbs that bring about such results are quite potent," Usha said. "I would not recommend them until you are absolutely sure. In two weeks' time, if you still have not had your bloods and are set on this course, send for me."

She left lost in thought about how best to help the widow. Sometimes, in the meetings she attended, her comrades spoke of reforming the laws that forced women into these choices. Perhaps someone there—

She collided with a warm body.

“My apologies,” said an unfamiliar man. “Usha, yes?”

She studied him. Something within her recognized him, although she had never seen him in her life. His skin was the light brown of the wealthy, his hair short and curly. His eyes, though, were vaguely golden.

“Do I know you?”

“No,” he said. “But I know you. I have been watching over your people for centuries.”

She laughed at that. “All right. Have a good day.”

“Your friends, they are dangerous. I did not think you needed protection, but under the current circumstances...” His hand brushed her, and Usha gasped. Her mind opened at his touch.

“Who *are* you?”

“My name is Muya,” he said with a small smile. “I have lifted the veil of ignorance from you. Use it well.”

Something caught her eye—a person walking on the opposite side of the street. He seemed perfectly ordinary, and yet Usha could see across his shoulders a cape of power. When she turned back, Muya was gone.

Instinct made Usha stay her tongue and keep this new power to herself. There were other problems to focus upon: the butcher was killing more women, the British were tightening their control, there were whispers of a poor harvest. And then, the worst happened. One week after leaving the Joshis, Usha was summoned to their home in the dead of night, and arrived to find the widow bleeding out. Usha’s caution had killed her.

Usha resolved to find the butcher and send him away from her city. She could not stomach watching one more woman slip away after his ministrations. But just as she arrived, so too did the police, and with a nasty smile, the butcher pointed to her as his accomplice. After all, it was undisputed that Usha provided abortions, and the British had recently made such terminations a crime. They were here to save the souls of the heathens. Nothing Usha said swayed them, and

when she asked to speak to the Joshis, nobody came for her. It was Radhabai who finally bribed the guards to release her, but Usha knew that would not be the end of it.

She sought out her friends, the ones who held meetings to speak about self-determination, and discovered that protecting the practice of abortion was not all that important to them. They had lofty ideals with which to be concerned. She left the meeting alone, friendless, and hopeless. It was then that Muya appeared again. He came to her house in the night, and against her better judgment, she let him in. Nothing in the world had seemed quite right since she'd met him, and perhaps he could set things right.

"I am sorry," he said. "I did not want for you to get in so much trouble."

It took a moment for Usha to realize his meaning, but when she did, she was incandescent with rage. "You had me arrested?" His wince was all the answer she needed. "My whole life is in ruins because of you! What possible reason could you have? What are you, a demon?"

"So what if I am?" Muya retorted. "That has nothing to do with what happened."

"Oh my gods," Usha muttered. "You cursed me, didn't you? What possible threat can one woman be to you?"

"You'd be surprised," Muya responded. "Your forebears have caused me plenty of trouble. But please believe me when I say, you were just collateral damage in my hunt to destroy a disease in the heart of this city. I will do my best to get you out of this, but your friends—"

"I don't have friends anymore," Usha said. "Get out."

She devised a plan to rid herself of this curse. Clearly this man had brought misfortune upon her. Perhaps upon generations of her family. After all, hadn't they all encountered great calamities? She had to rid this world of him once and for all, but he had made himself scarce, and Usha could not determine the nature of the curse. She could see the power within those few she knew to be gifted, as she did in sacred animals and temples. The Joshis' house also seemed oddly veiled in magic. She was afraid of going back there after they had abandoned her, but it occurred to her that this horrible demon might have convinced them that she was responsible for their great misfortune. If she cleared the air, maybe they

would help her. It was not a good plan, but she was desperate. She had heard stories of what the British did to make examples of those who broke the law.

When she arrived, she was shown to the candlelit sitting room by a servant and left alone with a fine statue of Lord Nataraja. In the flickering light, it looked like it was moving. Dancing. Nataraja was laughing, his feet trampling the demon of ignorance. She recognized something in that statue. It reminded her of—

“What are you doing here?” Muya demanded. She jumped away.

“What are you—why are you here? Are you going to manipulate this poor family even further?”

“I’d hardly call it manipulation,” Muya responded. “Do they not deserve it? They have betrayed you. Betrayed all their kinsmen. I don’t know why you’re here, but I suggest you leave.”

He stepped closer to her until they were only a foot or two apart, his features now in full view. He had never looked more inhuman than in this shadowy room. Her eyes darted to the statue, where Apasmara lay prone. She at last understood, too late. He raised a hand as if to touch it, but stopped a finger’s length away from the metal.

“It is dangerous.”

“How so?” Usha asked. “It is just a statue.”

He laughed, and it was obvious he was laughing at her. “It depicts perpetual punishment, and yet is the object of worship. Is that not heinous?”

He was afraid of the statue for a reason. She had heard tales of people who trapped demons in rocks, and more importantly, she had nothing to lose. In one sweeping motion, she grabbed Muya’s fingers and slammed their joined hands into the statue, their skin opening and blood mixing on the metal. Muya cried out, and she did, too. She could feel Muya’s power begin to separate from her soul, so she tugged on it, pushing it into the statue. She focused all her rage, and pain, and hopelessness, until there was nothing left, not even consciousness.

When she awoke, it was to a great emptiness. The magic was gone. The candles had blown out, and she was in total darkness.

“Muya?” she asked, her voice a tremble. There was no response, but she could sense the change in her. She felt light. Free.

We are brave, Usha says. Choose to be bold.



DELUSIONS OF GRANDEUR

I grew up believing I was destined for something great. When I was in high school, I thought I would become a senator or a Supreme Court justice. Somebody special, somebody who could change the world. Adulthood kicked me in the ass. When I had my freak accident, I realized that if I had died, my life would have meant nothing. I was hit by a car and then forgotten in an ER hallway for hours until I almost died. Nobody would take my case or help me sue the hospital, because they didn't care. I had cost Aai so much money, so much pain, for nothing. I was helpless, powerless, too weak and tired to rebuild my life.

And if I had died in the fire, I would have died the world's biggest idiot, because this whole time I've trusted Muya, and this whole time, he's been a traitor. He's probably working with Asmodeus, and they're laughing at me right now, a classic good cop, bad cop duo. They'll end up with my power one way or another. He tried to set me up, just the way he did Usha, and I walked right into his trap. Every time Muya told me that he hated humans, that he thought me beneath him and his notice, he was telling me the truth and I still fell for it all. And because of my own stupidity, I have put Aai in danger. I call her before I can second-guess myself.

"Aai, I have something to tell you."

“What the hell is going on with your clinic?” she demands immediately. “Are you being threatened? It’s time to leave.”

“It’s not that. It’s...” I know she’s going to think I’m crazy, and the words get stuck in my throat. At last, I manage, “It’s a demon.” There’s total silence on the other end, which I take as my cue to confess everything that’s happened—the Art Institute, Muya, Asmodeus, the dancing visions. “I know I sound insane, but it’s true, and—”

“That man today. He didn’t feel right. I took one look at him and wanted to pray.”

“He was under a demon’s influence, that’s why. Human, but controlled by a demon.” *Like me.* It makes me sick to think of Muya’s power inside me, to think of what he put Usha through. Usha, whose work was so similar to mine. The song remains the same.

Aai FaceTimes me. The moment I pick up, she starts moving her fists in circles, whispering to herself. I recognize it immediately as a ritual to dispel the evil eye. We are well beyond that, but I obediently fake blow on the camera and hang up as she leaves to toss salt down the drain.

When she calls back, she says, “You need to stay with me. It’s too dangerous for you to be alone.”

“It won’t help. You’re in danger, too. Maybe you should stay with Rima Aunty.”

“I’ll come stay with you. I’ll be there in an hour.” I hear movement in the background, as though she’s already started packing.

“Aai. No.”

“Last time I checked, I’m your mother. I tell you what to do, not the other way around.”

“Let’s not start—”

“You’re in danger! You cannot expect me to do nothing.”

I hate hearing the anger and hurt in her voice. She has a point. “You’re right, I’m in danger. But I also have powers to protect myself, and...”

“What, you think I can’t take care of myself? You think I’ll get in your way?” I pinch my leg in frustration, because that’s exactly what I think, but I can’t say that. In the pause, she adds, “Have you even been eating properly?”

“Seriously?” I snap. “We’re talking about demons and you’re asking if I’m eating right? This is not the time.” I take a deep breath, and say more calmly, “I know I haven’t given you a lot of reason to trust me, but I need you to trust me right now. I’ll give you my location, so you can check where I am whenever you want. And if I don’t respond to your texts quickly enough, then you can come find me. But right now, I need some space to figure this out. Please.”

There’s a long silence on the other end. Then she says, “At least consider quitting your job. I know you can find a different one. These demons are attacking your clinic, you’ve said it yourself. If you remove yourself, you’ll keep yourself safe. And it might help keep your clinic safe, too, yes?”

“I can’t. Aai, you know that. What I need from you is information. What do you know about Muya? What stories were you told about him?”

“There aren’t many,” Aai says. “Only that Shiva defeated Apasmara and dances on top of him to keep him at bay. He’s dangerous.”

“I know that,” I say. “But how do I stop him?”

“You should try praying.”

“Aai—”

“What, demons are real but my prayers are not?” That shuts me up, and she continues, “I’ll talk to some friends and go to the mandir to ask some of the gurujis. And I’ll read up online. I’m sure all the good sources will be in Hindi or Sanskrit, so I will translate them for you. Don’t worry, Nisha.”

—

The next day I lie in bed, paralyzed by visions of death and despair, until the doorbell rings. It turns out to be JJ, holding a take-out bag filled with chocolate chip pancakes and blueberry French toast. We used to do brunch all the time in college. I drag myself out of bed to let her in. She tidies up my neglected kitchen while I brush my teeth, and then we eat and chat about the various Netflix shows we’ve been watching. Eventually, the conversation turns to Aaron.

“Why are you letting him work at the clinic?” JJ asks with a wrinkle of her nose.

“I’m not *letting* him do anything. It wasn’t exactly my call, and he’s provided a lot of abortions since he’s been there.”

“Don’t you think that makes him inconstant?” she argues around a massive bite of pancake stack.

“I have to hope he’s changed...”

“Or he’d be like that resident in the news,” she says. “What a disaster.”

“What are you talking about?”

“Oh, I wouldn’t worry!” Her tone is bright, but at my anxious expression she pulls up something on her phone and turns it toward me.

It’s an article headlined, *Medical Resident Sues After Being Fired by Program*. The subheading explains, *Dr. John Doe alleges that he was fired by his obstetrics program after refusing to provide abortions on religious grounds, but in a press release the program stated that Doe was fired because of mounting evidence that he was recording abortion patients and sabotaging abortion-related equipment*. My stomach drops as I skim the article. John Doe doesn’t contest that he was secretly voice-recording appointments, breaking machinery, and trying to talk patients out of having abortions. He only claims that these actions were normal, valid responses to being “forced” to provide abortions. The program director gives a comprehensive statement explaining that the organization grants religious exemptions to residents who request them, but Doe never asked. He states that Doe in fact volunteered to assist with abortions, and that the program is investigating whether Doe was purposefully infiltrating the program to try to “expose” its practice—they are considering legal action against Doe for clips of counseling sessions posted online. Doe has already found another placement at a religious hospital.

Could Aaron be doing something like this? I remember his past betrayal like a gut punch. It was JJ who noticed Aaron first. I was so focused on getting her into the clinic that I didn’t bother glancing at the protesters. But JJ was nervous about getting her IUD, and trying to stall, when she made eye contact with Aaron. She grabbed my hand, and I knew immediately she had seen something scary; we were in sync back then. I looked up and—

It was as though lightning struck us both. I am sure it looked like I was the patient, JJ the protector. I know what Aaron thought in the moment. He was

wrong. All I could think about was what an utter *idiot* I was. But I still texted him. I thought maybe we could talk it out. JJ told me not to, and then held me when I cried after Aaron Robinson made it clear he never wanted to speak to me again. She rubbed my back and reminded me over and over that he wasn't worth it. I cried over an anti. I'm still embarrassed about it, but at this point it's no longer even in my top ten worst moments.

"He wouldn't do this, right?" I say. "What if it's some anti plan to send a bunch of undercover residents to abortion providers?"

"I didn't mean to freak you out," JJ says. "There's not a big conspiracy."

I snort. How wonderfully naive. "You remember what he was like then. What's more likely, that he's really changed or that he's faking it?"

"He sucks, but I mean, if you had been doing what he thought you were doing, I get why he'd be mad. Super shitty to ghost you and make assumptions without hearing you out, of course, but it's hardly on the same level as this."

I chew my piece of French toast to give myself time to think. I realize that JJ doesn't know how this story ended. I went alone. I told nobody. Still, I want to defend myself from the implication.

"It would have been fine, though, don't you think? If he was an anti, he didn't have a right to know... If that's what I had been doing."

JJ looks at me like I'm crazy. For a moment, I see a flicker of something dance across her face. "Of course he would have had a right to know! It would have been his baby. It would have been unforgivable if you"—she swallows as though the idea horrifies her—"aborted it without telling him."

My cheeks burn and I look away.

—

That evening, I see a bizarre message from Aai.

I was talking to Rima about demons—don't worry, no specifics—and she told me that Shreya Pillai does that research.

Shreya Pillai is a doctor.

The Pillais never shut up about it.

Doctor of Philosophy, according to Rima.

Google is free and confirms Aai's story. I find an article Shreya wrote titled, "Anti-Demon Propaganda as a Form of Colonial Control." I've known Shreya my whole life, so it's hard to believe that this author could be the same perfect eldest daughter I grew up being endlessly compared to. But I click on her bio, and it's unmistakably her. She's two years older than me, and we were always friendly at parties and gatherings, but she shone so brightly that it was hard to be too close to her. Shreya got a *1600* on her SATs. Shreya went to *Harvard*. Shreya was a *doctor*. It was hard not to feel pathetic in comparison. I assumed she was a Goody Two-shoes, judgmental, uninteresting carbon copy of her parents, and shared their occasionally troubling views. Now I'm realizing that I didn't really know Shreya at all. She might be cool, actually.

And more importantly, she might be helpful.

Before I can stop myself, I dial her number. I don't think I've ever called her in my life, and yet on the third ring, she picks up.

"Hello, this is Shreya." She sounds warm, confident.

"Hey, Shreya, it's Nisha."

"Oh, hey. I thought it might be a butt dial or something."

"No, sorry, is this a bad time? I should have texted or—"

"Are you okay? You sound a bit stressed."

"I'm fine, sorry."

"You don't need to keep apologizing," she says. "So... what's up?"

"I know this is super out of the blue, but I was just doing some research and I came across one of your papers. I didn't know you had a PhD!"

"I never thought you were the type to judge." The warmth is gone, replaced by an icy affect.

"No, no! Shit, this is coming out all wrong. I think your research sounds very interesting. I admire you for devoting so much time and energy and creativity to it. I just had no idea."

She snorts, followed by a sigh. “Sorry to snap at you. It’s just most of the people we grew up with aren’t very kind about it, especially because my parents insisted on acting like I had an MD.”

“*What will people say?*” I joke, and she laughs.

“I’m sure you get that all the time, too,” Shreya says. “I always thought you were so fucking brave, girl. Doing the work that needs to be done, and never caring what anyone else thought.”

“Thanks,” I whisper.

“So, you were doing research for work? How can I help?”

“It’s more of a personal project.” Part of me wishes I could tell her the whole story. The rest of me knows she’ll think I’m crazy. “I went down an internet rabbit hole. Demons, aliens, that kind of thing. I noticed that every culture has stories of demons walking among us, wielding supernatural powers, performing magic that nobody else can comprehend. I’m doing a... comparative study of different cultural myths across history. It’s part distraction, part preliminary research for a cultural competency module.”

“Well, if you do turn this into a lesson, keep in mind that people still write about demon sightings, though mostly in rural, less-inhabited areas,” Shreya says immediately. “Less so in America, but it’s not out of the realm of possibility that you could see a patient who believes in them. Demons and magic have long served as a way to explain the unexplainable world. Some days I wish they were real, but unfortunately, people have always been behind the ills of the world. It’s actually the focus of my current research—the use of demons in mythmaking and storytelling as a means of deflection. Demonic rationales for the despicable acts carried out by powerful humans. It’s so much more convenient to have a demon to slay.”

“I guess,” I say. I thought her words would relax me, but they don’t. I know what I’ve been living. “Thank you for your time. I’m sorry again to call you out of the blue.”

“Please,” Shreya says with a laugh. “I always wished we were better friends, but I figured you were a little too cool for me.”

“Me?” I let out an incredulous huff.

“Yes, you! You did what you wanted to do, you make a difference, you speak your mind. Trust me, at least half the desi kids who know you want to be you.”

I find myself unexpectedly touched. “Do you want to grab coffee sometime?”

“I’d love that. When works for you? I’ll bring some books you might like, to help with your project.”

I try to laugh, but it comes out strangled. Maybe one day someone will write a book about me, a person so deep in delusion she thought demons were real—or worse, proved that they were.



ROAD LESS TRAVELED

When I arrive on Monday morning, there are two escorts already outside who seem to be doing just fine. I head to my temporary desk, which is basically a supply closet, and sort through my emails. There's one from a local college we partner with on sexual health education, asking us to table at a fair in April, the week after Easter. Another is from a business owner down the street, and at first I'm worried—the businesses near us suffer from their proximity, since the protesters turn customers away. But they're also largely run by South Asian immigrants who show us kindness. Sure enough, it's a sweet email, asking if we're all right and offering parking spaces to our patients if needed. I set an alarm on my phone to remind myself to personally walk over and thank them after work. My inbox also has a lovely little shooting threat that made it through my spam filter. I forward it to security, and I'm about to read it more closely to see if there's anything in it that may relate to Asmodeus when in walks Aaron.

"Are you all right? You look..." He trails off when he realizes there's no good way to finish that sentence.

"I look what?" I ask, my tone sharper than he probably deserves.

"Tired?"

"Are you telling me that with everything going on, you're sleeping well?" I ask.

"I'm a resident," he answers, as though it explains anything.

We stand in awkward silence for a few moments before he says, “I had a quick break between patients and wanted to make sure you’re doing okay. And I was thinking... I would love to catch up with you sometime.”

“Aren’t we caught up?” I ask.

“I meant over dinner?” When he sees my face, he backtracks, “Or maybe coffee? As colleagues?”

There’s very little I want to do less, but I haven’t forgotten my previous suspicions about him and I probably shouldn’t close the door on an investigative opportunity. “Maybe sometime,” I say, and then before he can do something awkward like follow up with a date or time my phone starts ringing. I put a smile on my face before I start talking.

“Hi, Dr. Levy. Problem in the clinic?” Aaron takes this as his cue to rush off, presumably to attend to whatever duties he was shirking.

“It’s been a morning,” she says with a sigh.

“It’s nine forty-five. Want me to run out and grab you a coffee?” She would never ask me to do it, but Dr. Levy is critical to this clinic’s survival, and I would do literally anything for her.

“No, I need you to come down to room five. The patient said it was fine to share information with another employee.” Although this is obvious, and we are all beholden by HIPAA, Dr. Levy puts lots of checkpoints in place to make sure we’re never violating patient autonomy. I feel sick thinking about whether I’m going to be able to protect her in return. “The social worker’s kids are home sick, and I think there’s something off.”

“Abuse?” I ask. It’s important to be as prepared as possible.

“No...” Dr. Levy draws out the word. “Never say never. I wouldn’t rule it out. But more like, she doesn’t seem to actually want the abortion. Obviously I’ll give it to her if that’s what she wants, but if she’s being coerced somehow...”

Sometimes we get people in here who desperately want a baby, but their boss or their landlord or someone else with power over them has told them they must get an abortion. Not infrequently, we perform the procedure, because at the end of the day, they’re making an informed choice from an array of shitty options. However, we’ve developed enough contacts with pro bono attorneys and

various counseling and placement services that sometimes we can present alternatives.

I pass through the waiting room and see a patient crying. Diane is speaking to them in low, soothing tones and locks eyes with me as I pass. She makes an eye movement that I understand to mean the protesters did something heinous. I double my pace. I used to have these fantasies when I first started that someone—maybe even me—would give a rousing speech about the protesters' hypocrisy and they'd finally see the truth. It's embarrassing to even admit that to myself now. Jesus Christ himself could come down and tell them he thought abortion was acceptable and they would crucify him all over again.

I knock on the door of room 5 and hear a voice say, "Come in." The curtain is drawn around the exam table.

"May I pull the curtain?" I ask.

"Yes."

I draw it back and sit down. There's a South Asian woman sitting on the edge of the examination table, her arms wrapped tightly around herself. "If you're more comfortable, I can close the curtain," I offer. "Whatever works for you."

"Are you another doctor?" she asks. Her voice is shaking. She has a strong accent.

"No, actually. My name is Nisha. I work in community relations here at the clinic. Dr. Levy asked me to come talk to you because she thought you might want more information before choosing your treatment." It's important not to phrase it as offering anything, because people can feel defensive.

"I'm Divya," she says with a small smile.

"Nice to meet you, Divya. Now, I want you to know that you don't have to talk to me. Dr. Levy will still treat you no matter what. I'm just trying to make sure you have as much time and information as possible. If you want to send me out, there will be no hard feelings. Your medical treatment isn't contingent on it."

"That's okay." Divya fidgets a little. "I'm happy to talk to you."

"Great. Well, Dr. Levy mentioned you came here because you're thinking about an abortion, is that right?"

“Yes.” I can tell by her demeanor that she has more to say, and so I smile and nod for her to continue. “I want the baby!” she bursts out. “I wish I didn’t have to get an abortion. I’m not irresponsible.” I wish I could tell her that responsibility doesn’t matter to us, but I know she’s only trying to cope; it’s not my place to correct her.

“It sounds like this is a really hard decision for you.” Divya nods, then raises her head to look at me. I see a glint around her neck, a gold chain with black beads. “Is that a mangalsutra?”

“Yes!” She pulls it out from under her patient robe, and I see it’s a traditional two-bowl pendant.

“It’s beautiful.”

“My husband picked it out,” she says. Her smile is still soft and real. “We want a baby so badly. He doesn’t know I’m pregnant. He doesn’t know I’m here.” She drops the mangalsutra, her cheeks coloring.

“Do you feel safe with your husband?” I ask. It’s a delicate question, but I have to ask.

She nods firmly. “Yes, of course. I don’t want to break his heart. He would be so sad, and I love him. I can’t do that to him.”

“That’s very kind of you.”

“But I have to get the abortion,” she says. “I can’t lose my job. We’re barely making it as it is.”

“Can you tell me more?” I ask her. Just telling her that it’s illegal to fire someone for being pregnant is not helpful, since employers still do it all the time. When you’re a minimum wage worker, as Divya might be, pretty much anything goes. Nobody has the time or money to sue.

“I work not far from here, serving food in one of the shops on Devon. Last month, my friend got fired for being pregnant, as soon as she started showing. It was for poor performance, they said, but it wasn’t true. She was the hardest worker, even though the smells were so hard for her. But our boss, she said that as soon as the girls start having babies, they’re unreliable. And nobody else will hire me, how I sound. I have tried. I was a nurse in India. But I don’t have papers. My visa expired, and...”

“It’s illegal to discriminate against anybody on the basis of pregnancy,” I tell her, speaking slowly and thinking as quickly as I can. I run through my mental list of the job placement agencies we’ve used before, but they struggle to place immigrants, especially undocumented ones. “But even if that’s the case, if an employer is fine with breaking the law and has a lot of power, there’s not a lot you can do.”

She frowns. “I know this. That is why I am here.”

“Can you wait one moment?” I ask her. “I want to help you find another job, but I need to speak with your doctor first.”

Divya nods. “I like you,” she says. “It is nice to see a face like yours.”

I smile at her, then draw the curtain and step outside. I’m searching for Dr. Levy when Aaron walks by.

“How is she?” he asks. “Dr. Levy briefed me.”

I step into room 3, two doors down, and he follows. “She thinks she’s going to get fired for being pregnant, and she’s undocumented.”

“I see.” His face gives nothing away.

“How far along is she?”

“Only five weeks,” Aaron says. “She was very proactive. Many people don’t even know they’re pregnant at five weeks.”

“Do you think she could wait for her abortion?” I ask. “Without risking worsening side effects?”

“Like I said, she came in early, so she has three weeks, maybe a month, and the medication would be just as effective. After that, it would be harder on her body—still safe, but if time off work is a concern...”

“That’s not a lot of time, but maybe...” I feel like I’m giving her false hope and prolonging the inevitable. But we have some pro bono immigration and employment lawyer connections, and we could ask some friendlier businesses to see if they’re hiring—I have to at least try, especially because she has more time than most patients.

“You could explore options, at least. And we can set up an appointment in three weeks, so that she’s all set if the leads don’t pan out.” There’s an odd expression on his face.

“What is it?”

“The patients who come to your clinic... it’s naive, I know, but I didn’t think that much about how nonmedical issues would impact pregnancies until I started here.”

“Better late than never,” I say. “You’re here now.”

I feel like a snake oil salesman when I offer Divya the option to wait so she can try to work with a lawyer to sort out her situation and find another job. Even though I repeat three times that there’s no guarantee, she immediately and enthusiastically agrees, thanking me over and over. It’s hard to tell if the pit in my stomach is because I feel like I’m leading her on or because I’m about to face the music.



A DANCE WITH THE DEVIL

The upside of all this demon chaos is that I'm getting much stronger from dancing. After a quick stretch, I move right into a warm-up tatkar. My arms don't burn and my calves are ready to spring into action. It's hard to believe I gave this up. Without bothering to play music, I transition into a set of todas, counting the bol under my breath. It's hard work, reciting and dancing at the same time, and I love it. I feel so connected, like I am rooted to the earth and blossoming, pouring out life. It's an incandescent, effervescent joy to spin and stamp and throw my hands up.

But I don't see any visions, and am offered no guidance as I move into a Shiva Tandava. I hear the words of the stotram in my head as I dance, music only I can hear. Perhaps there is nothing more to learn from the past, now that I've discovered the truth about Muya. I move from a sitting pose to standing, with my hand in front of my forehead signifying the third eye.

I think of Chandini, her quiet power, the greatest of them all.

I leap to one side to show Shiva's hair, extending to symbolize the Ganga flowing from it, then to the other side to show his snake necklace, a sharp, sudden motion.

I think of Usha, fighting threats in every corner until she was horribly betrayed.

I hold up my hand and shake it to symbolize the damaru, stamping a beat with my heel and toes.

I think of Tara, steady and strong, hardening her heart.

I jump into the dramatic Nataraja pose, then out of it to show a trident. I stab and claw as I become fearsome Shiva defeating his enemies.

I think of Laila, annihilating those who dared to sow destruction.

I am Shiva, fighting his enemies. I am Shiva, benevolent and auspicious. I am love, passion. I am Shiva dancing the Tandava. Shiva bringing destruction.

I think of Heera. Annoying, and yet...

I spin into the final beats of the Tandava, my arms moving into sum, triumphant. I stamp my feet to assume the final pose, panting.

“Well done,” a voice says. My eyes adjust from the spinning and I find Muya standing in my dark kitchen. “Was that a Shiva Tandava?”

“How did you get in here?” I ask. My chest is heaving, and I hope it disguises my fear. “I’m willing to scream.”

“Like you did the first several times we talked?” he asks. “You’re a good dancer, but surely there’s better subject matter. Krishna, perhaps?”

I thrust one of my feet forward at an angle my body instinctively knows, the first step of the Nataraja pose. Muya flinches ever so slightly. I grin, recalling something from the vision I had a week ago. I was so irritated by Heera that I failed to recognize the most important part of her story: she beat a demon.

“What do you want? I know who you really are now. You helped burn down my clinic, you tried to get us in trouble by almost killing a protester, and you nearly got me arrested. You can tell Asmodeus I know you’re working together, and I still have one more day before he comes for the clinic.” The energy from the dancing is leaving my body, and I take a step back to lean against the wall.

Muya stalks forward. “What are you talking about? I did what you asked. I got you into the office building. I came here to tell you that after you ran away like a coward, I couldn’t learn anything else. Your country is filled with dark networks of powerful people. Why go out of your way to blame me?”

“I know your game,” I tell him. “I know what you did to Usha. I’m not going to let you get anywhere near me. Besides, I know Asmodeus is the person pulling the strings. I’m not going to waste my time negotiating with you.”

“Usha?” he whispers as his face crumples. “Is that what this is about? What did I do to Usha? Tell me. I tried to help her, and she repaid me by trapping me. And now you take her side?”

“What are you talking about?”

“You’re an idiot!” Muya snaps. “She turned on me when I tried to warn her that her friends were foes. She might have been even stupider than you, and that’s saying something.”

“You ruined her life! You set her up!”

Muya tips his head back and laughs. “I was trying to help her, but humanity is beyond help. I promised Chandini to look out for others like her, to aid people just because I could. She was *good*. The only good one of any of you. I assure you, I would never have chosen you. I would never have chosen any of your awful, disgusting kind.”

“I didn’t want you to choose me!” I yell. “I want you to leave me alone. I want my life to go back to normal.”

“Okay,” Muya says. “Let’s make your life go back to normal.” He lunges forward and grabs my wrist with inhuman strength. “You already hate me, so what’s another...” I feel his power creeping over me, and the command beneath its touch. *You don’t remember why you want this power.*

Nausea churns in my gut. He’s finally revealed himself. He’s trying to force me to give up. And I can’t even remember why I’m fighting—

But I can still remember that he is not to be trusted, and certainly not with power. I hold on to that thought, and meet his power with my own. His own. Though they are the same magic, they feel completely distinct, as my desire to avoid ignorance meets his desire to inflict it.

“How dare you?” I grit out.

He pushes again, stronger this time, and I cannot remember why I’m here or what I’m doing. I want to give in to this nice, helpful man, this... demon. With my free hand I swipe at his eyes. He ducks, a pathetic human instinct, and his grip loosens. I pull myself free, dodge around him, and run toward the kitchen for a knife. Muya looks down at his hands, then back at me, shaking his head like he doesn’t know where he is. Then he meets my eyes and sneers.

“You’re pathetic, wanting to be someone and yet doing nothing. Sooner or later you’ll fail, and I’ll be there to laugh at you.”

He sees himself out without trying to attack me again. I dead-bolt the door behind him, a headache forming in my sinuses from the force of holding back sobs. Muya’s right, and I despise him for it. I almost wish I could go back to not knowing, back to suspecting him without certainty. Back to ignorance.

I try all night to recall the memory of Heera, whose story I hardly cared about the first time. She touched a demon and made him ignorant of himself. I cannot replicate it exactly, but I will have to try. I’ll be no worse off, unless of course he senses my attempt and snaps my neck. But I suspect public killing is not his style—and even if it is, death will be preferable to the alternative. All I have left is to use the solutions the past has offered me.

—

I spend all Tuesday trying to devise some better solution, but I come up so blank I wonder if Muya in fact succeeded in muddling my head. On Wednesday morning, four weeks into the Forty Days, I get to the clinic early. Diane raises an eyebrow at me when I walk up just as she’s getting out of her car.

“Please tell me you don’t have another feeling. We barely survived the last one.”

I shake my head. “Nope. Just woke up really early.”

The protesters are rowdier than usual. I don’t know if they’re just really riled up about Forty Days or if Asmodeus has had some hand in it. Maybe they’re excited about all the progress that they’re making. If I was on the other side, I guess I would feel victorious too. For a couple of years after *Roe* fell, I was naive enough to believe that each new development was rock bottom. Six-week abortion bans. Complete abortion bans. No exceptions for rape, incest, or life-threatening complications. Paternal notice requirements. Parental rights for rapists. But now, when I read the latest updates in abortion news, I don’t bat an eye. Attempts to ban contraceptives as abortifacients. Wastewater testing to monitor use of birth control. Criminalizing women who leave the state for an abortion. Rewards for those who turn women in. Flagging social media posts

about abortion. The administration threatening every other day to ban abortion outright. It's bleak, and I know it will only get worse. There is no rock bottom, only the molten core of the earth.

The patients seem more on edge as well. We've had a lot of out-of-staters recently, several of whom openly espouse their anti-choice beliefs even as they ask for abortions, which we still provide for them. One college-aged girl came in to get a Pap smear and an IUD and got in a shouting match with a protester, almost pushing over JJ in her haste to get inside. It's a bad time for all involved. The fear leaves me with too little time to plan, and I cannot come up with an ethical situation in which I could practice using my powers. If my attempt fails with Asmodeus, I have a group text composed for Diane, Dr. Levy, Nina, and Dan telling them to evacuate the clinic. Again. It will stay cued up in my phone, ready for me to press send. *If I fail.*

When I go back out after a bathroom break, Asmodeus has arrived. He's in a different body than the last time I saw him, but I can see that same outline of power that tells me it's him and not someone under his spell. I want to know what happens if I defeat him in this body—if he'll simply spin up a new one. But it's too late to find out now. Instead I extend my hand, and he takes it with a broad grin.

My power is coiled just under my skin, and I let it pour forth. I bleach myself from his memory. Block out the clinic. Urge him to forget this quest for power. It's terrifying. I can almost feel his presence against my mind, soft, probing, inviting. And massive. I am so, so small. I am no one. And yet, Muya's power is like an endless shadow, absorbing light, absorbing knowledge. It envelops the parts of Asmodeus I'm seeking. It smothers out the light in him. I push and push, hoping that it will be enough.

I feel myself start to grow weak, spasms shuddering through my muscles. I am not sure whether I've succeeded. Is this how Heera felt, in her moment of destiny? It is time to face my own fate. I release him as spots dance before my eyes. He looks at me blankly, then down at his dropped hand.

"Who are you?"

"You asked me for directions to the Red Line. Two blocks thataway." I point, and with a befuddled shrug, he spins on his heel and walks away.

He just walks away.

I want to jump for joy, to grin up at the sky and spin in a circle like they do in the movies. Instead, I'm rooted to the spot, heart pounding and limbs shaking. I erased the memory of a demon. I saved the clinic. A wall of noise pierces through my haze and I remember where I am. There are still plenty of protesters outside, and they're engaged in their usual screaming routine, but our clinic's going to make it. I can *feel* it.

Of course, the moment I step foot inside, everything changes. The two patients in the waiting room look fine, but Diane is on the phone and has a hand pressed against her heart. She's white as a sheet, which is hard to achieve on a Black woman. I hover by the desk as Diane murmurs, "My god" and "Yes, sir." I know something unthinkable has happened. Is it Diane's family? Her husband?

My thoughts are only just beginning to spiral when Diane says, "Let me put you on hold a minute. I'll see if I can get someone else to speak to you." She presses a button, and then turns to me with tears in her eyes.

"What's happened?" I whisper. "Is Tony okay?"

"Do you remember the girl who came in here last week from Texas, with the little blond boy?"

"Lauren?" I ask. I walked her out as she explained that she just didn't have it in her to raise another child right now. She needed to focus all her energy on little Jason. She was young, and sweet, barely affected by the protesters. When I talked to Diane afterward, I learned that a borderline abusive boyfriend was still in the picture, but because she lived in Texas we couldn't do much to help. "Was there a complication? Is it critical?"

"She's dead," Diane says. "Her boyfriend shot her and the little boy after he learned she had an abortion. The police need to speak to everyone who interacted with her."

And then Diane, strong, unflappable Diane, breaks down in tears.

Jason, dead. Lauren, dead.

All I can think is, this is my fault. Too slow. Too stupid. Too weak. That meeting was just to distract me. Asmodeus told me he punished all who resisted him, and I—I still fell for it, trusting that the choices he gave me were actual options. A woman is dead. A child is dead. And it's my fault.



21

SHOWING UP

I sleepwalk through the next couple of days. Every time I see Diane or another staff member, their hollowed-out expressions mirror my own. The news doesn't seem to have picked up the story yet, but I am sure that the murders were part of Asmodeus's greater plan.

On Friday, after the last patient has left, there's an all-hands meeting. Our director wants to talk about her concerns as we head into the last two weeks of Forty Days.

"The arson incident already put us in the red," Geeta says. "And then there's the awful matter of the shooting in Texas. It's horrific. You all are doing amazing work on a day-to-day basis. I really couldn't ask for more. But one more incident, and the clinic will have to shut down."

"Could we fundraise off the arson?" my boss asks. I'm surprised to see him in person, since he's a completely remote worker. To be honest, I thought he had moved to Wisconsin. "I'm sure we can bring in community donations and maybe even get national reach with a social media campaign. Perhaps we can fundraise for Lauren Martin's family as well."

Every once in a while, there's a boost of funding through various independent clinic networks, usually when the GOP and their puppet courts have done something especially heinous, but most of the money ends up with Planned Parenthood. They're out there doing issue work and lawyering that we

can't, but they ultimately provide only about a third of abortions. We desperately need funding to keep going, but we don't have the same reach.

Geeta shakes her head. "The police won't call it arson, so we can't either unless we want to piss off insurance. And I think we should distance ourselves from our role in the shooting, terrible as that sounds."

"She didn't die because of us," Dr. Levy says. She sounds angry. "I've lost patients on the operating table, and I've blamed myself plenty. So each of you better believe me when I say it is not a single person in this room's fault. It is her boyfriend's fault first and foremost, and all the terrible people who inspired him second." The room falls silent. "Do you hear me?" Dr. Levy repeats. Aaron's standing behind her, since we don't have enough chairs. He looks vaguely like her bodyguard. "It is a tragedy. We are all mourning. But it is *not our fault*. We cannot carry it as if it is. We tried our best to help her."

"That's another thing," Geeta says. "You all need time off to recover from this stress. We could close and plan to reopen after Easter." She says it so quickly I know that's why she called the meeting in the first place. "I know two weeks is a long time. But canceling two weeks of appointments is better than canceling them all, isn't it?"

Geeta is pretty hands-off as a director, and we're all grateful that she invested in the clinic as a passion project, but she doesn't know this place the way we do. We all look around, not wanting to be the first to shoot the idea down.

It's Diane who speaks up. "We can't close. You give them an inch and they'll take it all. They'll keep going past Easter. It will never be over. They're terrorists. We can't close out of fear or they'll have won. And as for our mental health—I won't lie, this is hard. But what about our patients? Who are we to prioritize ourselves over them?" It's an unhealthy way of thinking, we all know it. And yet we all nod along. We're here for a reason.

"That's hundreds of women," Dr. Levy says. "Hundreds of patients who won't get care, a substantial portion of whom will *never* receive care. There are countless studies showing that if the first appointment falls through, patients won't reschedule or find another option. And what about the people who are already in their second trimester? Two weeks is the whole ballgame."

“We’re under scrutiny from our local alderman and other groups,” Geeta says. “Closing would show that we are taking their concerns seriously.”

Closing the clinic would mean more time to figure out what to do about my little demon situation. I flash a glance at Aaron, who is staring at me intently. If I back up Geeta and suggest that volunteers want closure, the idea might get more consideration at the very least.

I also want time to collect myself because I’m lazy and scared, but there’s no guarantee at all that two whole weeks will make me any better.

“I agree with Dr. Levy and Diane,” I say. “Our escorts are still showing up, despite everything. Our patients are showing up. We can’t be the ones to give in. If our alderman has a problem with abortion clinics, nothing is going to change his mind.”

Geeta spreads her hands. “All right, I hear you. I’ll have a conversation with the police precinct captain about having someone keep an eye on this place. I’m just trying to keep you safe.”

“We appreciate it,” Dr. Levy says. “Our job is to keep our patients safe. And that’s what we’re going to do.”

—

JJ is waiting for me outside the clinic when the meeting is over. I only realize Aaron’s behind me when they both startle upon seeing each other. It would be funny at any other time, but instead it makes me want to cry. And something seems off about JJ—I can’t quite read her.

“Can I talk to you?” Aaron says softly behind me, but I gesture him to go away and pull JJ aside.

“Are you okay?”

She’s shivering. “Fine, sorry. Just recovering from food poisoning.”

“Well, you should be resting,” I say. “You’re shaking.”

“There’s something I need to tell you, Nish. I’m scared.” She clams up, and for a bleak moment I wonder if she’s been threatened before she adds, “I’m sorry.”

“For what?” I ask.

“That day, with the fire, I...”

I grab her hand. “JJ, it’s okay. There’s no way you could have known. Nothing you could have done.”

“You should leave here,” JJ says. “It’s not safe.”

“I know. If you want to stop being an escort, I understand.”

“Seriously.” JJ sounds more confident now. “My family can help you find a new job.”

“Uncle Gary?” I ask with a laugh, trying to lighten the mood, but fear flickers across her face. “I’m kidding, JJ. If it will make you feel better, I can talk to someone.”

“You promise?” JJ perks up.

“Only if you go home and get into bed,” I tell her.

“Thank you. Thank you! I’ll text you,” JJ says.

As she leaves, Aaron comes up behind me. “That was weird.”

“Were you listening in?” I ask.

“No,” he says. “But JJ seemed... not herself.”

“You don’t know her that well,” I point out. “But yeah, she’s shaken up about what happened.”

“You would know better than me,” he says easily. “Anyways, I thought we should talk. You’ve been avoiding me, and I... I’m sorry about how I left things last time. Can we go somewhere more private?”

A few days ago, I might have jumped at the opportunity to talk to him, to try to catch any information he might let slip. Determine his true loyalties. Now, the idea is exhausting. What would I even say? I have no emotional capacity for this conversation. I look back over my shoulder at the clinic. It seems small, weak. I move closer, touch my hand to the brick. The same brick I’ve leaned against and stared at for years. It’s still here, still standing, despite everything.

“Nisha?” Aaron calls after me, but I don’t answer. “Nisha?” he tries again.

I glance at Aaron, and he looks absolutely ordinary. I brace myself against the wind and trudge home.

On Saturday, Shreya texts me.

You still good for today?

So much has happened since we last spoke that I forgot about our plans. Still, I have time for a coffee a couple of blocks away, since I'm already at the clinic. I wonder how much of the story I can tell her. I don't know her well enough, to be honest, but perhaps one of her books has an answer.

Definitely

I'll swap you clinic swag for a book or two!

I grab a clinic-branded tote bag and add to it a water bottle and some stickers from the closet, relics from the days right after *Roe* fell when various businesses offered merch to abortion clinics as though that was the kind of support we needed. I push down the unexpected wave of anger that passes through me. The country needs systemic change, not fucking water bottles that go out of vogue every year according to the whims of TikTok. I wave goodbye to Diane and walk past the clamoring protesters, still bubbling hot with fury. The urge to scream back has never been stronger, even though they're being downright tame now that it's lunchtime. They know we schedule abortion patients in the morning, and most will probably head home soon. Steve glares at me, and I find myself taking two steps toward him before stopping myself.

"Don't you have hobbies?" I shout, even though I know better.

"Stalker! Freak!" he shouts back, but there's no venom in his voice. He seems shocked that I said anything at all. I am, too, my pulse throbbing in my ears. I force myself to turn away and train my eyes on the pavement so that I won't take the bait.

Shreya's waiting in the café when I get there, and I order a drink at the counter before joining her. We exchange a little side hug because we're not exactly sure where we stand and then sit in awkward silence for several seconds.

Finally I reach for the tote and hand it to her at the same time as she pulls out a stack of books, and we both laugh.

“Sorry, I’m a bit rusty at... coffee,” I offer.

“Trust me, this is already better than most coffees with academics,” she says. “Anyways, I grabbed a couple of books on demonology that you probably wouldn’t be able to find elsewhere. Hopefully it can provide a distraction from all the...”

“Treatment of women like baby factories?” I fill in.

“I don’t know how you do your job every day,” Shreya says, shaking her head in sympathy. “It seems so dystopian, the way some people spend their whole day screaming at patients. All those demon conspiracy theorists would be better off realizing that humans are the real demons, huh?”

This is my opening, but I don’t know exactly what to say, or how. “I know that it’s very human to get caught up in these kinds of crowds, to try to control others instead of help them, and even to take an anti-abortion stance to get more votes and wealth and power. That’s all textbook. But I feel like we should be able to fight back effectively, and I just can’t.”

Shreya leans back, looking thoughtful. “Some of the great philosophers thought that demons were not truly their own entities, but beings that fed off humanity’s failings, and thus could never be killed,” she says. “The idea was that our only recourse was overcoming what they represented in ourselves. It’s a great metaphor for the human experience.” I sit with that grim pronouncement for a moment as she adds, “I mean, almost all the demons from the Western storytelling canon are said to have a human master. These big great evils from across time and space, controlled and summoned by humans like you and me.”

Despite my overwhelm, I manage to sound casual. “I don’t know about these demon summoners being all that similar to you and me.” My mind is spinning in a million directions.

She laughs. “Hey, it’s possible! Though you’re right that the stories usually describe more powerful demons being summoned by more powerful people.”

Shreya grins as though we’re sharing a joke. I can sense pushing any further is going to make her think I’m mentally unstable, so I fake a laugh. “Well, thank you for the mental break. I needed it.”

“Speaking of breaks from work, are you looking for volunteers?”

“Oh, I didn’t mean to guilt you—”

“Not at all. It’s one of those things that I’ve always wanted to do, but never followed through on.”

I’m not going to look a gift volunteer in the mouth, so I pull out my phone and text her the volunteer application link before I can forget. “It’s just a formality,” I add. “I already know you’re not a plant.”

“Maybe I’ve been playing the long game,” she says, getting a real laugh out of me. For a moment, I’m able to enjoy coffee with an old acquaintance-turned-friend before the guilt and fear come roaring back. Progress.

—

My dreams are dark. Literally. I’m standing in a consuming blackness. My eyes are open, but I see nothing. Perceive nothing. I close my eyes, and when I open them, I see flames. I try to flee, but there’s fire all around me. Bizarrely, I’m cold. I’m so cold. As my body spasms with shivers, I feel a hand on my shoulder. I whirl around, but there’s nobody there. Something taps me again, and I spin and spin and spin to catch a glimpse of them until I’m dizzy. Suddenly, the fire is gone, as is the darkness, revealing the familiar interior of the clinic. The lights are still turned off, but I can see. I call out, but no one responds. My voice echoes in the emptiness. I head toward the medical wing and push open the doors, finding nothing. I hear a dripping sound, and I follow it into room 3. The door is unlocked. Lauren is lying on the bed, a hole in her chest. Blood is dripping, dripping, dripping onto the linoleum tile. I open my mouth to scream, but my jaw is locked.

I back into the main hallway, now filled with people. I can’t make out any of their faces, each blurred and ghostlike. My jaw is still clenched in a painful vise, so I lunge toward one of them for help. When I near them, I realize everyone here is holding a sign. Anatomically incorrect fetuses, slogans about murder. The clinic is full of ghost-antis. I need to get out. I need to run, but I’m hemmed in and there’s nowhere to go. Someone tugs on my hand, but I can’t make out who. I’m hot now; there’s sweat beading on my forehead. The ceiling has caught

fire. I allow the hand, cool to the touch, to pull me along. I take two steps forward, and the clinic walls crumble. The ceiling collapses in chunks that pass so close they ruffle my clothes. I pull my hand free to cover my head, and suddenly my mouth wrenches itself open—

I wake up screaming, my chest heaving from the force of it. I turn over onto my side, squeezing my eyes shut to stop myself from crying. I know better now than to write off the content of my dreams as meaningless or mere coincidence, but I can't make sense of the images. I try to recapture the fleeting moments of the dream, but nothing stands out. A month ago, before all this began, I would have ignored this warning. I would have doubted myself. But the clinic is still in danger. Asmodeus is out there, lying in wait. I doubt my influence over him will last forever. Maybe the dream is a threat from him, letting me know what's in store for us if I don't yield. Or, of course, it could be a message from whoever summoned him, if Shreya's research is to be believed.

I'm not experienced enough to permanently rid myself of these demons on my own, and I turn my attention to more tangible problems, like the clinic's money woes. Our fundraising efforts are floundering. Even with all the disasters we've suffered, we're barely making the news. I think of all those rich people milling about the Art Institute, giving money to organizations that, in hindsight, further the anti agenda. JJ has always been a little oblivious.

My phone pings with a text from Aai.

Nisha, enough is enough. Come home so I can see you with my own eyes or I'm going to drag you.

An idea begins taking shape, and before I can let lethargy defeat me, I jump to my feet and leave my apartment, forcing myself to travel to the one place I'd least like to be right now.

I approach Aai's place, an apology for her sitting on my tongue, but it curdles when Rima Auntie opens the door. We gape at each other, and I hear the chime of an alarm system, which is new, and a relief.

Before I can collect my thoughts, she says, "I'm sorry." I almost choke on my own spit. "I've been bad to you and your Aai."

“Yes,” I agree. She lifts a brow, and I manage to add, “I’m sorry, too.”

“Come in, then.”

I kick off my shoes and enter the kitchen, where Aai is cooking. She turns off the stove to look at me, and I see a light in her eyes that thrills my heart. Despite everything, she seems more excited than I’ve seen in a long time. Hopefully my idea doesn’t bring her down.

“Good thing you’re here and I didn’t have to drag you kicking and screaming,” she says. And before I can figure out the right way to start the conversation I came here to have, she continues, “I have an idea for you. Since the fire, the clinic keeps getting coverage in the Midwest Family Institute.”

Rima Auntie nods along. Weird.

“That makes sense,” I respond. I’m not sure why she’s bringing it up. The Midwest Family Institute is an ultraconservative group operating in Wisconsin, Illinois, Michigan, and Indiana that focuses on family-oriented work like outing gay public-school teachers and closing abortion clinics.

Aai pulls out her phone, opens Safari, and turns the screen toward me—always a jump scare, because it’s on 100 percent brightness and font size seventy-two. I look at the article and see the Midwest Family Institute bragging that our clinic will be closed soon and thanking the soldier for life who set the fire. There’s a quote from our new alderman claiming that the clinic is not the most efficient use of the space, and one attributed to a Harry Fleming saying that their plans for putting the clinic out of business have been in motion for months, that it must be god’s will to have them succeed just in time for Easter. I have a strange tingling feeling that propels me to read further, though I’d rather throw Aai’s phone against a wall. *Lift the veil of ignorance*, I tell myself. But all I get is a headache.

“Don’t worry about this stuff, Aai. I actually came to ask you something.”

“Anything, baccha.”

“You’ve always said the Bhats owe you, right?”

Aai smiles, a lot wider than my question merits. “Yes. As a matter of fact, just this morning I called in that favor with them.”

“What?” I can’t believe it. “I was thinking that since the clinic needs money, maybe they would host a fundraiser and invite their friends, but it seems like I’m

too late—”

Aai pushes her phone back into my hands. I glance at the screen, where her WhatsApp thread with Mrs. Bhat discusses plans for... a fundraiser.

“I still keep up with our friends from back when we lived in Rogers Park,” Aai says. “I know plenty of people who would be interested in helping out, especially after they learned that you’re working there. So I got Geeta’s number and we came up with this plan.”

“How can I help?” I ask. I almost can’t believe that after what Aai has suffered for me and my work, she’s putting her time into this. Except... I can believe it, because no matter what I’ve done to her, she has always done everything for me.

“Don’t worry about it,” Aai says, as if sensing my thoughts. “Rima is helping me organize some of the details. You focus on keeping yourself safe. Actually, she was just saying that in the past, demons were always defeated by using their own tricks against them.”

Rima Auntie finally ends her impression of a statue to speak. “You are just one in a long line of women who were able to succeed despite the odds. You might be nothing special, but an average woman is good enough.” A classic Rima Auntie underhanded compliment, but it gives me a bit of strength. If so many before me have survived, maybe I can save my clinic.

“Do you want to stay?” Aai asks. I can see the hope in her eyes that I’ll say yes, but I can’t forget why I’ve been avoiding her. Even this latest effort to save the clinic is just my taking further advantage of her without having anything to offer in return.

“I don’t want to get in the way,” I say, feeling like I’m speaking through glue.

“In the way?” Aai echoes, even as she speed-packs food into old take-out containers.

I shake my head. “I could be putting you in danger.”

“That’s a stupid reason,” Aai says.

I accept the food from her, my eyes stinging at the defeat in her expression. “It was good to see you.”

“It was ‘good to see’ me?” Aai repeats, incredulous. Guilt and loathing war in my gut. It’s all I can do not to burst into tears as I turn away and head back into

the cold.



LUSTY MONTH OF MARCH

I don't manage to access any other visions for the next several days as I wait for Asmodeus or Muya to resurface. By Friday, the day of the fundraiser, I'm panicking. The forecast predicts temperatures in the high sixties for the next week, the last of Forty Days. The weather really hates us. Violence always increases with the temperature, and I am certain we will also have demons to contend with.

Our social worker quit, so I've been doing part of her job in a more official capacity. But since I'm not a social worker and can't actually provide any psychological evaluation or guidance, I mostly just sit with patients who need company. And while I've used my magic to help patients and fight Asmodeus before, it's not really an option right now. Every time I reach for it, I feel exhausted—whatever I did to him during our last encounter also wiped a lot of my power. Though I've watched as those before me creatively bettered their respective situations, even if I could reach my magic, I can think of no way for it to save the clinic. So I stew and worry. The only bright spot is Shreya, who has started texting me daily. She's going to be at the fundraiser and has taken it upon herself to make plans to guilt specific uncles into donating, which makes me smile if nothing else.

That night, Aai and Rima Auntie come to pick me up. They put food in my fridge, dress me in an outfit of their choosing, Western this time, and then Rima

Aunty applies makeup to my face while Aai does my hair.

“Am I being set up for a surprise arranged marriage?” I joke, but they don’t respond. The tension is thick after I ran out of Aai’s house, and while I’ve been responding to Aai’s check-ins multiple times a day, I haven’t yet been able to dispel the frostiness.

We pull up in the mandir parking lot, and I sigh. Of course they planned on ambushing me by bringing me to the temple. I go inside and slip off my shoes, shivering as my bare feet make contact with the cold marble tile. I try to walk as quickly as is respectful, reciting the appropriate prayers at lightning speed. Somewhere along the way, though, as I do my pradakshina, the smell of incense and the quiet murmurs around me cause my shoulders to drop. This is such a simple way for me to make Aai happy. And that should matter to me. I can do this for her. I sit cross-legged on the women’s side without complaining about the gender segregation, and wait for as long as Aai and Rima Aunty take to finish up. Aai smiles as we leave and squeezes my hand.

It’s only when we get to the party that I wonder how Aai pulled this off so quickly. A month’s worth of planning in, what, under a week? At the Bhats’ place, a banner in the foyer reads “Rogers Park Health Center,” and another under it says “Donate Now!” There are QR codes, boxes for checks, and plenty of glitzy guests mingling. Most are desi folks, but surprisingly not all.

“How...?” I don’t even know how to frame the question.

Aai smiles. “You go work the crowd. The Bhats owe me for quite a bit, as it turns out.”

“What do you have on them?”

Aai shoots me a mysterious look. “Let me have my secrets, yes?” She gives me a little push, and I plaster on a smile.

“Namaskar, aunty! My name is Nisha. I work at the clinic. I would be happy to tell you more about it.”

The aunty in question gives me a once-over and replies, “Yes, the Bhats did not give much information. Just said it was urgent. Between us, they are very liberal, don’t you think? Parading all this around... it is not very savory.”

I literally just said I worked there, but if she wants to gossip, I can work with that. “We provide a lot of different types of services to recent immigrants. We

help with prenatal care for women who have just come over.”

“That’s good,” she says approvingly. I can see her reevaluating, so I decide to lay it on a bit thicker.

“Lately, these other people have been trying to shut us down. A lot of them still believe all those stereotypes about Indians—they think our patients are coming in to get sex-selectives. That is why we need help with funding.”

“They do not understand our culture,” the aunty says angrily. “As if! We are not backward, they are!”

“Exactly, aunty ji.”

The evening passes in a blur. Some folks are excited about the cause and just want to hear stories that make them feel even better about their contributions. I don’t mind it at all, because they are all that stands between us and closure. Not everyone can work on the front lines of every fight for justice, but the fact that they still care enough to help almost makes me cry after the month we’ve had. A few are more wary of supporting an abortion clinic but feel pressured by the Bhats’ social influence, especially when they have to explain their positions to me. Before, I might have condemned them as fence-sitters and moralizers, but now I see the shades of gray and appreciate their help. They’re not bad people—to have their own qualms about abortion but look past them for the welfare of the larger population is maybe even an act of true goodness. The smile on my face becomes more and more genuine.

I talk to an uncle who lives in the area, whose son runs a business on Devon Avenue. I talk to an ajji who babysat me when I was very small, though I don’t remember her, and after I touch her feet, she pinches my cheeks and says she’s proud of me. I talk to a couple I’ve seen at other Bhat parties who inform me that their daughter is a doctor in California who provides abortions. At one point, I find myself on autopilot, starting my pitch to none other than Geeta.

“You’re doing amazing,” Geeta says. “I hear all the time about how indispensable you are at the clinic. Great work.”

It’s such a silly, meaningless platitude, but I let myself feel good about it anyway. Across the room, I see Dr. Bhat talking to someone animatedly and accepting a check. Miracles will never cease.

“This is a lovely event,” Dr. Levy says. I whirl around to see her grinning at me. She’s wearing a powder-blue suit and looks absolutely lovely.

“Is it enough?” I ask, because I suddenly feel small. The place has gotten more crowded since I got here, but it’s no Art Institute fundraiser.

Dr. Levy’s smile smooths into a look of understanding. She takes my hands in hers. “I’ve asked myself that every day of my life.”

“I didn’t mean you—”

“Of course not. You think everyone is doing a good job but you.” My mouth falls open. She laughs, then squeezes my hands like she is trying to show me something. “Sometimes I worry that I’m only treating the symptoms, instead of finding a cure. I’ve made my peace with it. We are doing something that helps people. Have you ever heard the saying, ‘Whoever saves a life has saved the whole world’? Overwrought, perhaps, but our work has saved more than one life. That’s what I tell myself.”

“It doesn’t feel like enough.”

“It never will,” she says frankly. “It isn’t a bad thing to never be completely satisfied, so long as you can find a little peace.”

I close my eyes, because I can’t bear to witness any more of this earnestness, when I sense Aaron beside me. I open my eyes to see him offering me a plate.

“You look great,” Aaron says, and Dr. Levy laughs as if we weren’t just discussing the source of my all-consuming depression.

“I’ll leave you kids to it,” she says.

“Thank you.” It’s wholly inadequate for her perhaps life-changing words, but it’s all I can manage. Aaron offers me his arm. I study him, looking for any evidence that he’s been sabotaging our clinic or working alongside demons, but my brain goes fuzzy at the sight of him in a tux. I slip my hand onto his arm, and we head back into the crowd.

—

As the evening wears on, Geeta comes by to let me and Aaron know that we’ve received enough donations to fix the damage to the administrative wing *and* fund operations for three months. Apparently that means that Geeta can use her

money to make a substantial donation to the alderman instead of rebuilding the clinic, taking care of yet another thorn in our sides. It's almost too good to believe, but as I look around and spot doctors and bankers and engineers, it makes sense. We've been building generational capital, but we haven't used it for this type of collective action before. I know there are plenty of problems in our community, and in who gets to build that kind of capital, but tonight all I feel is pride.

Aaron and I are still arm in arm, our eyes occasionally meeting before one of us glances away. At some point, I look down to find that we've switched to holding hands, although I can't remember when or how that could have happened. It's bizarre, but I'm more curious about the crowd. Aunties gazing adoringly at their husbands—and each other? An older couple kissing in the corner? For Indians at a public function, that might as well be third base. Aaron follows my gaze and giggles, and I join him. His hand brushes the skin on my upper arm and heat pools low in my belly. I've never felt this kind of romance-book physical attraction before, not even to Aaron, and it feels wrong in my body. And yet so good. Before I can get too carried away, a hand clamps mine, nails digging into my skin. I let out a yelp and whirl around.

“Shreya?”

“I thought this was a fundraiser, not an orgy!”

The adrenaline and pain clear away some of my earlier fog. I take Aaron's and Shreya's hands in mine before either can protest, try to avoid the thrill of this skin-to-skin contact, and lift the veil of ignorance. It's hard, perhaps harder than it's ever been, even when I was more inexperienced. I reach deep into the depleted well of my magic, stretching the muscle as much as I can bear, and at last the spell dissipates, leaving me nauseated about how cozy I'd just been with Aaron. The room is covered in a haze of pink.

“Well, damn,” Shreya says, scanning the crowd.

Aaron whispers to himself, “What the fuck?”

I remember that one of Asmodeus's many titles is the Lord of Lust—he told me that himself. I haven't experienced this side of his powers before, but I know it must be him. Aaron steps away from me, and I study his face. He looks confused, and not really like someone whose demonic plans were just foiled.

Shreya whispers, “Am I hallucinating?” I shake my head. “This is—I must be.”

I turn to her, grasping both her hands in mine, and with what little power I have, I scan the crowd for demonic energy. It doesn’t take me long to find a gleeful-looking man who I can immediately tell is under Asmodeus’s influence. Thank gods for small miracles. I focus my attention on allowing Shreya to see it, too. When she does, she gasps.

“It’s just like in the books,” she whispers. I can almost see the gears turning in her head as she compares what she’s seeing with our conversation over coffee.

The man approaches us, and I put myself between him and Shreya. Aaron lingers nearby.

“Hello, Nisha,” the man says. I don’t know how to respond, because I’m all too aware that I don’t have enough power to erase Asmodeus’s influence or make him forget me. I’m already struggling just to push away his influence. “I have a message for you.”

“Yes?”

“Let’s discuss outside. It’s a bit stuffy in here.”

“What is Asmodeus’s plan?” I ask, pitching my voice low.

“I’ll tell you outside,” the man says. “Cross my heart.”

He reaches out his hand, and I stare at it. I know I shouldn’t go with him, but maybe outside I can find a way to stop whatever he’s planning, with fewer people caught in the cross fire. I release my hold on Shreya’s hand to reach for his.

Shreya’s punch to his face comes as a surprise to all of us. His nose audibly crunches as he doubles over in pain. Before I can react, she grips the man’s shoulders and knees him right in the balls. As he writhes, I see the haze lift off everyone in the room. There’s a clamor as the assemblage clears their throats and rearranges their clothing, and everyone’s extreme efforts to studiously ignore their surroundings offer great cover for the demon fight unfolding before me. I did not know Shreya had it in her. The man whimpering on the ground looks supremely confused, and it appears that whatever tether he previously had to the Lord of Lust is fully severed. He looks up at Shreya in fear and hobbles quickly out of the room.

“That *hurt*,” Shreya says as she shakes out her hand. “You’re very lucky, because a lust demon wasn’t going to work on me.”

“You’re taking this surprisingly well.”

“I’m in shock,” she supplies. “I think, though, you owe me an explanation.”

Aaron has melted into the crowd, and I have no desire to follow. Soon, though, I have to investigate that lead more thoroughly for the sake of the clinic. If Asmodeus was summoned, it was likely by someone interested in ruining our clinic. I can’t rule out Aaron. I think suddenly of how he said *your* clinic when we spoke about Divya. Not *our* clinic. Tomorrow I’ll confront him. I have to.

I find a peaceful corner for Shreya and me to talk. After she grabs an ice cream cup to soothe her hand, I fill her in on everything. To her credit, she takes it all in stride, even the ending: Asmodeus is still alive and kicking, Muya’s at large, and my magic is pretty much gone.

“I believe you,” she says, and her words are so sweet that tears prick my eyes. “You... we can figure it out.”



RIP CURRENT

Contrary to Saturday's sunny forecast, it's fifty degrees and sheeting rain. There will still be some folks out, I know, but for many protesters their own comfort trumps all else. Though, I suppose that's why they're out here protesting in the first place. I'm getting wrapped up in my own anger again, but it keeps me warm—along with waterproof snowpants and a windbreaker. Chicagoans have a very no-nonsense, fashion-blind approach when it comes to weather protection; it's something I have always loved about the city. As I approach the clinic, I get a text from Shreya.

hitting the books today!

I lift my gaze to find only a few miserable-looking protesters out in the rain. Steve is not there—I think this might be an Aurora weekend for him—but one of the regular MRAs is, as are two women huddled under an umbrella, praying the rosary. I slosh into the clinic and find a bedraggled-looking Dr. Levy standing at the front desk, on the phone.

"What is it?" I ask.

"Diane isn't in, and she didn't call out. We're short-staffed as it is, and this is unlike her. We open in five minutes, and we're lucky nobody has shown up early."

“It’s raining really hard, the roads are probably a disaster,” I say.

“She would call. She would text.”

“What’s on the docket for today?” I ask. “I can handle check-in until Diane gets here or we have more information.”

Dr. Levy whirls around to face me. “Why are you so determined to believe it’s not a big deal?”

Because I’m a coward. Because I’m lazy. Because I’d rather accept the easy explanation.

But that’s not really why. “I’m worried,” I say. “We all are worried about each other all the time. But it’s pouring rain, our patients need us, and we’re not going to be a very effective search party with just us two. I’m going to text Diane and her emergency contact, and woman the front desk.”

I can see the moment Dr. Levy pulls herself together. She’s a mom of two children, an attending physician, and a part-time abortionist. She has nerves of steel, despite everything the world is throwing at her. “You’re right,” she says. “It’s just Janey, and...” I reach out and touch her shoulder.

“Things are really bad, huh?” I say. “I can barely get out of bed most days.”

Dr. Levy gives me a small smile. “You could say I’m on edge. Another doctor at the hospital just got served for mailing abortion pills—Louisiana says it’s illegal. It’s never been worse than today, and yet tomorrow will be even worse. I worry about my children, and about all you children.”

All I can think to say is, “After this, you should take a vacation.”

“I’ll take Easter,” she says, and we both laugh.

“Me too!” I say. “Think they can spare us both?”

And then we’re both laughing, clutching each other’s arms and giggling like children. There are tears in my eyes, and hers, too. It’s about a moment away from becoming uncomfortable when the clinic door slams open with the wind. Diane trudges in, followed by Aaron.

“What’s so funny?” Diane asks, squinting at us. “I didn’t know anyone at this clinic could have fun without me.”

Dr. Levy straightens. “Nothing. Just glad to see you, Diane. We were worried about you.”

“Sorry, my dog somehow unplugged my phone last night and I barely had the juice to text Aaron when my car spun out from hydroplaning.”

“We live close enough,” Aaron says with a shrug. I give him a look. From the personnel files I snooped through, they live at least half an hour apart in weather. “I picked her up, got a tow truck called. Figured that was more important than being on time. I think we’ll have a couple cancellations, though.”

“About half of our day is abortions,” Dr. Levy says briskly. “But the other half, maybe. Come on, let’s get ready.”

“Sorry, hon,” Diane says as Dr. Levy gets moving. “Didn’t mean to scare you.”

“I’m glad you’re all right,” I say, my throat tightening slightly. “That’s all that matters.”

“Don’t be that glad!” She bustles over to the desk and starts setting up. “Now you’ll have to stand outside all morning.”

I’ve never been happier to escort in the sheeting rain.

—

I’m less content by the end of the day. I massage my temples as I wait for Aaron to appear—the protesters have given me a headache, setting up megaphones despite the rain.

“THESE WICKED WOMEN HAVE BEEN MISLED BY FEMINISM. THEY THINK THEY ARE SAVING WOMEN, BUT INSTEAD THEY CONSIGN THEM TO A LIFE OF PAIN AND REGRET!”

Because it was a slow day, a few of the protesters approached me to try to start a debate.

“Margaret Sanger believed in eugenics! She would have wanted you to die!”

“Abortion is responsible for millions of missing girls! Imagine if your mom had aborted you for a boy!”

Steve showed up a few hours in, and I thought I saw him roll his eyes at their pitiful attempts. Only newbies and traveling protesters try to convert escorts. The true regulars know we’re all Satan’s spawn and lost causes. Eventually they gave up and I spent the rest of my shift staring at the clinic’s exterior. The bricks

had all turned brown from the rainwater, dark and menacing in the downpour. There was a sense of foreboding all around the building, but no matter how hard I tried to concentrate, I couldn't make out what was wrong with it. During a brief pause in the rain, I even attempted to muddle through a few dance steps in a futile attempt to figure it out. I only slipped and splattered mud on myself, getting nowhere, gasping in air that was somehow both cold and muggy.

And now, mud-covered and exhausted, I have to confront Aaron.

"We should talk," I tell him the moment he leaves the clinical wing. He's clearly happy that I want to speak to him, but he can tell from my tone that it's not going to be about anything good. "How about we go down to the Riverwalk?"

It's not the best suggestion, but after the pandemic, I've socialized in worse weather. Aaron drives us both downtown, which is at least part of the way home for me. The awkward silence almost causes me to break, but I don't want to have this conversation in a small, enclosed space. He could be dangerous, but I feel so disarmed by him that it's hard to believe. At last we end up at the windy Riverwalk, our feet dangling over the concrete.

Even though I've been here a million times, I still think about the engineers who reversed the flow of the river in the middle of the night to prevent downstream cities from obstructing them until it was too late, ending the scourge of waterborne diseases in the city and securing Chicago's place in the American firmament. The city of broad shoulders and corruption. Of course it was that same spirit that led Mayor Daley to order an airport bulldozed in the night, also to avoid his political opponents stopping him, but his covert activities were far less cool.

"You're thinking about the airport, aren't you?" Aaron asks, lightly shoving my shoulder. I laugh.

"How did you know?" I ask. My teeth chatter a bit, and I clench my jaw against the cold seeping into my bones.

"You get this funny look..." he says. "You're such a history nerd!"

"Who wouldn't want to know the history of the best city in the world?" I reply. I take a fortifying breath, then blurt, "I have something to tell you."

"Okay." Aaron looks confused, but doesn't try to stop me.

I lower my voice. “The patient we saw last week, the one who decided to wait for her abortion because she wanted to find a way to stay employed? She was married, and her husband didn’t know she was there.”

Aaron’s face falls. “Are you worried about abuse?”

I shake my head. “No. They both want kids. She didn’t want to upset him.”

“Oh. That’s her choice, then. All the people we see are in a hard place.”

I swallow. “You’re not... upset? On behalf of her husband?”

“She’s not my partner. It’s not my right to care.”

I take a deep breath. I’ve decided to tell him what happened all those years ago. If he’s an anti, there’s nothing else I can think of to make him break his cover. My power is still just dregs, but I should be able to spot traces of demonic interference after eliciting a strong emotional reaction from him. Hopefully I won’t need to make him forget this. I don’t know if I would be able to even if I wanted to—I haven’t been able to shake what JJ said about his right to know. “I had an abortion.”

“Oh.”

I can’t read the expression that plays across his face. I focus on looking for evidence of magic, but he looks perfectly normal. Human.

“It was two months after we broke up. It was yours.”

Aaron is silent, and I force myself to keep looking at him, even though it hurts. Something touches my wrist. I flinch, and then I realize Aaron was trying to hold my hand.

“It was the ear infection,” he says. “Right?” I nod. Of course he would understand immediately—I had been on antibiotics the week before I saw him outside that clinic. “You tried to text me about it, didn’t you? I—I’m sorry.” His voice cracks. “I won’t lie, it hurts to hear. Not because—not because we should have been parents, but I guess I wish I had known. I’m a little hurt, even though I didn’t have a right to know.” He’s processing the news in real time, but I can see that whatever suspicions I’ve been clinging to were false. He’s a good person. I doubted him, but he really has changed. “Are you still angry with me?”

“I was, then. But I’m not anymore. It’s in the past. I haven’t been angry since the day you reappeared. I will admit, though, I have been... suspicious. This season has been particularly hard.”

Aaron looks more hurt at this revelation than at my confession. "I would never..."

"I think I just wanted to believe that you were the cause of our problems. That we're not fucked." I laugh bitterly. I'm ashamed to realize my eyes are welling.

"You raised a lot of money, you'll be okay," he says.

"Why do you keep saying 'you'?" I ask. "'Your' money, 'your' clinic? Doesn't that sound suspicious?"

"I—I don't deserve to have any ownership over it." His voice is soft as he looks out at the water. "After what I did... It's not about being ashamed, it's about being unworthy."

"Funny," I whisper. "I feel the same way."

His head snaps toward me. "You're strong and brave, helping so many people, and—"

"Stop," I interrupt. "I don't want compliments, that's not what I mean. They're ramping up their campaign against us, don't you see that? If they don't put us out of business this time, they'll find another way to get what they want soon enough. Who can withstand that? Come on, you should know. You used to be one of them. They're all so brainwashed by their rich overlords that they'll believe—"

"Listen, I don't like them," Aaron interrupts. "But they do have agency. They're not just puppets. They have deeply held beliefs fueling them, not just propaganda."

"Great. Well, they're using that 'agency' to destroy us." I look out at the churning gray water and am struck by how wrong I was about Aaron, how wrong I might be about everything. The words come out of me before I can stop them. A confession, a cry for help, to a person that I wanted so badly to love and then so badly to hate. "There's a cloud over my head. I feel like I'm drowning all the time."

"You're in a rip current," Aaron says. "Even the strongest swimmer could drown."

Something breaks in me. I cover my face to hide the tears pouring down my cheeks. I'm shaking, cold and hot at the same time. An arm wraps around me,

then another. He's holding me. I try to believe his words. I really do.

—

Eventually, Aaron drives me home, then gives my hand a reassuring squeeze as I leave the car. I feel empty, but not alone.

"You're wasting your time," Muya says from my kitchen table the moment I unlock my door.

I'm too tired to scream. "We have to stop meeting like this," I deadpan.

"If you would behave like a powerful woman instead of an idiotic little girl —" He stops himself. "I'm here to apologize. What I did to you, it was wrong. Even if you're a thief and a moron, it was wrong."

"What do you want from me, Muya?" I drop into the chair across from him. I don't know if Asmodeus and Muya are working together or are independently evil. I don't know if Shreya's right and they're being controlled. I don't know why Muya would teach me to access memories that paint him in such a harsh light or to channel powers that could be used against him. Nothing makes sense. And yet, something has shifted inside me over the last five weeks, so subtly that I haven't noticed until now. I'm confident in my instincts, in my own brain—it's an odd feeling. And instinct tells me to listen to him. I'm going to figure this Muya situation out, tonight.

"I want to help." I scoff, but he leans forward, more earnest than I've ever seen him. "Instead of forcing your hand, I will explain. I should have from the start. It seems that you have decided that I am to blame for Usha's misfortune. But that's not true. I never betrayed her. I tried to help her, but she grew afraid and trapped me instead. You don't have to believe me, and at this point I don't think I can change your mind. And yet—despite my best efforts to leave you idiot humans behind—I have come to try."

"Try what?" I ask.

"To save your life. Asmodeus is formidable, but the human working with him, whoever it is, is far more powerful than you could ever imagine."

"Don't worry, I figured that out myself."

Muya slams his hands onto the table, and I flinch. “Listen to me! You are wasting your time with that bland little boy from your clinic—don’t give me that look, of course I followed you—but clearing his name doesn’t matter. You cannot win. You are going to die.”

“And my power will die with me, blah, blah, blah,” I say. “Tell me something I don’t know.”

“Give up your power to that other demon and *survive*.”

For a moment, I just stare at him. My brain has gone fully offline. Then I start to laugh. “Was this the plan all along? In the end, you would send me to him?”

“Are you truly this stupid?” He looks wounded, but I remember he’s a demon of ignorance. He could easily be manipulating me. “I am trying to save your life, your livelihood. If you keep resisting, you will die. Everything you love and everyone you love will suffer. I’ve seen it happen, don’t you understand? I’ve seen it happen—” He cuts himself off. If he’s lying, he’s due for an Oscar.

“Why shouldn’t I give the power back to you?”

“As much as I would like that, he would destroy you for giving the power to someone else. It’s not worth it.”

“You’ve changed,” I say.

“Yes,” he says simply. “I no longer think you’re a worthless human. But you can do whatever you wish. It’s no longer my concern, you’ve made that clear.” I gape at him as he pushes the chair back so hard it topples over and stalks out of the apartment.

For so many years of this work, I have felt completely powerless. When the Supreme Court acted without proof or law or history on its side, I was consumed by hypotheticals. If only they had read the recipe for inducing abortion that Ben Franklin, an actual Founding Father, included in one of his books! If only they didn’t credit the invented opinions of people who didn’t even understand germ theory, let alone fetal development! If only they saw that most people throughout history accepted abortions in the first trimester! In time, though, I came to understand that it was never about scientific evidence or historical precedent. It was about power and control. So I gave up. And yet—I

feel a shift inside me, slow but finally apparent. I do still have some choices left to me, some meaning to make.

I rise so fast my chair clatters to the ground, too, and begin my todas. There's no music, just the rapid beating of my heart and a burning will to understand.

Please, I beg the past. I need help.



USHA

Usha rose to her feet in a dark and empty room, wiping the moisture on her hand against the edge of her sari. She hoped the bleeding would stop on its own. A door slammed open, light entering the room along with Joshi sahib.

“What are you—what are you doing?” he shouted. “What have you done? How dare you come back here and practice your... your dark rituals. Get out!”

She looked behind her, but Muya was gone. “There was a demon in your home,” she said at last. Her voice trembled. “I came to help you.”

Joshi sahib laughed. “Demons? You think I believe in them? The British have shown us the foolishness of those beliefs. They have no power over me.”

“But—Muyalagan—” she protested faintly.

“You are a foolish, ignorant woman,” he said, in a tone so sweet it was poison.

“I came here to beg your forgiveness,” she said. “To apologize for what happened to your sister.”

“Because you want clemency?” He shook his head in long, slow movements. “It is good you see the error of your ways. But there will be no escape from your sins.”

And Usha knew she was doomed. That night, she didn’t sleep. She thought about running, but she was weak, her body too exhausted by the confrontation. Her mind whirled, searching desperately for a solution, but in the morning she was still answerless in Pune.

“I’m sorry,” she said to Radhabai.

Her aunt hugged Usha. “You have done nothing wrong, child. Whatever happens, we will figure it out.”

A prominent lawyer, Pandit Ranade, appeared at the door to escort her to the courthouse. It wouldn't matter, but she wished she knew who had sent for him, so she could thank them for their valiant efforts. When they arrived, Pandit Ranade explained that this courthouse was nothing like the one in Bombay, that Pune's court was informal. But there was a judge seated at the dais, an officer swearing people in, and a translator present. Usha looked around and saw the Joshis enter. The wife had wrapped her shawl around her shoulders in a demure fashion, and Usha wished she had thought to do the same.

The judge held up a piece of paper, and the translator said, "I have here the examination report of Ahilya Joshi. It says that she suffered a perforation of her uterus in the commission of an abortion."

"While that might be true, Ahilya Joshi did not suffer at the hands of this woman," Pandit Ranade responded. "It was a rogue by the name of Deepak."

"Will the witness come forward?" the judge asked, and with a sinking feeling Usha watched as the wife approached, her eyes downcast. After some pleasantries, the judge continued, "Do you know who provided your sister-in-law with an abortion?"

"I know she asked Usha tai."

That was not an answer, and the judge seemed to recognize it. "Did this woman agree to provide it?"

"She said she would provide an abortion within two weeks," she said. "And a week later, my sister-in-law was dead."

"So she did provide the abortion?"

At last, she looked at Usha. Her face was sad, and a little bit angry. Usha could see the lie building in her eyes. *I delivered your baby*, Usha wanted to scream. *I wanted to help your sister-in-law. You know that. You know that!*

And as if the woman could hear her, she said, "No, a man by the name of Deepak did." Joshi sahib jumped to his feet but was quickly blocked by a white man. He looked wild, furious. "Usha tai tried to save Ahilya's life, but she could not. Perhaps it was her lack of skill."

It was meant as a jab to placate her husband, but that didn't matter. Usha turned to her lawyer, but he still looked pensive.

“But she was willing to provide the abortion?” the judge asked. “She said that?”

The woman looked confused. “Yes, of course. Usha tai provides abortions to many women.”

“Thank you,” the judge said. He turned to Usha. “Do you deny providing abortions?”

Usha was caught. If she lied, the wife’s words would still be considered more powerful than hers. But if she told the truth, she would be admitting to a crime. She had lost most things, but not her own self.

“I provide abortions,” Usha said simply.

“Are you aware that it is a crime?”

“I was not aware of it at the time,” Usha said.

“How could she be?” Pandit Ranade interrupted. “How could a working midwife be expected to know about the English laws passed in another country?”

The judge frowned. “This is the first time a woman has come before us for this crime, and I know it is not your custom to educate your women.” Usha’s lawyer shot her a sharp look, and she bit her tongue. “But this is a particularly heinous crime. People ought to know that murder is wrong. Ordinarily, the punishment would be transportation.”

“Transportation? For a woman?” her lawyer cried out. “To send a woman out of her country alone... it is unthinkable. She is willing to pay a fine, that is appropriate for a first-time offense.”

“A fine alone is not sufficient for this crime,” the judge said. “A year in the women’s penitentiary, then.”

“Your Honor,” Pandit Ranade began, but the judge was already standing up to leave.

Joshi sahib came up to Usha as soon as the judge was gone, dragging his wife behind him with a grip tight enough to leave marks on her skin. “Do not ever show your face in this city again,” he barked.

“What did I do to you?” Usha asked. She could not even begin to comprehend what had just happened, that she had nearly been exiled, that she would go to prison. “I helped you, I—”

“You said no,” his wife replied in a voice quiet enough that only Usha could hear. The woman had put herself in a precarious position by acting against her husband’s plan and aiding Usha. His word was meant to be law.

“I imagine he has substantial financial interests to protect from the embarrassment of his sister’s actions,” her lawyer added coldly, his gaze piercing Joshi sahib. “Better the attention is on the midwife than his own family.”

“Don’t come back,” Joshi sahib repeated, his face red with rage.

Usha did not intend to. She saw it all clearly now. Muya was a demon, but Joshi sahib was evil. The British were evil. Muya had not been trying to get her arrested; she had been collateral damage when he tried to stop Deepak. She had wronged him, while the ordinary humans she had been too naive to even suspect had engineered her downfall.

Usha looks at me, from over the woman’s shoulder. I can see her spirit is lighter despite her circumstances.

We can be forgiving.

I startle. Of all things, why that?

But Usha only smiles wider. *Choose trust.*



24

CHAIN MAIL

Muya is innocent. I have, following in the footsteps of Usha, horribly mistreated perhaps the only person who has tried to help me from the start.

And if Muya is telling the truth, then his honest advice for me is to give up.

Things are ugly outside the clinic. This Monday marks day thirty-five, even though it's been almost six weeks since Ash Wednesday. Only six days left to survive. There is a veritable sea of protesters across the street, extending in an unbroken chain that's longer than our clinic. They've looped around the boundaries of the property, confidently standing in the street and opening a link to allow cars to pass through before closing it back up. It's illegal, and absolutely nobody gives a damn. In fact, I read the other day that the current administration is actively pardoning the few people who have been convicted of obstructing clinics.

"Human chain is new," JJ calls from behind me. I'm standing on the street corner, staring at this travesty.

"I thought you had work," I say.

"I called out. Today through Friday. I have way too much vacation accrued, and this is important."

"You seem better," I tell her.

"Much," she says. "And I talked to my dad. He's going to send you an email. I am still serious about getting you out of here."

I want to tell her about the success of our fundraising night, but something stays my tongue. Probably embarrassment, since it's nothing like the fundraising I saw at the Art Institute. Besides, this current scene is pretty demoralizing. "Any patients who walk to the clinic won't be able to get through. And even the ones who drive—this is... this is... maybe we should have closed."

"Come on. Let's go get our vests. We do what we can, right?"

"How are you so calm?" I demand.

"You always figure everything out," she says.

Diane waves me inside, and JJ grabs a vest before heading back out. What she's going to do about the literal human chain I'm not sure.

"We heard more about Lauren's case," she whispers to me. "The police say someone here recorded her, that they've been sharing videos of patients on their forums to shame them."

"What the fuck?" I hiss. "Whoever sent the video to her boyfriend is an accessory!"

"Honey, the boyfriend is pleading emotional duress or something. Saying that she murdered his child, so his response was excusable."

"That's... not the law," I say, but I'm only half confident because it's Texas. And Texas certainly won't prosecute the recorder, since that would require caring about the lives of women. "So they're just going to drop it?"

"They're still moving forward with the case, but only for now. Once the whole thing dies down, I'm sure they'll make him a sweetheart deal. We need to warn patients..." She trails off, because we both know if we do, some simply won't come in. And they might be right not to.

"Don't they have any shame?" I mutter. "Surely it's bad for the pro-life brand if they get a woman killed."

"They get women killed every day," Diane says. "That *is* their brand."

"We'll think on it," I tell her. "In the meantime, can you give me the volunteer umbrellas? We'll use those for now. By the way, any ideas on the human chain?"

"I called the police, reported a traffic violation." Diane shrugs. She's usually positive, but her shoulders are slumped and her face is devoid of any attempt at optimism.

“Right, well, when the police show up in five hours, I’ll be sure to let them know what they missed,” I say. It’s a bad joke, but Diane gives me a forced pity snort and hands over the umbrellas. I take them and head back outside, expecting to find the antis encroaching farther onto the street.

Instead, I see a horde of what looks like... desi uncles? They’re arguing very loudly with the protesters and have managed to disrupt the chain. JJ comes up to me, looking confused and flustered.

“They just appeared! I don’t know what to do. I don’t know who they are.”

But I do. I hear a heavily accented “Absolute idiot!” shouted from one corner, followed by an “I am a doctor!” from the street. It sounds like Sanjiv Uncle.

“What’s going on?” JJ asks.

“We just held a fundraiser for the clinic. I guess the people who attended are feeling extra motivated... and I bet my Aai had something to do with it.” I look down to text her.

Did you send the uncles here?

She doesn’t immediately respond, and when I look up, the chain is fully broken.

“What happened?” I ask JJ, who is watching the scene with a mix of awe and fear.

“They rushed it.” I stare at her, sure I’ve misheard. Old Indian men rushing a line of screaming white people? “They just barreled through them. One guy shouted something in a language I couldn’t understand—it was kind of scary.”

“You’re kidding me.” I burst out laughing. The antis are trying to regroup, but as they attempt to link hands and block the road again, a car drives through and they jump out of the way. The person driving it rolls their windows down to wave at the uncles. “Is that Ajoba?” I ask, more to myself than anyone else. We all just call him Grandfather, since he’s been in this area longer than the rest of us have been alive. “Is he legally allowed to drive?”

“Look, there’s a patient!” JJ exclaims. Suddenly the mirth of the last few minutes is gone.

I run toward the woman, holding an umbrella. As I approach her, I push it open, but the woman tries to shove me.

“Get away, creep!” Then she blinks at me and offers a sheepish look. “I thought you were one of them.”

“Thankfully not,” I say. “But they’ve been recording patients, so I wanted to protect your privacy.”

She huddles under the umbrella, and we take slow, careful steps toward the clinic. “I’m here for an abortion. I forgot to take my birth control, and of course the one... okay, two times—”

“You don’t have to explain yourself to me,” I tell her.

“Sorry. I’m a nervous talker.” She rubs her arms, and I feel bad. It’s always hard to judge these situations.

“In that case, tell me about yourself. You from around here?”

She nods. “I’m from the South Side. There are closer clinics, but this one is far enough away that nobody will recognize me. My mama had an abortion, and my sister, but people still judge you.”

“We get people from all over the country. South Side is practically our backyard.”

She laughs. “Not to someone from the South Side.”

“Fair enough,” I say. As we near the door, she looks a lot steadier. “You’re in good hands. It was nice to meet you.”

“Do they train you on how to calm people down?” she asks. “Because you give off the calmest energy. Thanks.”

“I’m going to tell my mom you said that,” I say, and she laughs and enters the clinic. I watch Ajoba reverse down the road.

“Good work!” JJ calls out. “Do you need to go inside? We can probably hold it down.”

JJ’s words dissolve in my ears, because I spy another woman walking toward us.

“Aai?”

She can’t hear me over the protesters. They swarm her immediately, shouting and shoving flyers in her face. Surely even they are smart enough to realize that

she's postmenopausal? But the uncle squad descends upon them, and soon enough Aai is free to make her way to me.

"So it worked?" she asks.

"I can't believe you had a plan for this, too," I say.

She laughs. "I started a WhatsApp forward, telling everyone to come to the clinic at such and such time to make their displeasure heard! Take back their neighborhood! You made quite the impression at the fundraiser, you know. I had so many messages about you, how smart and committed you are. It made me worried about nazr, but don't worry, I dispelled the evil eye from you already."

We look at each other for a moment, and then Aai sighs. "What is the matter with you, Nisha? Why are you being this way?"

"I'm trying to be independent, to stop burdening you with my problems. I know you would do anything for me, but I hate that you're stuck with a depressed girl who never achieved her potential. I know you gave up everything for a kid you didn't even want to have, and I ended up not being worth it at all."

"What the *fuck* are you talking about?" Aai snaps. My brain short-circuits—I've only heard her swear in traffic. "Where did you get that idea?"

I gesture miserably around me. "Come on. I know you wouldn't have chosen to have me if you had any other option. You had to leave everything—"

"What is it about you Americans and inventing stories in your head?" Aai says. "My country wasn't as backward as yours. Women could get abortions in India without any fuss if they wanted to. But I didn't want one. I wanted *you*. This is ridiculous." She pulls some Tupperware out of her purse. "You clearly haven't been eating. Here."

I'm gaping at Aai. This doesn't feel like the right place or time for earth-shattering revelations like this. "Even if it's true that you wanted a child, you must be so disappointed that you got me. I tried everything. And it got me nowhere. What do I do?"

"Be happy?" Aai phrases it like a question, but it's not. It reminds me of Heera. My throat aches.

"That's not going to happen, Aai."

"Why not?"

“Because I’m mediocre and I can’t cope with being mediocre. Because I can’t even protect this one clinic. What’s the point of trying? I’m just wasting resources.”

“Sometimes I regret deciding not to slap you as a child,” Aai says. “I certainly did not raise a quitter. You know, most people don’t change the world, and yet, most people still matter. You’re smart, you’re capable, you’re driven. Your sincere effort is enough.”

“You don’t believe that,” I choke out. “For everything you gave me and all your sacrifices, I haven’t done enough. I haven’t—”

“You do not have to live for me. I have lived for me. I am proud of who you are, so do not talk about my daughter that way.” Her tone is light but her eyes are hard. Aai shoves the Tupperware into my hands. “The only thing you’ve done that disappointed me is running away and not talking to me.”

I throw my arms around her, and she squeezes me tight. After a lifetime together, everything we need to say is conveyed in that hug. *I love you. I’m sorry. I hope you understand.*

—

There are a hundred protesters outside the clinic for the next two days. But my uncles are here, too, and some aunties who heckle the hell out of them, and Aai in the mornings before she goes into work—I suspect it’s primarily so she can drop off a meal for me every day. The protesters *love* to argue, because the moment someone argues, they’re basically saying the antis have a point of view worth engaging with. The aunties, however, have absolutely no desire to engage with their arguments.

“Do your wife and children know you can’t even hold down a job?” one shouts.

“Look at him! You think that man has a wife?” another exclaims. “Does your mother know this is how you spend your days while she breaks her back to support you?”

The anti they’re targeting, a large man with facial hair and a bald eagle tank top, turns red. “I make six figures!” he shouts.

“They’re all just mad at these women for having sex, since they can’t have any.”

“We have plenty of sex!” one of the protesters shouts.

“With our wives!” another adds, trying to cover their bases.

I try not to laugh as I head inside. Or be horrified that the aunties are talking so openly about sex. Nobody is safe now.

There are a lot of protesters, and they’re annoying as all hell, but this extra contingent of volunteers has sufficiently neutralized them, and nothing too bad has happened yet. Still, I feel a tugging sensation right under where my heart is, exactly as I have every time I’ve encountered some type of demonic interference, and right now, it’s insistent. I think of Heera and Tara and Laila. Regardless of whether it’s magic or instinct speaking to me, I’m ready to listen. I open a private browser on my computer, close my eyes, and take a deep breath. My fingers start typing, and I pull up some of the extremist chat boards we follow for security reasons. Our team hasn’t flagged anything specific lately, but I’m looking at them with different eyes. The first two are duds. But while scanning the third, a place for gun nuts and survivalists who want to purge the earth of the spawn of Satan or some such, sparks fire in my brain. It actually physically hurts, so much so that I clutch one hand to the back of my head. This is it.

I read a post from several hours ago, a call to arms against the murderous terrorists running Chicago’s abortion clinics. It says that they must be cleansed in fire and blood. It doesn’t explicitly name our clinic, but I know. *I know*. They’re coming for us, and soon. I screenshot the page and send it to our external security consultants, explaining my concerns and asking if they can send over a team for the next few days or if we should shut the place down.

There’s one other thing I can do while I wait. I can find Muya. I don’t have his number, but I have his magic. I stand and draw up the drips of my magic, then dance a simple tatkar. I think of Muya, of like calling to like. *Find me*, I plead. *Find me*.

My phone rings. Unknown number.

“I’m sorry,” I say before he can get out a single word. “I’m sorry. I was wrong. I have been extremely unappreciative of your assistance.”

“Were you bitten by an intelligence demon?” Muya asks.

“I just finally lifted the veil of ignorance.”

“You sound surprised.”

I laugh, and then remember myself. I contacted him for a reason. “I found a threat to the clinic online. I think they’re coming soon.”

“How?” All mirth is gone from his voice.

“I followed my instincts. Or maybe your instincts.”

Muya swears. “I told you to give in, but you wouldn’t. There’s no way I could convince you to at least stay away?”

“I can’t just protect myself. I can’t let everyone else get hurt. I was hoping you would know something, anything that could help me.”

“I’ve been keeping an eye on that office building since the night you and I went there. The whole building is bathed in magic now. There have been constant meetings over the last few weeks, but I’m not sure why.”

“If you’re sure that’s where they’re meeting, we could try going again tonight.”

“It’s risky,” he says. “We’d have to hide outside. It wouldn’t be safe to just attempt making ourselves invisible.”

“Okay.” My hands are shaking. “I’ll meet you when I’m done with work.”

“I’ll text you the details,” he says, and hangs up.

My laptop pings. The security team has emailed back a long form response that boils down to: This is a generic threat, not worth a response. No need for concern.

I tell Diane and Dr. Levy about the anonymous post anyway. My last bad feeling ended with arson, and even though we don’t put much stock in superstition, they both take it seriously. We go through the patient list and cancel everyone whose appointments aren’t time sensitive, reducing it to surgical abortions and out-of-staters. It’s something, but it doesn’t feel like enough. It never feels like enough. At exactly five o’clock, I race out of the clinic and catch the bus down Touhy to Edison Park. Muya is waiting for me at the bus stop, looking grim.

“I don’t think this will tell us anything we don’t already know,” he says as we walk toward the building. When it comes into view, my mouth goes dry. “We

can still turn back. You could run or beg for mercy and attempt to make a new deal.”

“Thanks, Muya,” I say. “But I can’t do that. I won’t lose the clinic, and I won’t give in.”

“I was afraid you would say that,” he says. “You women always do.” He sounds almost fond.

Muya takes my hand and covers me in a cloak of ignorance. We sneak all the way around the building to a window at the back. Inside, I can hear muffled voices, though I can only make out a phrase or two.

“Final phase.”

“Offer’s on the table.”

“The contractors are ready.”

I feel incredibly stupid for coming all this way. Muya was right, they’re not going to go over the in-depth logistics of a demonic takeover in an office building. These types wouldn’t resort to violence. My phone pings, and I scramble to silence it. It’s an email from JJ’s dad saying that he has lots of friends who run various nonprofits and would be happy to help me find something suitable. It’s sweet, and I find myself smiling at how much JJ loves me even if she’s being a bit cowardly about the whole thing. Muya tugs on my arm, and I realize the meeting has ended. We dash around to the front and take cover behind the bushes. I hope Muya’s power is enough to shield us as we take note of who exits. The door opens, and a few people walk out into the night. I think I might recognize a protester or two, but that’s hardly helpful.

The door opens again.

I wish there was a succinct word to describe the feeling of your world burning down, of your trust shattering into a million pieces, of wanting to let the water pull you under because you’ve been such an idiot.

Exiting the building, chatting lightheartedly with a man I vaguely recognize from a long-ago parents’ weekend at college, is my friend.

It all falls into place. JJ said that she came back home to help with the family business, but she never said what it was. JJ tried to get me a new job, was occasionally hesitant about abortion, and worried about my mentioning the clinic to her family members at the fundraiser. JJ obfuscated her name.

I take a step forward, but Muya grabs a fistful of my jacket, holding me back.

“You know her?” he whispers.

“She’s my friend. She was helping me. She—”

“You can’t do anything right now,” he says. “Stay down. We’re in their territory.”

While we wait until we’re sure everyone is gone, I confirm my suspicions. This time, I scroll to the bottom of the email from JJ’s dad to read his email signature. Harry Perkins *Fleming*. When I Google “Fleming + Midwest Family Institute,” I get thousands of hits, including that quote attributed to Harry Fleming a couple weeks back. I bet their family has shrines to Mitch McConnell and Samuel Alito in their house. I let JJ into the clinic. I gave her complete access. I may have doomed us. And yet, JJ is trying to save me before destroying everything I stand for. Somehow, that makes it worse. What does it mean to be loved by someone like that?

I push the thought away. I have to warn the others. I text Diane, my fingers numb in the cold.

**We need to lock Julie Perkins out of all systems and
put her on a turn-away protocol**

**I have reason to believe she’s affiliated with some
pretty serious anti groups**

Better not to take any chances

Diane’s response is immediate.

:(

They truly have no shame!!!

Sorry baby

I’ll tell her not to come tomorrow until we work it out

My fingers hover over the keys as I stare at JJ’s contact. Every interaction we’ve had over the last six weeks flashes before my eyes. She was there the day of

the fire. Chances are she set it. A swell of nausea hits me. But at least she doesn't know that I know.

**Hey! No need for you to come in tomorrow—another
volunteer wants to swap shifts.**

Let's get an afternoon coffee, though?

By the time Muya has walked me to my apartment door, I feel like I'm splitting apart. Even with the benefit of the past, I have followed Usha's path exactly. I have become the architect of my own destruction. My feet stamp on the floor without conscious thought, and I pull out my phone and set my dance playlist to shuffle. It spits out "Nagada Sang Dhol," a decade-old, fast-paced garba song. My body is already moving, clapping, and spinning, my hair flying free. And I see.



CHANDINI

Something, perhaps the depths of my anguish, pushes the vision to fragment into pieces, flying by too fast to be helpful.

I watch Chandini move into her own house, never marrying or having children of her own. She is happy to remain an unnerving, scandalous woman, and open her back door in the middle of the night for Muya, gathering him into her arms and asking whose ignorance he fed on as he laughs.

I see Chandini treating the patients who come seeking her healing and wisdom. She listens to each of them, sorting through Vedic wisdom and her own learnings, lifting the veil of ignorance from her own eyes when needed. She tries her best to leave each woman better than she found her, craving that ache in her arms at the end of a long day of work.

I witness Chandini walking down the street, watching tendrils of magic dancing around like motes of light. They burst forth from the earth, transfer from creature to human, and arc across the sky. The whole world is filled with power, each breath she takes is filled with magic, and she marvels that she has never known before, never seen life as it truly is.

I observe Chandini bending the magic around her to reshape the world into one a little safer for her patients, her family, the weak. I grasp for something, some wisdom, and fall more deeply into her story.

Chandini learned in time how to nudge her reality this way and that, and under her shelter, people survived and flourished. Their traditions lived on. She wondered if one day her people would be chieftains of a great city, warriors who could stand against invaders, mothers who would save a burgeoning new empire,

or women whose sacrifices would change the lives of thousands more. Perhaps not. Who could know the future?

All she knew was the feeling of gathering her sister's daughters in her arms, kissing their round cheeks, and loving them so intensely she could hardly contain herself; sitting at her parents' bedsides when their time came and they passed away peacefully and without pain; watching as a new generation grew, their ideas reshaping the world, ever-changing.

She had a lifetime of happiness to cherish. Holding Muya's hands in hers. Pressing Muya's lips to hers. Lying next to him and staring up at the sky. Splashing in the river and shrieking together like children. Listening as he described how he was still learning his place in the world, how Chandini had given him the chance to do that.

And she grew old, without sadness or regret. Despite the piece of him that Muya had once given her, she was just a woman. A human woman. She would not live forever, and even though she met this fate without sorrow, she was still afraid. Not for herself, but for the future.

"Please," she begged Muya at the end. "Will you watch over them? This town, my sister's daughters, and all the women who come after me who need the help you once gave me?"

His fingers gripped hers so tightly she worried that they might break. "They will not be you," he whispered, tearful. She could sense the unspoken wish, for her to stay.

"I am not asking you to love them, only to keep them safe, when you can. Please."

"I promise," he said. "Whatever you want, I will give. I always have."

She laughed, and at last, her soul could rest. At last, she was ready to go. She closed her eyes, sighed, and then it was over. Some part of her lingers just long enough to impart her final wisdom.

Make your own choices, she says. You know yourself.

And for the first time, I respond. I know. I don't need the past to tell me that.



25

CHOICE

I'm woken up by a phone call from Shreya. We've been texting on and off, but I haven't updated her on what I just learned.

"Oh, sorry! I didn't realize the time. Never went to sleep!" She sounds way too awake for someone who has just pulled an all-nighter. "I haven't slept in days. The whole thing is terrifying, to be honest."

"I'm sorry," I offer. "It's been—"

"Sorry?" Shreya breaks in. "The fuck are you sorry for?"

"It's my fault you got dragged into this mess."

"I don't know whether to reassure you or to be astounded at your arrogance."

"My arrogance?"

"You believe that *you* have control over demons and what they do? That you're responsible for stopping them? Now, I won't lie and say this hasn't shaken me," she continues, "but mostly I'm just amazed that you've survived on your own for what? Over a month?"

"It's not done yet," I say.

"Yes, about that. I've been reading about reports of demon magic and gifted powers."

I'm a lot more awake now. I reach for my magic, but it's still too weak to be of much use. "Any word on a turbocharger?"

“I found an ancient Hindu text—long believed to be apocrypha written by a madwoman—that describes ‘energies gifted from the gods.’ She says that as long as a kernel of power remains in you, your own spirit will naturally replenish and refill it, the way trees lose their leaves and grow them again. The only way to lose the power is to use it all up at once, completely.” Shreya’s voice kicks up a notch in excitement. “She mentions that it is possible to experience something roughly translated as a ‘surge’ either through a moment of great personal... ‘triumph’? Or through the demon giving you a bit more power.”

I fall back against my pillows. “Fuck. That’s not going to help me.”

“The way I see it, you’ve been experiencing small moments of triumph every day. Maybe you need to try using one to supercharge your power. I don’t know how it works, but quite frankly, neither do you, so why not try?”

I want to scream at the absurdity of it all, but instead I say, “Thanks. It’s better to have some hope than none at all.”

I want to drown in my own fear, in the desire to do nothing. But instead, I force myself to roll out of bed. My feet hit the ground, and I move forward.

—

The protesters are so loud, I feel myself pushed back a pace when I round the corner. They’re absolutely everywhere. There are probably ten protesters for every patient that we’re going to see today. But a quick scan of the crowd reveals that many of them are schoolchildren, probably here on a private-school field trip. I almost feel a little bad for the underpaid women who are supposed to be managing a hundred children protesting a topic they know nothing about. Right next to them is a guy wearing a shirt proclaiming “I Concealed Carry” and holding a sign plastered in 3-D resin-covered fake bloody tissues that reads “Don’t Murder Babies.” Steve looks pretty weirded out by it, too.

Our efforts yesterday have limited today’s load to the first half of the day, with most patients arriving first thing in the morning to get dilated. The mad dash in the morning isn’t ideal, but once everyone is in their procedure or recovery room, I’ll basically be in the clear. I’m counting down the hours in my head.

Then I see JJ standing in the lot, and my brain grinds to a halt. She's not wearing a vest, so I don't think she's gone inside.

I force a smile on my face. "Hey, did you get my text? We're already covered for today."

"Doesn't look like anybody else is here," she says, gesturing around. She looks nervous. "We've already had three patients arrive."

"Good work, but JJ, really..." I take a deep breath and know I can't maintain the facade. "I know. I know what you've been doing. So just... please go. Or—"

JJ's face changes. Hardens, solidifies. "You can't make me," she says. "My dad is friends with the police."

"Why are you doing this?" I demand. "In college, you weren't like this."

"We all regret who we were in college," she snaps. "This place is wrong. I'm just doing my part."

"You don't even sound like you believe it," I say. "What, did your family offer you early access to your inheritance or a path to the United States Senate or something if you helped them get rid of us?"

I can see on her face that I'm right, and I scoff. "That's pathetic, JJ, really. You're just a sellout who can't hack it alone, huh?"

"Better that than a has-been," she snaps. "Stuck working at some third-rate murder clinic!"

There's fire in me, close to the surface, and it feels good. I should be sad about losing JJ, but right now all I feel is strength coursing through me. "Your family might be able to give endless cash to Fox News and OANN and scammy crisis pregnancy centers and all those pastors who preach hate, but for all your power, we've survived. Daddy's money can't even beat one measly clinic. People will keep getting abortions. Aren't you tired of being such a loser?"

"You people are the losers, dragging down the rest of us. Bribing people to support you, stacking the odds, but we're evening the playing field—"

"What, you mean the demon?"

Shock flares across her face, but she masters it quickly. "Look at you! Think you know it all, don't you?"

I grab her wrist. "JJ, what do you have planned? If you care about life, then stop this madness."

She tries to tug out of my grasp, but I hold fast. “Don’t talk to me about caring for life. I’m doing what I have to do. I offered you so many outs. I’ve been trying to save you, you pathetic idiot! We literally asked that demon to spare you, even after you really pissed him off, and—”

She stops herself, as though remembering we are not friends anymore and she shouldn’t be revealing her dastardly plans to me. I consider trying to force the information out of her. The magic flows sluggishly under my skin, but I am willing to give it a try, until I look into her eyes. Though I hate that she still has any power over me, I can’t forget that she showed me a bit of mercy. I release her.

“Okay, then!” I say with forced cheer, letting a smile stretch across my lips. “Have a great day!”

As expected, she is too bewildered to respond, and I use that beat to slip away, just as the uncle and aunty squad arrives. They seem baffled about what to do in the face of children. I watch an Uber approach the clinic, then stop when the driver sees the protesters. After a brief pause, a person emerges, red-faced. This happens sometimes. We recommend that patients don’t take Ubers or Lyfts because drivers sometimes refuse drop-offs, but people don’t have many options. I head toward the patient and escort them inside.

“Diane, JJ is on the property and she won’t leave. I’m going to go back out there to keep an eye on her, but can you watch her on the camera?”

“Of course,” Diane says. “But, honey, she’s not there anymore.”

“What?” Fuck. “Okay, I have to go back—”

There’s a popping noise, followed by a scream. Before my brain can even comprehend what I’ve heard, my body is in motion. I lock the door and push the metal bar over the entrance. Lockdown protocol. Diane is on her feet, staring at the monitor. She grabs her phone, already dialing.

“There’s been a shooting at Rogers Park Health Center. The clinic is going into lockdown.”

The patients waiting around us rush toward the door, but I hold up my arms to block them.

“In here is the safest place to be. Our doors lock from the inside, and our windows are bulletproof. Please, come with me to the back.”

Was this JJ's plan? Was she carrying a gun just now? The aunties, the children—no. I can't think about it, not when I need to follow procedure. Everyone follows me into the health wing, and I make sure to collect any ambulatory patients along the way. I glimpse Aaron and Dr. Levy, but I have to assume they're obeying their own protocols. Instead, I make a beeline for the recovery wing and find Dan and Nina, the nurses who basically run this part of the clinic, conferring with our temporary PA.

"The back door is already locked," Nina says. "We'll take care of things over here. Diane shouldn't have to wait for the police alone."

"Be right back," I tell her.

Dr. Levy and Aaron both emerge into the hallway as I approach, looking worried. Aaron is rubbing his nose with his wrist, a sure sign he's fighting some strong emotion and trying to keep calm.

"Nisha," Dr. Levy says, "I think we may need an ambulance for one of the patients."

"What?" In all my time working here, I can only remember one other time we've needed an ambulance. "Now?"

"I'm going to have Aaron call it in, but I wanted to make sure emergency vehicles can safely approach. Why are we in lockdown? If it's a drill—"

"Shots fired," I tell her. "The police are on their way, probably ambulances, too. That said..." I think the police will come when called for reported gunshots, but they could still slow-walk it.

The doors to the lobby swing open. "It's chaos outside," Diane says. I realize she's been crying, although she appears entirely calm. "Hard to tell who was hit. It looks like someone threw a smoke bomb, and people are banging on the doors, trying to get in. There may have been a stampede."

A single, large tremor goes through Dr. Levy's body. Aaron is frozen.

"Okay, we have an ectopic pregnancy back there who is showing signs of rupture, but maybe—"

An ear-piercing scream reverberates from the recovery room, and more follow as the whole building shakes. I'm paralyzed by fear, but Dr. Levy takes off. Running *toward* the sound. And I follow, because I'm not letting her go alone. There's smoke everywhere, people sobbing, at least one form on the floor.

Oh gods. The back door to the clinic is somehow wide open, sunlight streaming in. I blink. A man holding a gun stands in the middle of the doorway.

“I only want to stop the killing,” he says. His voice is low and rough. “If the doctors come forward and renounce their murderous ways, I’ll be happy to leave.”

Dr. Levy mutters something that sounds like a prayer. Someone tries to crawl toward the open door, and the man shoots in their direction. It’s like I’ve left my body and am watching it all happen from a removed vantage point, like I’m observing another woman’s life.

“Nobody?” he asks. He aims at a patient. “It’s not a sin to kill someone who would kill their child, to prevent them from killing again.”

Someone steps in front of the gun. It’s... Steve? “Don’t do this,” he says. “Don’t be as bad as them.”

“You little—you followed me?” the man demands. “Get out of the way or I’ll shoot.”

“Then shoot me,” Steve says calmly. The man’s hand shakes, then steadies.

“It’s me!” Dr. Levy steps forward. I grab for her, but she’s already gone. “I’m the doctor here. Please, let’s go outside and talk. These people have done nothing—”

“Haven’t they? One of your nurses tried to rush me. Everyone here is part of your murder cult.”

I realize there’s someone lying at his feet. Dan. I want to scream. My throat is burning. The room is boiling. Where is all the smoke coming from?

“More killing won’t help,” Dr. Levy says. She is so very calm. “Let’s go outside.” The man lowers his gun slightly, and she continues, “I’ll go first. I promise I’ll come with you.”

It all happens too quickly. Dr. Levy takes a step forward. A rush of flames passes across the doorway, and Dr. Levy shouts, throwing up her arms. At the sudden movement, the man lifts his gun and shoots.

Dr. Levy crumples.

With a bellow, Aaron charges the man. The man shoots again, but Aaron takes him down. The man’s head hits the floor with a crack. Aaron rolls off him. It looks like Steve has dropped down to help Dr. Levy, applying pressure to her

wound. The wall is on fire, the door impassable. People are moving, clamoring around me. And then there's a moment of tense silence as the patients and staff seem to realize they're all going to die. I look at Aaron through the haze, hunched over Dr. Levy's body with Steve. They're no longer trying to administer medical care. Oh gods. Dr. Levy.

A figure steps through the fire and moves inexorably toward me: Asmodeus, serene and pleased. He wears another face I've never seen before, but I recognize his power, flaring like a demented halo.

I lock eyes with him. It is time to end this. "Come to gloat?"

"I'm here for you, for your power. I will stop this fire if you give it up to me. I am offering you one last chance to end this."

"To end the situation you created?" I try to fight back the sob in my voice. For all my bravado, I know we're fucked.

"I can hardly take credit for all this." He gestures around him. "That stupid, feckless girl and her family summoned me, and I agreed to help them when I learned there was a far better prize on offer than any they could provide: your power. But truthfully, I haven't needed to do much. You humans are quite capable of violence and destruction all on your own. I just activated a few latent impulses, removed some obstacles."

Dan shifts on the ground, squirming in pain. A patient next to him is bleeding out. It's too much to think about. My mind wants to shut down, wants to believe that I'm a coward, that I'm not meant for this.

And still, I step forward. I know better.

"Then what good are you? You've sent a hundred people and the magic of hell to beat me and still haven't gotten what you wanted," I say, filling with strength at my own words—I remember Shreya's advice that this feeling could be a source of power. Sure enough, there's magic tingling underneath my skin. I tug on it, urging it forth. When the surge roils through me, I stagger, unprepared for the intensity. "If humans can do all this by themselves, then we are far more powerful than you."

Another step forward. I'm going to use my magic to erase his memories, permanently. And maybe some of us will live long enough to be rescued by the fire department. I close my eyes, steel myself, and reach for the power.

“You think your paltry little trick will work? You already failed once. You can still choose differently. Choose to survive, with my aid.”

And then, I hear music. It’s my dance music—there must be a Bluetooth speaker back here that auto-connected. More importantly, it’s “Mahishasura Mardini,” a dedication to Durga, slayer of the demon Mahishasura. My body responds to it, to the feeling of inhabiting a goddess. The only life I can choose is my own. I will never give in. I never would have.

I know who I am.

I think of Chandini, how perception made reality.

I close my eyes, draw on my power, and let it pool out of me. This isn’t normal, not how I’ve seen it used by Muya or those who came before me. I feel the earth sing. It is ready to receive this magic, and with it, the demon in front of me.

“No!” Asmodeus shouts as he reaches for me.

I don’t care. I won’t stop. He can kill me, but I will see this through. I have chosen.

“Kaitabha banjini, rasa rathe.” *You who slays the demon, and indulges the dance of war.* Someone is singing along—there must be a Hindu patient here who knows these popular verses. I draw strength from her, from all the patients around me. From Chandini, Tara, Laila, Heera, Usha. I have to succeed, I have to unmake this tragedy, for all of us.

I give and I give and I give, even as Asmodeus tries to stop me, his power clawing at my skin. Even as I feel my mind tearing apart. It only strengthens my will to keep going. Humans hold the power—and he’s afraid of me. The earth tugs on my magic. This fire isn’t real. This smoke isn’t real. It is not of the earth. I unmake it. I unmake it.

And as I exhale, the flames die.

“Durdhara nirjara shaktibhrite.” *You who eliminate evil with infinite strength.*

The demon’s hold on me wavers, but I’m still giving. My vision swims. There are so many people here, so many hurt. The flames erupt once more. It’s not enough. There is so much suffering and I can’t undo it all, even now, connected to the vastness of the earth. I’m at the end of my power.

“Let me help,” Muya says. Somehow, I’m not surprised he’s found his way to me now, in my moment of need. His arms are wrapped around Asmodeus’s struggling body. “Let me.”

Asmodeus growls. “Why betray your own kind? You could have all the power in the world if you joined us.”

“You think I would join forces with an *Anglo?*” Muya asks, filled with contempt. “She is far more my kind than you.”

He came for me, just as he once came for Chandini. Muya is not just ignorance, but loyalty incarnate. He, like any living thing, contains multitudes.

I reach forward, and Muya’s hand grabs my own.

“Jaya jaya he mahishasura mardini!” *Victory to you, slayer of the demon Mahishasura!*

I’m not underwater. I’m standing firm on dry land. I squeeze Muya’s hand, and the strange magic left within him becomes my own. It is enough. We are enough.

I understand what Chandini was trying to teach me. Knowledge and thought is the world entire; and what is ignorance but one side of that selfsame coin?

I unmake wounds and collapsing buildings. I unmake fire.

I unmake demons.

The flames die. My sight is blurry, but I think I see Dan sitting up. Diane stumbles in, supporting the woman with the ectopic. Aaron rises to his feet and checks on the patient slumped against the wall. He helps her stand. I’m watching it all, on my knees, weeping.

The police barge through the door, shouting for everyone to put their hands up. When I slip into darkness, I’m smiling.



26

DAY ONE

Dr. Levy's funeral is the day before Easter. Day forty. We all go, and I recognize some of our patients in attendance as well. The place is crowded, but we're protected by private security hired by the clinic's donors. The clinic itself is closed for the foreseeable future, but we've already raised enough money to reopen, in time. A lot of the money is going to Dr. Levy's family.

I hang in the back. I know it's not my fault that she's dead, that the shooting would have happened without the magic or the demons. But her family is now in mourning because Dr. Levy tried to save her patients, tried to save me. And, as I had always feared, I couldn't save her back.

Her family couldn't bury her until they got permission, which I know they were upset about—they wanted to do it within the twenty-four hours prescribed by the Torah, but the feds got involved. Once they finally paid attention to us, they were able to piece together the conspiracy in hours. People volunteered to be martyrs and targeted us because we're a smaller operation. There was no other reason, just dumb luck and hatred. And then, of course, the feds dropped the case because they didn't care about anything beyond avoiding the bad press of not investigating at all. JJ certainly won't face any consequences, despite her role in everything. Her daddy knows some prosecutors and judges. She's on house arrest awaiting potential state charges, but I've heard she's claiming that I forced her to get involved in the clinic, that we set her up to take the fall for the

conspiracy. She'll probably be a senator one day. It's hard to stomach that it was someone I trusted who did this. It's hard, too, to know that she tried to save me. But I'll move on.

One of the schoolchildren was shot during the stampede. Their parents have been saying god healed their child, a miracle they earned because their side was so righteous. The other protesters who got hurt have been saying the same. It was me. It wasn't a conscious choice, but given one, I would have unmade their wounds again. Everyone in the clinic who saw what happened kept their mouth shut. Steve even gave a vaguely positive statement about us to the police and the press, before saying that he would be outside Planned Parenthood next Saturday.

The part of Muya's magic I burned through appears to be gone for good. It's a relief for me not to shoulder that weight anymore, but Muya is understandably taking it much harder—a piece of him will never return. It's not even been a week, though. He'll survive. Yesterday I showed him a documentary about the Indian independence movement and he cried a little bit. Weirdly, I think we're going to be friends. And one day, knowing him, he will find another woman to gift even his diminished power to.

I don't know how I'll feel a week from now, but the fog in my mind has cleared. I'm going to go back to work as soon as I can. I'm going to write applications for law school. I'm going to stick around Chicago. I'm going to make these assholes pay. For Dr. Levy. For Aai. For Shreya and the desi community who showed up for me and even for Aaron. For myself.

I haven't yet done enough to be satisfied with my life, but I have decades ahead of me. I remember Dr. Levy telling me that she asked herself every day if she was enough. I hope she knew she was, that her life meant a whole hell of a lot even if she couldn't accomplish every single goal she hoped to. She was important. She changed the world, even if most people will never know her name. At her funeral, they repeat the saying she once recited to me, and I learn it's from Jewish scripture. *Whoever saves a life has saved the whole world.* It gives me peace to know that Dr. Levy found meaning in it. I find meaning in it, too.

Of course, there are protesters outside Dr. Levy's funeral, because they're just that pro-life. I think some of them are a bit disappointed that the rest of us didn't die, too. But the clinic staff stood outside, blocking the protesters and

ushering the mourners inside, just like always. Dr. Levy loved her work and died the way she lived—saving lives. The only way to honor that is to continue on.

Tomorrow, I'll go to the lake. Even though it's still freezing, I'll strip down and let the wind whip around me. I'll hesitate for a moment, then take the plunge.

I might panic and forget what to do. I'll probably think about sinking.

But then, I'll kick my legs. I'll reach up. I'll surface and see the shore. I'll take a deep breath, and the cold air will invigorate me.

I will remember how to swim.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

In the summer of 2016, I met a woman who had, as a college student, helped start the Jane Collective. The Jane Collective began providing abortions for women in Chicago in 1969, when abortion was still illegal. I was the age she had been when she helped found Jane, and she warned me that we were not far off from a time when something like Jane would be needed again. I did not believe her then, but our conversation has since served as a lesson to heed the wisdom of the generations who came before us.

I was always abstractly interested in the fight for abortion access, but after graduating from college, I decided to start escorting at the Aurora branch of Planned Parenthood of Illinois. Only then did I realize how committed the anti-choice movement was to punishing anyone who doesn't agree with them. The abuse, insults, lies, and occasional physical assault were stunning, without even considering the ways in which anti-choice operatives tried to terrorize staff. Even after writing a whole novel about these experiences, I still didn't have the space to include everything. My first legal internship was with the ACLU Reproductive Freedom Project, during which time I started to see the true, insidious rot of the anti-choice project. And then Justice Ginsburg died. *Roe* was only a matter of time. The anti-choice movement had stacked the deck, the only way they could win in a majority pro-choice country. For two years, I had a front row seat to watch some of the smartest, strongest people I knew fight ceaselessly against an outcome they all knew to be preordained.

When we lost, I knew I had to write about it. Not just about the depravity of a movement that condemns children to bear children, that is content to let women die preventable deaths in the name of life, that must constantly overturn the democratic will of the people by legislative trickery, but about the toll it takes to push back. I am writing this note in late spring of 2025, when the war on reproductive rights is so relentless that I fear elements of this story may be

outdated by the time of publication. But I know *We Dance Upon Demons* will stay relevant in at least one way: We will still be fighting. This project is about history and dance and demons, but it is also a tribute to all those who toil for our rights. If you, reading this, have received abortion and miscarriage care, or contraceptive care, or fertility care, if you were able to choose when and how to have children or become sexually active, know this—someone fought for you. And people are still fighting to hold on to every inch of ground gained.

My work was greatly aided by scholarship and investigative reporting on the reproductive rights movement. In the areas of history and scholarship, I consulted Melissa Murray, Katherine Shaw, and Reva Siegel's work in general and *Reproductive Rights and Justice Stories* in particular, Michele Goodwin's *Policing the Womb*, Laura Kaplan's *The Story of Jane*, Mary Ziegler's *Roe*, Jennifer Wright's *Madame Restell*, and Diana Greene Foster's *The Turnaway Study*. I am deeply indebted to memoirs written by those fighting to provide reproductive care, including Dr. Meera Shah's *You're the Only One I've Told*, Dr. Willie Parker's *Life's Work*, Dr. Susan Wicklund's *This Common Secret*, Dr. Curtis Boyd and Dr. Glenna Halvorson-Boyd's *We Choose To*, and Hannah Matthews's *You or Someone You Love*. Works in the philosophy, activism, and policy space are too numerous to name, but I found particularly helpful Judith Jarvis Thomson's *A Defense of Abortion*, Loretta J. Ross and Rickie Solinger's *Reproductive Justice: An Introduction*, Robin Marty's *New Handbook for a Post-Roe America*, Ann Furedi's *The Moral Case for Abortion*, Lauren Rankin's *Bodies on the Line*, and Rebecca Little and Colleen Long's *I'm Sorry for My Loss*. The Christian nationalist project to reshape America forms the backdrop of this work, and I am indebted to Katherine Stewart's *The Power Worshipers*, Timothy Egan's *A Fever in the Heartland*, Tim Alberta's *The Kingdom, the Power, and the Glory*, Talia Lavin's *Wild Faith*, and Mary Ziegler's *Dollars for Life* for illuminating these dark corners. Finally, in order to understand the anti-choice camp on its own terms, I reviewed Francis J. Beckwith's *Defending Life*, Randy Alcorn's *Why Pro-Life?*, and Lila Rose's *Fighting for Life*.

There is always a way to fight back. If you have money to donate, I recommend giving to your local abortion clinic or travel fund. Some excellent national organizations that could also use your support include the National

Women's Law Center, Pregnancy Justice, Planned Parenthood, and the Abortion Care Network. But donation, while helpful, is not enough; change comes from community action. If you care about reproductive justice, volunteer at your local clinic. Escort patients. Staff a reproductive care hotline. Organize transport or host individuals who need to cross state lines for care. Attend government meetings and advocate for safety and access. Be vocal.

I leave you with this quote from Margaret Mead, which I have clung to for nearly a decade and may well be this novel's thesis statement: "Never doubt that a small group of thoughtful, committed citizens can change the world; indeed, it is the only thing that ever has."

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Vaishnavi Patel is the *New York Times* and internationally bestselling author of *Kaikeyi*, *Goddess of the River*, and *Ten Incarnations of Rebellion*. She is a lawyer specializing in civil rights litigation, including issues of gender and racial justice. *We Dance Upon Demons* is her fourth novel.

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